

Ordinary Holiness

Finding God in the Life You Actually Have

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LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

The world is charged with the grandeur of God.

— Gerard Manley Hopkins, 1877

Introduction: The God I Kept Missing

I found God in a jail cell, which is exactly the kind of story I used to want. It has drama. It has a before and an after with a clean line drawn between them. It has a grown man who was an atheist on a Tuesday and a believer by the weekend, and it makes for a testimony that holds a room. I told it that way for years. I am not ashamed of it. It happened, and it was real, and God met me in a place I had no business expecting him. But I want to tell you what I learned in the twenty years after that story ended, because that is the part nobody asks about, and it is the part that saved my faith.

The dramatic conversion was easy. What came after was the hard thing. I walked out of that season expecting the rest of my life to feel like the moment I met God. I expected the mountaintop to be a place you could move to and live. And so for a long stretch of years I chased the feeling. I chased the conference high and the worship set that broke me open and the answered prayer that arrived like a lightning strike. I read my Bible looking for the burning bush. I prayed the way a man plays a slot machine, waiting for the bells and the falling coins. And when the ordinary days came, as ordinary days always do, one after the other after the other, I read them as failure. I thought God had gone quiet. I thought I had lost something. I did not understand that the ordinary day was not the absence of God. It was the address where he actually lived.

I am a pastor now, which means I have spent fifteen years

watching people make the same mistake I made, and I have watched myself keep making it long after I should have known better. I stand in the pulpit and I say beautiful things about the presence of God, and then I go home and I cannot find him in a sink full of dishes. I have five sons. I have a wife named Susanna who has watched me look for God in the dramatic and miss him in the dishes for the better part of two decades. There is a particular look she gives me, and it means: he was right here, and you were somewhere else. She is usually right. I keep scanning the horizon for the spectacular arrival of God and I keep tripping over him in the hallway. This is not a book I am writing from above the problem. It is a book I am writing from inside it.

Here is what I have come to believe, and I believe it with the whole weight of a man who resisted it as long as he could. We have been taught, by our culture and often by our churches, to look for God in the exceptional. In the mountaintop. In the miracle, the movement, the ministry with our name on it, the moment that feels different from all the other moments. We have built an entire spiritual imagination around the idea that God shows up when life stops being ordinary. And so we treat the ordinary as the waiting room. We treat Monday as the thing to get through until something real happens. We treat the commute and the meeting and the diaper and the marriage on a Tuesday as the static between the songs. And in doing so we miss him, because the ordinary is not the waiting room. It is the sanctuary. It is where he mostly comes.

Consider the arithmetic of the life of Jesus, which is the arithmetic I keep coming back to. He lived for something like thirty-three years. We have detailed accounts of maybe three of them. The other thirty are almost entirely hidden, and what little we know of them is stunningly ordinary. He grew. He learned a

trade. He worked with his hands in a shop in a town so unremarkable that a man once asked whether anything good could come out of it. For thirty years the Son of God swept sawdust off a floor. Thirty years. If the ordinary life were beneath God, if it were merely the thing to escape, then God himself made an incomprehensible mistake, spending nine tenths of his earthly existence in the very place we are all so desperate to get out of. He did not make a mistake. He was telling us something. He was telling us where to look.

I want to say a hard thing about the church, and I say it as a man standing inside it, not throwing rocks from the parking lot. We have often made the problem worse. We have built a spirituality of the event. We have taught people that the real Christian life happens at the retreat, at the altar, at the summer camp, at the conference with the good lighting, and then we send them home to Tuesday with no theology for it. We hand them a mountaintop and no map for the valley, which is where they will spend ninety-five percent of their lives. And then we wonder why they burn out, why they drift, why the faith that felt so alive under the stage lights cannot survive the fluorescent hum of an ordinary week. We did this. I did this. I preached the mountaintop for years and gave people nothing for the plain.

So this is a book about the plain. It is a theology of the ordinary, if that phrase can hold. It is about work as worship and not as the distraction from worship. It is about the body and sleep and food and the rhythms God built into us on purpose. It is about the table and the shared meal, about the dishes and the laundry, about the marriage that is mostly Tuesdays, about parenting as a slow formation in the mundane, about the neighbor you did not choose. It is about the long faithfulness that no one applauds and no one photographs. Eugene Peterson, borrowing a phrase from

Nietzsche of all people, called the Christian life a long obedience in the same direction, and I have never found a better description of the thing. Not a series of spectacular sprints. A long obedience in the same direction. A walk.

I am going to lean on some witnesses in these pages, and I want you to meet them now. Brother Lawrence, a seventeenth-century monk who found God among the pots and pans of a monastery kitchen and left us a small book about it that has outlived nearly everything published in his century. Gerard Manley Hopkins, the poet whose line sits at the front of this book, who saw the grandeur of God flaming out of shook foil and gathering to a greatness in the most ordinary things. Wendell Berry, who has spent a lifetime insisting that the sacred is located, that it has an address, that it is found in a particular field and a particular marriage and a particular town. Kathleen Norris, who wrote about laundry and prayer in the same breath and was not being cute about it. James K. A. Smith, who has argued that we are formed less by what we believe than by what we repeatedly do, that our loves are shaped by our liturgies, and that this is true whether we notice it or not. These are my company for this book. They saw what I keep failing to see.

I will make you one promise, and it is the only one I can keep. This book will not hand you a mountaintop. It will not tell you how to feel God the way you felt him at the retreat. It will do something harder and, I think, better. It will try to teach you to find him where you already are, in the life you actually have and not the more spiritual one you keep thinking you are supposed to be living. Because you are not going to get a different life. You are going to get this one. The dishes will be there tomorrow. The commute will be there Monday. The people in your house will need you in a hundred unremarkable ways before you go to bed

tonight. The question is not whether you can escape the ordinary into something holier. The question is whether you can learn to see that the ordinary was holy the whole time, and that the God you kept missing was never far off. He was right here. You were somewhere else. Let us go and find him where he actually is.

Chapter One: The Mountaintop Addiction

We are a people trained to wait for the exceptional, and so we sleep through the arrival of God.

There is a mountain in the Gospels, and three of the disciples got to go up it. Peter, James, and John climbed with Jesus and watched him change in front of them, his face and his clothing lit from the inside with a light that did not come from the sun. Moses appeared, and Elijah, the two great figures of the law and the prophets, standing there in conversation with him. It was the single most spectacular thing any of them would ever see. And Peter, being Peter, being all of us, immediately wanted to build something and stay. Let us put up three shelters, he said, one for you and one for Moses and one for Elijah. Let us make this permanent. Let us live here on the mountain in the light. He did not know what he was saying, the text tells us, which is a gracious way of putting it. He wanted to move to the mountaintop and take up residence. And within a few hours they were all back down in the valley, where a desperate father was waiting with a sick boy and a crowd was arguing and the ordinary broken world was grinding on exactly as they had left it.

I understand Peter completely, because I am Peter. When something transcendent happens, when God feels close and real and undeniable, the instinct is to build a shelter and stay. To make it permanent. To live there. And the deep spiritual disappointment of the Christian life, the one nobody warns you

about, is that you cannot. You always come back down. The retreat ends. The feeling fades. The Monday comes. And if you have built your faith on the mountaintop, if you have taught yourself that the mountaintop is where God is, then coming down feels like losing him. So you start to chase the next mountain. You become an addict of the exceptional. And an addict of the exceptional is, by definition, a person who cannot bear the ordinary, which is a terrible thing to be, because the ordinary is where you live.

I want to name this precisely, because I think it is one of the great unexamined sicknesses of the modern Christian, and I have had it for most of my life. We have confused the presence of God with the feeling of the presence of God. These are not the same thing. The feeling comes and goes with a thousand variables that have nothing to do with God, with your sleep and your blood sugar and the music and the lighting and whether you had a fight in the car on the way. But the presence does not come and go. The presence is constant. The God who was overwhelmingly real on the mountaintop is exactly as present in the valley, in the kitchen, in the traffic, in the ordinary Tuesday. He has not moved. Your feelings have moved. And when we build a spirituality that depends on the feeling, we build a spirituality that will collapse the moment ordinary life resumes, which will be by Monday at the latest.

The culture we live in is not going to help you with this, and I want to be honest about the depth of the problem, because it is downstream of everything. We are formed, all of us, by a machine that runs on the exceptional. The whole economy of the screen in your pocket is built to make the ordinary unbearable. Every feed you scroll is a highlight reel of other people's mountaintops, their weddings and their vacations and their

achievements and their perfect meals, curated to make your own ordinary Tuesday feel like a failure by comparison. The technology theorists have a phrase for what this does to us, and it is bleak enough to be true: it manufactures a permanent low-grade dissatisfaction with the actual conditions of your actual life. You have been trained, hour by hour, scroll by scroll, to believe that the real life is elsewhere, that it is more exciting, that it is happening to someone else. This is a lie, and it is a lie with a business model.

And the church, God help us, has too often baptized the same machine. We have Christian versions of the highlight reel. We have the conference speakers with their extraordinary stories, the testimonies of dramatic deliverance, the ministries that grew from nothing to thousands, and we hold these up as the picture of what a real spiritual life looks like. There is nothing wrong with any of it in itself. God does dramatic things and we should tell about them. But when the dramatic becomes the standard, when the exceptional becomes the expectation, we do violence to the ninety-five percent of the people in the room whose lives are and will remain gloriously, stubbornly ordinary. We tell the faithful mother of three that her life is a waiting room until God does something real. We tell the man who has worked the same honest job for thirty years that he is missing out on the move of God happening somewhere with better lighting. We did this. I did this. I gave people a hunger for the exceptional and no theology for the plain, and then I watched the plain crush them.

Here is what the addiction to the exceptional actually costs you, and I have paid this cost, so I am not speculating. It costs you the present. It costs you the only moment you will ever actually be given, which is this one, the ordinary one, the one you are in right now. Because if God is only in the exceptional, then the

ordinary present is empty, and you will spend it the way an addict spends the time between hits, which is to say restlessly, distractedly, waiting for the real thing to start. I have missed years of my sons' childhoods this way. Not physically absent. I was in the room. But I was scanning for the significant moment, the teachable moment, the spiritual breakthrough, and while I was scanning for the exceptional the ordinary childhood was happening right in front of me and I was not in it. The bedtime I hurried through because it was not significant was the significant thing. I could not see it because I was looking for a mountain.

Brother Lawrence, the seventeenth-century monk I will keep returning to in this book, understood something about this that took me forty years to begin to grasp. He worked in the kitchen of his monastery, and he was not good at it, and he did not like it, and it was about as far from the mountaintop as a religious life can get. And he wrote that he had come to a place where it was all the same to him. The time of business, he said, did not differ from the time of prayer. In the noise and clatter of his kitchen, with several persons at the same time calling for different things, he possessed God in as great tranquility as if he had been upon his knees at the blessed sacrament. Read that again. He found no difference between the kitchen and the altar. He was not waiting for the kitchen to end so the real spiritual life could begin. The kitchen was the real spiritual life. He had been cured of the addiction to the exceptional, and what he got in exchange was every ordinary moment, which is to say he got his whole life back.

I do not want you to hear me saying that God never does anything dramatic, that the mountaintop is a lie, that you should never go to the retreat or feel the feeling. That is not it. The mountaintop is real. Peter did see the light. God does break in,

and when he does you should let it wreck you. The problem is not the mountaintop. The problem is moving there. The problem is treating the exceptional as the norm and the ordinary as the exile. Even in the Gospel account, the whole point of the mountaintop was to send them back down. The vision was fuel for the valley, not an escape from it. Jesus did not let Peter build his shelters. He walked them straight back down into the crowd and the sickness and the argument, because that is where the work was, and the work is almost always in the valley.

So here is the invitation, and it is going to sound like a loss before it sounds like a gift. I am asking you to give up the addiction. I am asking you to stop waiting for the exceptional and to stop reading the ordinary as the absence of God. I am asking you to come down off the mountain you keep trying to move to, and to look for him in the valley where you actually live, in the kitchen with several persons calling for different things, in the ordinary Tuesday that you have been treating as a waiting room your whole life. It will feel, at first, like settling. It is the opposite of settling. It is waking up. Because the God you have been chasing across the mountaintops was never only on the mountaintops. He was in the valley the whole time, in the dishes, in the diaper, in the drive, waiting to be noticed by a people too addicted to the spectacular to see what was right in front of them. He is right here. You have been somewhere else. Come down. He is closer than the mountain ever was.

Chapter Two: The Thirty Hidden Years

God spent nine tenths of his earthly life doing nothing anyone thought worth writing down.

Let us go back to the arithmetic, because I do not think we have sat with it long enough. Jesus lived roughly thirty-three years. The Gospels give us four accounts of his life, and if you took everything in all four and laid it end to end, the overwhelming majority of it covers the final three years, the years of public ministry, the years with the miracles and the crowds and the teaching and the cross. Which means that thirty years, three full decades, the entire first act of the life of God among us, is compressed into a handful of verses. He was born. Some things happened when he was very young. There is one story from when he was twelve, when he stayed behind in the temple. And then nothing. A silence that stretches for eighteen years, from age twelve to age thirty, in which the only thing we are told is that he grew, and that he was subject to his parents, and that he increased in wisdom and stature and in favor with God and man.

I used to read past this silence as if it were an accident, as if the Gospel writers simply did not have the material, as if the hidden years were an unfortunate gap in the record. I have come to believe the opposite. I have come to believe the silence is the point. The hidden years are not a gap in the story. They are a chapter of the story, written in a language we are too impatient to read, which is the language of the ordinary. God chose to spend

thirty years in obscurity. He chose Nazareth, a town so insignificant that its name was a punchline. He chose a trade. He chose to be the carpenter's son and then the carpenter. He chose, for the vast bulk of his human existence, to be utterly, magnificently unremarkable. And if we believe that Jesus reveals God to us, that in him we see what God is like and what God values, then those thirty hidden years are a revelation as surely as the cross is a revelation. They tell us that God is not embarrassed by the ordinary. They tell us he does not despise obscurity. They tell us that a life can be holy and hidden at the same time, and that these two things are not in tension.

Think about what those years actually held. He learned a trade, which means he was bad at it before he was good at it. There was a first time he cut a joint wrong and ruined a piece of wood. There was a day he hit his thumb with a hammer and it hurt exactly as much as it hurts you. He measured and cut and sanded and fit. He made yokes for oxen and doors for houses and tables for meals, and the people of Nazareth used these objects for years without any idea whose hands had made them. He swept the shop. He swept it every day, because sawdust accumulates every day, and there is no divine exemption from the fact that a workshop must be swept. He got up in the morning tired. He ate his breakfast. He walked to work. He came home. He did this thousands of times. Thousands. The Son of God lived thousands of ordinary days that no one thought worth recording, and he did not consider them beneath him, and he did not consider them a waste, and he did not spend them longing to get to the important part.

I want to press on the word obscurity, because our culture has made it into something close to a curse. We live in a moment that treats being unknown as a kind of failure, that treats the private

and unrecognized life as a problem to be solved by more exposure, more platform, more visibility, more reach. The unspoken assumption everywhere around us is that a life only matters to the degree that it is seen by many. And into that assumption walks the God of the universe, who spent thirty of his thirty-three years being seen by almost no one, known only to a small town, doing work that left no written record and won no acclaim. He was not on a platform. He was not building an audience. He was making yokes in Nazareth. And this was not the prelude to his real life. It was thirty thirty-thirds of his real life. It was most of it.

There is a mercy in this that I did not understand until I had been a pastor for a while and had begun to feel the peculiar temptation of the visible religious life. The temptation is to believe that the visible part is the real part. That the sermon on Sunday matters and the Tuesday afternoon in the study does not. That the thing done in front of people counts and the thing done in secret is merely preparation. But the hidden years demolish this. If God himself lived most of his life in secret, then the secret life is not the preparation for the real life. The secret life is a real life, complete and whole and holy in itself, whether or not it ever becomes visible. The mother whose work is seen by no one but her children and forgotten even by them is living the shape of the life God himself chose. The man doing honest work in a job that will never make him known is standing exactly where Jesus stood for thirty years. This is not a consolation prize. This is the pattern.

I think of the parents in the story, Mary and Joseph, and what it must have been to raise this child through those hidden years. Joseph taught him the trade. Picture that. Joseph, an ordinary carpenter, teaching the Son of God how to hold a plane, how to

read the grain, how to true a board. And it was in that ordinary transaction, the daily, unremarkable business of a father teaching a son a skill, that the incarnate God spent his formative years. Joseph never knew he was discipling the Messiah in the use of a chisel. He was just teaching his boy a trade, the way fathers do, in the small daily lessons that no one thinks to write down. And that was holy work. That was as holy as anything Joseph would ever do. I say this as a man raised without a father, who has ached his whole life over the ordinary things a father teaches a son that I never got taught. The hidden years tell me those ordinary things were never small. They were the very stuff God chose to be formed by.

Wendell Berry has written for fifty years about the dignity of exactly this kind of unrecognized, located, ordinary faithfulness, and he has done it against the whole current of a culture that cannot see it. In his poems and his essays about farming and marriage and staying put, he keeps insisting that the good life is not the visible life or the mobile life or the upward life, but the faithful life lived in a particular place among particular people over a long time. There is a line of his I return to often, the idea that we should be joyful though we have considered all the facts, and that we should practice resurrection. He wrote that in a poem about a farmer, a man whose whole existence was hidden and ordinary and located. And Berry is right, and the hidden years of Jesus are the theological ground under everything Berry has ever written. The ordinary located faithful life is not the lesser life. It is the life God chose.

So I want to ask you to reconsider the hidden years of your own life, the parts no one sees, the parts that will never be recorded, the long unremarkable stretches of ordinary faithfulness that make up the actual substance of your days. You have been

taught, by everything around you, to consider these years as either preparation for something visible or as time quietly wasted. I am telling you, on the authority of thirty silent years in Nazareth, that they are neither. They are your life, and they are holy, and God is in them as surely as he was in that carpenter's shop, sweeping the sawdust off the floor of a life that no one thought worth writing down. The Gospel writers did not record those years. But do not mistake their silence for God's absence. He was there for every one of those thirty years. He is here for every one of yours.

Chapter Three: Work as Worship

The distinction between sacred work and secular work is a lie we tell to excuse ourselves from finding God on Monday.

I have preached a great many sermons about work, and for years I preached them badly, because I preached from inside a lie I had inherited and never examined. The lie is that there are two kinds of work in the world. There is sacred work, which is the ministry, the mission field, the pulpit, the things done explicitly for God, and there is secular work, which is everything else, the accounting and the plumbing and the nursing and the coding and the driving, the ordinary labor by which most people spend the bulk of their waking lives. And the lie ranks them. It puts the sacred work at the top and the secular work at the bottom, and it teaches the person in the ordinary job that their real spiritual contribution happens on the weekend or in the evening or on the mission trip, and that their forty or fifty hours of actual labor are, at best, a way to fund the real thing. I preached this. I am ashamed of it. It has done enormous damage.

Because here is what it does to the person in the pew. It tells the electrician that the eight hours he spent wiring a house safely so that a family will not burn to death in their sleep is spiritually neutral, a mere means to the end of tithing and volunteering. It tells the nurse that the twelve-hour shift she spent keeping frightened, dying people company through the worst nights of their lives was ordinary work, secular work, and that her real ministry is the Sunday school class she teaches when she can

drag herself out of bed on her one day off. It takes the very center of a person's life, the labor that occupies most of their time and energy and skill, and it declares that center to be spiritually empty, a thing to be redeemed only by the religious activities bolted onto the edges. This is a catastrophe, and it is a catastrophe of theology, and the church built it.

Go back to the beginning, to the oldest story we have about what human beings are for. Before there is any sin in the story, before the fall, before anything has gone wrong, the human being is placed in the garden and given work to do. To tend it and to keep it. Work is not the curse. Read it carefully. Work comes before the curse. Work is part of the original good, part of what it means to bear the image of a working God, a God who is himself introduced to us in the first sentences of Scripture as a worker, laboring for six days and stepping back to look at what he had made and calling it good. We are made in the image of a God who works. And so our work, our ordinary daily labor, is not a distraction from bearing his image. It is one of the primary ways we bear it. The curse did not add work to a workless paradise. The curse added thorns and sweat and frustration to work that was already there and already good.

This changes what Monday morning is. If work is part of the image of God in us, then the ordinary job, done well, done honestly, done as an act of care for the people it serves, is not spiritually neutral. It is worship. I mean that with full theological weight and not as a motivational slogan. The word we translate as worship in the Old Testament is the same word used for work and for service. To work and to worship were not two activities to the Hebrew mind. They were facets of one thing. When you do your work as unto God, when you wire the house well because a family will sleep in it, when you keep the books

honestly because people are trusting you, when you make the coffee with care because a tired stranger is going to drink it, you are worshiping. Not metaphorically. Actually. You are offering your labor to God as an act of service to the neighbor he loves, and there is no more concrete form of worship available to a human being than that.

Brother Lawrence, again, understood this in the kitchen. He wrote that we can do little things for God. He turned the cake that was frying in the pan for love of him, and when it was possible he would take up a straw from the ground for the love of God. He was not being precious. He had grasped a truth so simple that we keep missing it under our theology of the sacred and secular. God is not more present in the grand religious gesture than in the small ordinary task. He is equally present in both, or he is present in neither. The straw picked up for love of God is worship. The cake turned in the pan for love of God is worship. And if the cake and the straw can be worship, then your spreadsheet can be worship, and your sales call can be worship, and the truck you drive and the floor you mop and the children you teach and the code you write can all be worship, if they are offered. The offering is what makes it worship. And the offering is available in any work at all.

Let me be honest about the resistance I feel to my own argument, because I feel it, and you probably do too. It is easy to say your work is worship when your work is meaningful and pleasant. It is much harder to say it when your work is tedious, when it is a grind, when it is a job you took because you needed the money and not because it stirred your soul. Most work in the world is like that. Most work is not a calling in the romantic sense. It is a duty, a necessity, a way to keep a family fed. And I do not want to spiritualize that away or pretend the tedium is not real. But I

will say this. The thirty years in the carpenter's shop were probably tedious too. There is nothing in the record to suggest Jesus found making yokes to be a soaring spiritual experience. He made them because that is what the work was, day after ordinary day, and he made them well, and he made them as the Son of God. The holiness of the work was not in how it felt. It was in the faithfulness with which it was done and the love toward which it was offered.

I think of the men and women in my own congregation, the ones who will never stand behind a pulpit or lead a ministry or have their names known, the ones who get up in the dark and go to work in the cold and come home tired and do it again. There is a man who has driven a delivery route in the same county for twenty-six years. He knows every road. He has never once been asked to give his testimony from the stage. And I have come to believe that his twenty-six years of showing up, of doing an honest job honestly, of being kind to the people at every door, of never cutting the corner he could easily have cut, is worship of a depth and duration that would put most of my sermons to shame. He has been on his knees for twenty-six years. He just did it standing up, in a uniform, behind the wheel of a truck. God saw every mile of it. God received every mile of it. That is not a lesser worship. It may be a greater one.

So I want to release you from the lie, if I can, because someone should have released me from it decades before anyone did. Your work is not the thing you do to fund your spiritual life. Your work, done as unto God, in care for the neighbor and offered to the Father, is your spiritual life, or a very large part of it. The dividing line between sacred and secular runs not between the church job and the ordinary job but between work done faithfully in love and work done carelessly for self, and that line can be

crossed in a pulpit as easily as in a parking garage. Monday is not the exile from worship. Monday is where most of your worship will actually happen, in the ordinary labor of an ordinary life, offered to a God who worked for six days and called it good and who spent thirty years in a shop making yokes for oxen with his own two hands. Go to work. He will be there before you. He has always been there. He is at work himself.

Chapter Four: The Body and Its Rhythms

You are not a soul that unfortunately has a body. You are a body, and God made it, and he wrote his rhythms into your flesh.

I want to talk about your body, which is a strange thing for a theology book to do, and that strangeness is exactly the problem I want to address. We have inherited, most of us without knowing where we got it, a quiet suspicion of the body. We treat it as the lesser part of ourselves, the part that gets in the way, the animal we are stuck riding around inside. We talk about the spiritual life as if it were something that happens above the neck, or somewhere behind the sternum, in a region of pure soul unconnected to the meat and bone we actually inhabit. And so we try to have a spiritual life that ignores the body, that overrides it, that treats its needs as distractions from the real work. This is not Christianity. This is an old heresy in Christian clothing, and it has been draining the life out of the church for a very long time.

The scandal at the center of the Christian faith, the thing that separates it from every purely spiritual religion, is that God took on a body. He did not appear as pure spirit. He did not beam himself into our minds. He was born, which means there was a placenta and a cord and the mess of an ordinary human birth. He nursed at a breast. He was a baby who could not hold up his own head. He grew, which is a bodily process, cell by cell, inch by

inch. He got hungry and he got tired and he got thirsty. He fell asleep in a boat because he was exhausted, the way you get exhausted, so exhausted that a storm did not wake him. He wept real tears from real tear ducts. And when he rose from the dead, the great climax of the whole story, he did not rise as a ghost. He rose with a body. He ate fish to prove it. He told a doubting man to put his fingers in the wounds. The resurrection is the ultimate divine endorsement of the body, of matter, of flesh. God did not save us out of our bodies. He saved us in them, and he intends to raise them.

This means your body is not an obstacle to your holiness. Your body is one of the primary places your holiness happens, because your body is where you actually live. And your body comes with rhythms, built-in, non-negotiable rhythms that God wrote into your flesh, and I have spent much of my life at war with those rhythms as though they were beneath me, and I want to confess that here. I have treated sleep as a weakness to be overcome. I have treated hunger as an interruption. I have pushed my body to its limits in the name of ministry and called it sacrifice when it was really just pride, the pride of a man who thinks he is too important to have the same limits as everyone else. And my body, being wiser than I am, has repeatedly broken down and forced me to lie still, and in the lying still I have sometimes met God, who apparently was quite willing to wait for me to stop.

Consider sleep, which is the most humbling thing your body makes you do. For roughly a third of your life, God has decreed that you will be unconscious, useless, producing nothing, controlling nothing, aware of nothing. Sleep is a nightly enactment of the truth that you are not God, that the world runs without you, that you are a creature and not the Creator. The psalm says that God gives sleep to his beloved, and it says that it

is vain to rise early and stay up late anxiously toiling, because God provides for those he loves while they sleep. Sleep is an act of trust. Every night you lie down and surrender consciousness, you are confessing that you are not holding the world together, that someone else is, that you can let go. I have trouble sleeping. I lie awake running the accounts of my anxieties, and my inability to sleep is, at bottom, a spiritual problem, a failure to trust that the world will hold together without my supervision. My body knows I should sleep. My pride will not let me. The body, in this, is more faithful than the soul.

Consider hunger and food, which come around three times a day, every day, relentlessly, a rhythm you cannot escape. You have to eat. You have had to eat every day of your life and you will have to eat every day until you die. And in this daily returning need, there is a daily returning lesson, which is dependence. You do not contain your own life. You have to receive it, again and again, from outside yourself, from the ground and the rain and the labor of countless people you will never meet. Every meal is a confession that you are not self-sufficient. This is why nearly every human culture has attached prayer to eating, and why Jesus taught us to ask for daily bread, not weekly bread, not a lifetime supply, but the bread of this day, received today, so that tomorrow we will have to ask again. The rhythm of hunger is a rhythm of dependence, and God built it into your body so that you could not go a single day without being reminded that you are a creature who receives your life and does not generate it.

Kathleen Norris, in her writing about the ordinary and the daily, uses a phrase I love. She calls these things the quotidian mysteries, the mysteries of the everyday, and she notices that the daily physical needs of the body, the eating and the sleeping and the washing, are not obstacles to the spiritual life but its very

texture. She points out that the monastic tradition, the tradition that has thought most carefully about how to live a whole life before God, organized itself entirely around bodily rhythms. The monks got up at set times, ate at set times, worked and prayed and slept according to a rule that honored the body's needs rather than fighting them. They understood that you cannot have a healthy soul in a body you are constantly punishing, that the rhythms of the flesh are not the enemy of the spirit but its instrument. Brother Lawrence lived inside exactly such a rhythm, and it was the ordinary bodily structure of monastery life, the same tasks at the same hours, that gave his soul the stability to rest in God through everything.

I want to say something to the person who is exhausted, because I have been that person for long stretches, and I suspect you are that person now, or have been recently, or will be soon. Your exhaustion is not a spiritual failure. It is often the opposite. It is frequently the wage of trying to live as though you were not a creature, as though the limits God built into your body did not apply to you, as though you could keep pouring out without ever being filled, keep spending without ever resting, keep giving without ever receiving. The body will not sustain that, because God did not design it to, and when it finally forces you to stop, that stopping is not God's judgment on you. It is his mercy. It is the built-in mechanism by which a proud and driven creature is compelled, at last, to lie down and be still and remember that he is not the one holding up the sky. Your limits are not your enemy. Your limits are the shape of your creatureliness, and your creatureliness is not a flaw. It is the truth about you, and the truth is where God meets you.

So honor the body. Sleep, and let the sleeping be a prayer of trust. Eat, and let the eating be a confession of dependence. Feel

your hunger and your tiredness and your ordinary bodily limits not as interruptions to a spiritual life happening somewhere above them, but as the very rhythms through which God is teaching you, three times a day and every single night, the two truths at the center of everything, which are that you are a creature and that he is God. The grandeur of God is charged into your very flesh, into the beating of a heart you did not start and cannot stop, into the breathing that goes on without your permission, into the healing of a cut you did not know how to mend. Hopkins was right. The world is charged with the grandeur of God, and the nearest piece of that world, the one you are reading this with, the one that is tired right now and could probably use a glass of water and a full night's sleep, is your own astonishing, God-made, God-loved, ordinary body.

Chapter Five: The Table

Nothing so ordinary as a shared meal, and nothing so holy, which is why God keeps showing up at supper.

If you want to know what someone believes about God, watch how they eat, and watch especially whether they eat with anyone. Because the table, the ordinary daily table where food is shared, is one of the most theologically dense places in human life, and we have almost entirely lost the ability to see it. We eat alone now, more than any people in history. We eat in our cars and at our desks and in front of our screens, fuel poured into the machine so the machine can keep working. We have taken one of the oldest and holiest of all human acts, the sharing of a meal, and we have industrialized it into a pit stop. And in doing so we have starved ourselves of something the body needs less than the soul does, which is the communion that happens when people stop and eat together, face to face, at a table, in the ordinary miracle of a shared meal.

Look at how much of the Gospel happens at meals. It is astonishing once you start counting. Jesus is forever eating with people. He eats with tax collectors and sinners so often that it becomes one of the main charges against him, that he is a glutton and a drunkard, a friend of the wrong crowd, a man who will sit down and break bread with anyone. He turns water into wine at a wedding feast so that a party will not end too soon. He feeds thousands on a hillside because they are hungry and it is getting late. He tells story after story set at tables and feasts and banquets, and he says the kingdom of God is like a great supper

to which the unlikely are invited. And at the very center of the faith, the thing he commanded us to keep doing until he returns, is a meal. Bread and wine. Take and eat. He did not leave us a doctrine to memorize or a monument to visit. He left us a supper, an ordinary meal, and he said do this in remembrance of me. The holiest act of Christian worship is people eating together.

And notice where the resurrected Jesus chose to reveal himself, because it tells you everything. Two disciples were walking to a village called Emmaus, grieving, confused, and a stranger fell in step with them and talked with them the whole way, and they did not recognize him. He explained the Scriptures to them. He set their hearts on fire, they said later, and still they did not know him. And then they stopped for the evening and sat down to an ordinary meal, and the stranger took bread and blessed it and broke it and gave it to them, and in that instant, in the breaking of the bread, their eyes were opened and they recognized him. Not in the theological explanation on the road. Not in the exposition of the Scriptures, though it was the risen Christ himself giving it. They recognized him in the ordinary act of a shared meal, in the breaking of the bread. And the moment they recognized him he vanished, as if to say, now you know where to look for me. Look for me here. Look for me at the table.

I did not grow up with a table like this. I was raised without a father, in a home where meals were often just something that happened, or did not happen, on the way to something else. And I have spent my whole adult life, with Susanna and our five sons, trying to build the table I did not have, and I want to tell you it is hard, and it is worth it, and it is holy, and it almost never feels holy while it is happening. Getting seven people to sit down at the same table at the same time is a logistical war. Someone has practice. Someone is not hungry. Someone is angry at someone

else. The food is not fancy. The conversation is often about nothing, or it is an argument about whose turn it is, or it collapses into the particular chaos that a table full of boys can generate. And I have sat at that loud crowded ordinary table many nights, tired, wanting it to be over, scanning past it toward the peace I would get once everyone was in bed, and completely failing to see that the loud crowded ordinary table was the peace, was the blessing, was the thing itself, was Christ breaking bread in my own dining room while I looked past him toward some quieter holiness that was never going to come.

There is a discipline in the shared table, and it is a discipline our whole culture is arranged against. To eat together you have to stop. You have to be in one place at one time with the same people, which the modern world makes nearly impossible and increasingly optional. You have to slow to the speed of a meal, which is slower than the speed we like to live at. You have to be present to actual human faces rather than the more manageable faces on a screen. You have to receive the food as a gift and the company as a gift, neither of which you fully controlled or created. The table asks you to be a creature among creatures, dependent, embodied, located, present. This is precisely why it is disappearing, because our culture is arranged to make us feel like autonomous individuals who consume on our own schedules, and the shared table is a standing rebuke to that whole way of being. The table says you are not autonomous. You are a member of a body, and bodies eat together.

Wendell Berry has written that eating is an agricultural act, and he means that the meal connects us, whether we notice or not, to the soil and the rain and the seasons and the long chain of labor that brought the food to the plate. When you eat, you are eating the sunlight of a particular summer, converted into wheat by a

plant, ground and baked by hands, carried and sold and prepared, and set before you as if it were nothing, as if it were merely lunch. But it is never merely lunch. It is a piece of the created world, offered up to sustain your life, and the ordinary act of eating it is a participation in the whole economy of creation and gift. To say grace before a meal is not a religious formality bolted onto a biological function. It is the truest possible response to what is actually happening, which is that you are about to receive your life, again, from outside yourself, through the death of other living things and the labor of people you will never thank. Grace is just telling the truth about supper.

So I want to make a plea for the ordinary table, and it is a plea I am still learning to obey myself. Eat with people. Slow down and eat with people, at a table, without a screen, more often than you do. It will be inefficient. It will be inconvenient. The food does not need to be impressive and the conversation does not need to be deep. It will frequently feel like nothing, like the ordinary chaos of ordinary people eating ordinary food. But do not be fooled by how ordinary it feels, because the two travelers on the road to Emmaus did not feel anything holy either, right up until the bread was broken and their eyes were opened. The table is where he keeps showing up. It has always been where he shows up. He is a friend of sinners, a guest at weddings, a maker of breakfast on a beach, the one who took bread and blessed it and was known in the breaking of it. Set the table. Sit down. Stay a while. He will meet you there, in the passing of the bread, in the ordinary supper, the way he always has.

Chapter Six: The Dishes

The pile in the sink is not the interruption of your spiritual life. Some days it is the whole of it.

I want to write an entire chapter about dishes, and I understand how that sounds, and I am going to do it anyway, because the sink is where my whole thesis either holds or falls apart. It is easy to talk about finding God in a shared meal, in the warmth and communion of the table, because there is something obviously beautiful there to point at. But then the meal ends, and everyone gets up and drifts away to their lives, and someone is left standing at the sink in front of a pile of dirty plates, and it is that someone, at that sink, in that moment, who tests whether any of this is real. Because if God is in the meal but not in the cleanup, if he is at the table but gone by the time you are scraping the plates, then I have not told you the truth. I have just given you a prettier version of the same old lie, that God is in the nice parts and absent from the tedious ones. So let us talk about the dishes.

Kathleen Norris wrote a small and remarkable book about exactly this, and the phrase she gave us, the quotidian mysteries, has stayed with me for years. She noticed something about the repetitive daily tasks of ordinary life, the laundry and the dishes and the making of beds and the sweeping of floors, the tasks that are never finished, that undo themselves the moment they are done, that have to be repeated again tomorrow and the next day and forever. Our culture despises these tasks precisely because they are repetitive and produce nothing permanent. We are a

people who want to accomplish things, to build things that stay built, to check items off and be done. And the dishes will not be done. You wash them tonight and they are dirty again tomorrow. You do the laundry and within a day the hamper is full again. This is maddening to the achieving mind. And Norris suggests that this very maddening quality is where the spiritual work is, that the endless repetition of the daily task is a school of humility and presence and even, strangely, of joy, if we will stop fighting it.

Because here is the thing about a task that is never finished. It keeps you in the present. A task you can complete lets you live in the future, in the moment when it will be done and you will be free. But a task that undoes itself, that must be done again tomorrow no matter how well you do it today, offers you no such escape into the future. It offers you only now. Only these dishes, this water, this plate in your hand. The dishes cannot be gotten past, because there is nothing past them but more dishes. And so they force you, if you will let them, to be here, now, in the warm water and the ordinary work, which is the only place God has ever actually been available, because God is only ever available in the present, and the dishes are a machine for returning you to the present, three times a day, for the rest of your life.

Brother Lawrence, the monk in the kitchen, is the great master of this, and I keep coming back to him because he solved, in the seventeenth century, the exact problem I am still failing to solve in the twenty-first. He was assigned to the kitchen of his monastery, and he disliked it, and he spent fifteen years there, and somewhere in those fifteen years of pots and pans and endless meals to prepare and endless cleaning up, he discovered that he could do the work in the presence of God. He was not praying about the work and he was not escaping the work into

prayer. He was doing the work as prayer, holding God in his awareness while his hands were busy in the ordinary tasks, so that the cooking and the cleaning became, for him, a continuous conversation with God. He said that the noise of his kitchen, with everyone calling for different things at once, did not disturb his sense of God's presence at all, that he was as close to God among the pots as he ever was at the altar. Fifteen years of dishes made him one of the great spiritual teachers in the history of the church. Fifteen years of dishes. Let that sink in.

I stand at my own sink most nights, and I want to tell you the truth about what happens there, because the truth is more encouraging than a tidy success story would be. Most nights I do not find God at the sink. Most nights I stand there resenting the dishes, replaying the day's grievances, planning tomorrow, scrolling in my head through everything more important than this that I would rather be doing. I treat the dishes as the tax I pay for having eaten, a stretch of dead time to be gotten through as fast as possible so I can get to the real evening. And every so often, not often enough, something in me quiets, and I notice the warm water on my hands, and I notice that this small repeated task is exactly the kind of thing Jesus did ten thousand times in Nazareth, and I remember that God is not somewhere else waiting for me to finish, he is right here in the warm water and the ordinary work, and for a few minutes the dishes become what they always were, which is a place to meet God, and then the moment passes and I am resenting them again by the last plate. I am not the master here. I am the struggling student. But I have been at the sink long enough to know the master was right.

There is a deep pride that the dishes expose, and I think this is why we hate them so much. We want our lives to be about the big things, the significant things, the things worthy of a person of

our importance. And the dishes are an insult to that self-image. They are beneath us. They are what anyone could do, what no one notices, what will never appear on any account of a meaningful life. To do them, and to do them again, and to keep doing them for decades without applause, is a daily death to the grandiosity that wants our life to be about something more impressive. And that daily death is precisely the point. The dishes are killing the part of you that thinks you are too important for the ordinary, and the death of that part of you is not a loss. It is your salvation, worked out three times a day at the kitchen sink, in the humblest possible school, tuition paid in resentment slowly turning, over years, into something that might one day resemble peace.

Norris makes a connection I have never forgotten, between the repetitive work of the household and the repetitive work of prayer. The daily prayers of the monastic tradition, the psalms said at the same hours day after day, year after year, are as repetitive as the dishes, and for the same reason, and to the same end. You do not say the psalms once and finish them. You say them again tomorrow. The repetition is not a failure to progress. The repetition is the practice, the way a scale is not a failure to write a symphony but the discipline that makes music possible at all. The dishes are a liturgy. The laundry is a liturgy. The daily undoing and redoing of the ordinary household is a spiritual practice as real as any that has ever been prescribed, a practice of presence and humility and faithfulness, performed at the sink and the hamper and the unmade bed, in the presence of a God who is not too grand for the grease and the grime, who lived thirty years inside exactly this kind of daily repetition and called none of it beneath him.

So the next time you are standing at the sink, resenting the pile,

wishing you were doing something that mattered, I want you to consider that you may already be doing the thing that matters most, in the only school that has ever taught anyone to be present, to be humble, to be here. The dishes are not keeping you from your spiritual life. On an ordinary Tuesday night, with the house quiet and the water warm and the plates stacked, the dishes may well be your spiritual life, the whole of it, distilled into the simplest possible act of faithful, unrewarded, God-present ordinary work. Do not scan past them toward some holier moment that is not coming. Wash the dish that is in your hand. He is nearer to that dish than to any mountaintop you have ever chased. Brother Lawrence found him there for fifteen years. He is still there. Look down into the warm water. That is where he has been the whole time.

Chapter Seven: The Marriage on a Tuesday

Love is not mostly the wedding and the crisis. Love is mostly the Tuesday, and the Tuesday is where it is made or lost.

Everyone knows how to love on the wedding day. The whole culture has trained us for it. We know how to love in the grand gesture, the anniversary trip, the crisis when the diagnosis comes and everything else falls away and you remember with terrible clarity how much this person means to you. Those moments are real and they matter. But they are not where a marriage is actually made or lost. A marriage is made or lost on a Tuesday, an ordinary Tuesday, when nothing is happening, when there is no wedding and no crisis and no romance in the air, just two tired people and a pile of ordinary obligations and the small daily choices about how to speak and how to listen and whether to turn toward each other or away. The Tuesday is the real test. And most of us have no theology for the Tuesday, because we have imagined that love lives in the exceptional moments, when in fact love lives, or dies, in the ordinary ones.

Susanna and I have been married a long time now, long enough that the wedding is a distant photograph and the early romance is a memory we sometimes have to work to recall. We have raised five sons together, which is a thing that will grind the romance out of any marriage that was depending on romance to survive. And I have learned, slowly and against my own instincts, that the

marriage is not primarily happening in the moments I thought were the marriage, the date nights and the deep conversations and the anniversary getaways. Those are wonderful and we need them. But the marriage is mostly happening in the ten thousand ordinary Tuesdays, in who takes out the trash without being asked, in whether I actually listen when she tells me about her day or just wait for my turn to talk, in the tone of voice I use when I am tired, in the small daily accumulation of turning toward or turning away that no single instance of which seems to matter at all and all of which, added up over years, is the entire substance of whether we love each other.

There is a body of research on this that confirms what the wisest married people have always known, that the health of a marriage is predicted less by how couples handle the big conflicts than by how they handle the small daily moments, the tiny bids for attention and connection that pass between two people hundreds of times a day. One person makes a small comment, notices something out the window, sighs, mentions a worry. And the other person either turns toward that bid, responds, engages, or turns away, stays absorbed, does not look up. No single instance matters. But the pattern, repeated across years, is the marriage. The couples who turn toward each other in the small ordinary moments build something that lasts. The couples who turn away, moment by unremarkable moment, wake up one day as strangers, and neither of them can point to when it happened, because it did not happen at any single moment. It happened in all of them, in the accumulated weight of ten thousand small turnings away, on ten thousand ordinary Tuesdays.

I have to confess my own failure here, because I have been the man who turns away, and I did not even know I was doing it. I was present. I was in the house. I was not unfaithful and I was

not cruel. But I was often somewhere else, in my head, on my phone, in my ministry, scanning past the ordinary domestic moment toward whatever I had decided was more important. Susanna would mention something small and I would answer without looking up. She would reach for connection in the ordinary way that people reach, and I would be too preoccupied with the important business of my important life to reach back. And I told myself this was fine because I was not doing anything wrong, because I would show up for the big moments, because I loved her, which I did. But love that only shows up for the big moments is not love. It is a highlight reel. And the marriage is not the highlight reel. The marriage is the ordinary footage, the long unedited hours of daily life together, and I was not present for enough of it, and no grand gesture on an anniversary can make up for a thousand small absences on a thousand ordinary days.

The Bible's picture of married love is far more ordinary than the culture's, and far more demanding. When Paul reaches for a description of love, in the passage read at every wedding, he does not describe feelings. He describes ordinary daily behavior. Love is patient. Love is kind. Love does not envy or boast. It is not easily angered. It keeps no record of wrongs. Read that list again and notice that every single item on it is a Tuesday behavior, an ordinary daily practice, the stuff of how two people actually treat each other in the unremarkable moments. Patience is a Tuesday virtue. Kindness is a Tuesday virtue. Not keeping a record of wrongs is a Tuesday discipline, practiced or abandoned in the small daily accounting of who did what and who owes whom. Paul is not describing the wedding day feeling. He is describing the ordinary daily labor of love, the actual work of it, which is done not in grand gestures but in the patient, kind, unrecorded faithfulness of ten thousand ordinary days.

This is why I have come to believe that a good marriage is one of the great spiritual disciplines available to a human being, and one of the most sanctifying, precisely because it is so relentlessly ordinary and so impossible to fake over the long haul. You can perform love for a weekend. You cannot perform it for thirty years. Over thirty years the performance breaks down and the real person shows, the selfishness and the impatience and the deep resistance to being inconvenienced by another person's needs. And marriage, the ordinary daily grind of it, exposes all of that and then offers, day after day, the chance to die to it a little more. Marriage is a school of holiness disguised as a domestic arrangement. The person you are married to knows exactly where your selfishness lives and cannot help but keep pressing on it, not out of cruelty but simply by existing near you with needs of their own, and the daily choice to love them anyway, on the days you do not feel like it, on the ordinary Tuesdays when the romance is gone and only the commitment remains, is the choice that slowly, over decades, makes you into someone capable of love.

I do not want to sentimentalize this, because the same ordinariness that can make a marriage holy can also let it quietly die, and the difference is attention. The ordinary Tuesday is not automatically sanctifying. It becomes sanctifying only when you show up for it, when you decide that the ordinary moments with this person are not the boring backdrop to your real life but are, in fact, your real life and one of the primary places God is forming you. Most marriages do not end in a dramatic explosion. Most marriages end in a slow drift, an accumulation of ordinary Tuesdays in which two people gradually stopped turning toward each other, stopped paying attention, stopped doing the small daily work of love because it was small and daily and no single instance of it seemed to matter. The drift is undramatic. That is

exactly why it is dangerous, because we are watching for the dramatic threats to our marriages and missing the ordinary one, which is simply the slow erosion of attention across ten thousand unremarkable days.

So love your spouse on Tuesday. That is the whole of it, and it is harder than any grand gesture, because a grand gesture is over in an afternoon and Tuesday comes back every week for the rest of your life. Turn toward them in the small moment. Listen when they tell you the ordinary thing. Be patient and kind in the unremarkable exchange when no one is watching and there is no romance in the air and you are both tired and it would be so easy to turn away. This is where the marriage is. This is where the love is made or lost. And this is where God is, in the ordinary daily faithfulness of two flawed people choosing each other again on a Tuesday when there is no reason to except the reason that holds up everything, which is love, which is patient and kind and keeps no record of wrongs, and which is built not on the wedding day but on all the ordinary days after it, one Tuesday at a time, for as long as you both shall live.

Chapter Eight: Parenting in the Mundane

No one is formed by the lecture. Everyone is formed by the ten thousand ordinary mornings.

I have five sons, which means I have had roughly five childhoods pass through my house, and I have learned more about the ordinary than I ever wanted to know, and most of what I learned I learned too late to use on the older ones. Here is the central thing, the thing I would carve over the door of every new parent's home if I could. Your children are not being formed by the big moments you are planning. They are being formed by the ordinary ones you are not even noticing. Not by the vacation. By the ten thousand ordinary mornings. Not by the important talk you sat them down for. By the way you spoke to their mother when you thought the conversation did not count. Not by the church service. By whether the faith you profess on Sunday visibly governs the way you handle a Tuesday. Children are formed in the mundane, by the mundane, and there is no way around this, and it terrified me when I understood it, because it meant I could not delegate my children's formation to any special program. It was happening, all the time, in how I lived the ordinary hours in front of them.

I spent the early years of fatherhood waiting for the significant parenting moments, the teachable moments, the big conversations where I would impart wisdom and shape a soul. I had a whole theory of fatherhood built around these moments,

probably because I never had a father and had to invent the role from scratch, from books and imagination and longing. And I kept waiting for these moments to arrive, and when they did I would summon my energy and rise to the occasion and deliver the wisdom, and then I would relax back into the ordinary hours, which I treated as the unimportant space between the significant moments. It took me an embarrassingly long time to understand that I had it exactly backward. The big talks changed almost nothing. The ordinary hours changed everything. My sons were not becoming who they are because of my carefully planned significant moments. They were becoming who they are because of the thousand ordinary interactions I was barely paying attention to, the tone of the mornings, the way disappointment got handled, the small daily evidence of what their father actually valued as opposed to what he said he valued.

This is the terror and the mercy of parenting, and they are the same thing. The terror is that you cannot control it and you cannot fake it. Your children are absorbing you, the real you, the ordinary daily you, not the you that shows up for the significant moment but the you that reacts when the milk spills, the you that is behind the wheel in traffic, the you that comes home tired and either has patience left or does not. They are learning what a human being is by watching one at close range for eighteen years, in all the ordinary unguarded moments when you are not performing. They see who you are on Tuesday. And no lecture about honesty will survive a child watching you shade the truth on the phone, and no talk about kindness will outweigh the way they watched you treat the waiter, and no Sunday sermon they absorb will form them the way the ordinary texture of their own home forms them, day after day after day, below the level of anyone's conscious attention.

And that is the mercy too, because it means the formation does not require you to be extraordinary. It requires you to be ordinarily faithful, present in the mundane, which is available to anyone. You do not have to be an impressive parent in the big moments. You have to be a present parent in the small ones. You have to actually be there, attentive, in the ordinary hours, the breakfast and the drive and the bedtime and the endless small negotiations of daily life with children. James K. A. Smith has written that we are formed not primarily by what we are told but by what we repeatedly do and repeatedly experience, that our loves and our characters are shaped by the liturgies of our ordinary lives, the practices we repeat until they become who we are. This is true of children more than anyone. The liturgy of your household, the repeated ordinary practices of your home, is forming your children's deepest loves, whether you designed that liturgy on purpose or let it form by default. The dinner table or its absence. The way conflict is handled or not handled. Whether the ordinary rhythms of the home point toward God or away from him. This is the real curriculum, and it is taught in the mundane.

I think about the bedtimes, because I got so many of them wrong and a few of them right, and the difference has stayed with me. For years bedtime was a task to be completed, an obstacle between me and the quiet evening I wanted. I hurried it. I read the book too fast, skipping pages when I could get away with it. I answered the whispered questions in the dark with half my mind already downstairs. And I was blind to the fact that this hurried ordinary bedtime was one of the holiest opportunities I would ever be given, a child lying in the dark, safe, wanting nothing more than the presence of a parent, offering me their whole attention in the vulnerable moments before sleep. That is sacred ground. That is a thing people spend fortunes in therapy later in

life wishing they had received. And I was rushing through it to get to the television. Some nights, later, with the younger boys, I learned to slow down, to actually be there in the dark, to answer the small question fully, to let the bedtime take the time it takes, and those slow ordinary bedtimes are among the holiest hours of my life, and I almost missed all of them chasing an evening's peace that never delivered anything half so good.

There is a passage in Deuteronomy that has governed Jewish parenting for three thousand years, and it is entirely a theology of the mundane. It says to teach the commands of God to your children, and then it says exactly how: talk about them when you sit at home and when you walk along the road, when you lie down and when you get up. Notice that these are not special religious occasions. Sitting at home, walking along the road, lying down, getting up. These are the four corners of an ordinary day, the mundane hours, the unremarkable rhythms of daily life. The formation of a child's soul was to happen not in a special ceremony but woven into the ordinary fabric of daily living, in the car and at the table and at bedtime and at breakfast. The ancient wisdom knew what I keep forgetting, that the deep formation of a child happens in the mundane, in the ordinary hours, and that the parent's task is not to engineer significant moments but to fill the ordinary ones with a faithful presence and a visible love of God.

I want to say a hard word to the parents who are exhausted and who feel they are failing, because I have felt like a failure more nights than I can count. You will get it wrong. You will be impatient in the ordinary moments, absent when you should be present, hurried when you should be slow. I have been all of these, and my sons carry, I am sure, the marks of my ordinary failures as surely as they carry the marks of any good I did. But

here is the grace in the theology of the mundane. Because the formation happens in the ordinary hours and not in a few decisive moments, no single failure is decisive. The ordinary day comes back tomorrow. You get to be present tomorrow morning at breakfast even though you were absent tonight at dinner. The very repetition that makes the mundane so relentless is also what makes it so forgiving, because there is always another ordinary hour coming, another chance to turn toward instead of away, another Tuesday to get a little more right than you got the last one. The formation is long, and it is ongoing, and it is not decided by your worst moments any more than by your best ones. It is decided by the long accumulation, and the long accumulation is still being written, one ordinary day at a time.

So do not wait for the significant moments to parent your children, because the significant moments are not where the formation is. Parent them in the mundane. Be present in the ordinary hours. Slow down at the bedtime. Answer the small question fully. Let them watch you handle an ordinary Tuesday like a person who loves God, because they are watching, and the watching is the education, and it is happening whether you have decided to teach or not. Your children will not remember your lectures. They will remember, in their very bones, the ordinary texture of the home you built for them, the daily rhythm of your presence or your absence, the thousand small mornings that you thought did not matter and that turned out to be the whole of it. God formed his own Son through thirty ordinary years in an ordinary home learning an ordinary trade from an ordinary father. He knows exactly how a life is formed. It is formed in the mundane. So parent there. That is where your children actually live, and that is where you will actually reach them, and that is where God is forming them, and you, in the ordinary hours you keep wishing you could skip.

Chapter Nine: The Neighbor You Did Not Choose

You do not get to pick who lives next door, and that is precisely how God arranges to sanctify you.

There is a lawyer in the Gospel of Luke who asks Jesus a question I have asked in my own heart many times, though I would never say it out loud. He asks, and who is my neighbor. It is a question that sounds humble and is actually a request for limits. He wants to know the boundary of his obligation. He wants Jesus to define neighbor narrowly enough that he can be sure he is fulfilling the command without it costing him too much. And in response Jesus tells the story we call the Good Samaritan, and the point of the story is precisely to demolish the question. The neighbor turns out to be whoever is in front of you, whoever has been placed in your path, whoever needs you, regardless of whether you chose them, regardless of whether they are your kind of person, regardless of whether you find them convenient or agreeable or deserving. The neighbor is not a category you get to define. The neighbor is a person God puts in your way, and the whole point is that you did not get to choose them.

This is the part we resist, and I resist it as much as anyone. We live in a moment of unprecedented ability to choose our people. We choose our friends by affinity, our communities by preference, our online worlds by algorithm, so that we are surrounded, more and more, only by people we selected, people

who agree with us, people who are like us, people we find agreeable. And into this world of chosen relationships comes the ancient and stubborn category of the neighbor, the person you did not choose, the one who simply lives next door or works at the next desk or sits in the next pew, placed there by no decision of yours, and whom you are nonetheless commanded to love. The neighbor is God's great intrusion into the curated life. The neighbor is the person your algorithm would never have selected, and that is exactly why God gives them to you, because the people you would choose cannot sanctify you and the people you would not choose can.

I have a neighbor, and I will not describe him too closely, but he is not a man I would have chosen. Our politics are different. Our temperaments are different. He has habits that irritate me and opinions that I find hard to be near, and for a long time I managed the relationship the way we are all trained to manage such relationships now, with a polite distance that kept the irritation manageable and the obligation minimal. And I told myself this was fine, that I was being neighborly, that a wave from the driveway fulfilled the requirement. But I knew, underneath, that Jesus was not talking about a wave from the driveway. He was talking about the Samaritan getting down off his animal, getting his hands dirty, spending his own money, being inconvenienced at real cost for a person who was not his kind and had not been chosen. And I knew that my polite distance was not love. It was the management of a person I would rather not have to love at all.

The theology here goes deep, deeper than mere ethics, because the neighbor is where the entire command to love God gets tested and made real. John says it with brutal clarity, that anyone who claims to love God, whom they have not seen, while hating

their brother, whom they have seen, is a liar. The love of God is not a feeling you cultivate in private toward an invisible being. It is a thing that either shows up in how you treat the visible people around you or it does not exist at all. And the visible people around you are, to a large degree, people you did not choose, the ordinary assortment of neighbors and coworkers and fellow church members and family members that God has placed in your actual life. Your love of God is measured not by your feelings in worship but by your treatment of these unchosen ordinary people, which is a far more demanding test and a far less flattering one, and which cannot be passed by any amount of religious feeling if the ordinary love toward the ordinary neighbor is not there.

Wendell Berry has written about this in terms of membership, the idea that we belong to one another not by our choosing but by our given place, that a real community is not a collection of people who selected each other by affinity but a body of people bound together by proximity and need and the accidents of shared place over time. He writes about the members of a small farming community caring for each other not because they are compatible but because they are members, because they are there, because when a barn burns or a person falls ill you help, not because you like them but because they belong to you and you to them by the fact of shared life in a shared place. This is a picture almost entirely lost in our mobile, curated, affinity-sorted world, and it is a deeply biblical picture, because the neighbor and the member are the same person, the unchosen one, the one given rather than selected, the one whose need has a claim on you that no algorithm would ever generate.

I want to be honest that loving the unchosen neighbor is often not dramatic and not satisfying, which is exactly why it belongs

in a book about the ordinary. It is rarely the heroic rescue of the roadside Samaritan. It is much more often the small ordinary business of being present and decent and available to people you did not choose, over a long time, without the warm feelings that make it easy. It is bringing in the mail when they are away, though you have nothing in common. It is the ordinary conversation across the fence that you would rather not have. It is showing up when they are sick, sitting with them when they are grieving, being the presence God has placed nearby, again and again, in unremarkable acts of unremarkable love toward people you might never have befriended. The love of neighbor is mostly not heroic. It is mostly ordinary, daily, undramatic faithfulness toward the people who happen to be near, and it is sanctifying precisely because it is so ordinary and so unchosen and so often unaccompanied by any feeling of affection at all.

There is a particular grace in the fact that we do not choose our neighbors, and it took me years to see it as grace rather than as burden. If I only ever had to love the people I chose, the people I liked, the people who were like me, I would never have to grow. I would remain forever comfortable in the small world of my own preferences, and my love would never be stretched beyond the boundaries of my own affinity, which is to say my love would remain fundamentally a form of self-love, a love of my own kind, my own tribe, my own reflection. It is the unchosen neighbor who breaks me open, who forces my love past the boundary of my preference, who teaches me to love as God loves, which is to love the unlike and the unchosen and even the unlikable. God did not choose us because we were his kind. He loved us while we were his enemies. And the unchosen neighbor is God's ordinary daily instrument for teaching me to love the way he loved me, past preference, past affinity, past the comfortable boundaries of the world I would have curated for

myself.

So love the neighbor you did not choose, the one God placed next door or at the next desk or in the next pew, the ordinary unchosen person whose presence in your life is not your decision and whose claim on your love is not negotiable. Do not manage them with a polite distance that keeps the cost low. Get down off the animal. Be inconvenienced. Bring the meal, have the conversation, show up when they are sick, love them in the ordinary undramatic ways that love actually takes, over years, without the warm feelings that would make it easy. Because the neighbor is where your love of God becomes real or is revealed as a lie, and the neighbor is God's chosen instrument to break your love open past the boundaries of your preference, and the neighbor is, very often, the exact person Jesus is asking about when he asks what you did for the least of these. You did not choose them. That is the point. God chose them for you, and he chose them on purpose, and he is using them, that ordinary irritating unchosen person next door, to make you into someone who can finally love the way you have been loved.

Chapter Ten: A Long Obedience

The Christian life is not a series of sprints between mountaintops. It is one long walk in the same direction, and the walking is the point.

Eugene Peterson took a phrase from Friedrich Nietzsche, of all the unlikely places, and made it the title of one of the best books about the Christian life ever written. Nietzsche had said that the essential thing in heaven and earth is that there should be a long obedience in the same direction, and that thereby results something which makes life worth living. Peterson saw in that phrase, written by a man who despised Christianity, a nearly perfect description of what the Christian life actually is. Not a dramatic event. Not a series of spiritual highs. A long obedience in the same direction. A sustained faithfulness over time, in one direction, through all the ordinary years, without the drama, without the applause, without much sense of progress on any given day. He wrote that book in 1980, and it has outlasted almost everything published around it, because it named a truth that our culture is constantly working to make us forget, which is that the good things are built slowly, by long faithfulness, and cannot be built any other way.

We do not believe this anymore, if we ever did. We are a people formed to expect fast results and dramatic transformation, and we import this expectation directly into our spiritual lives, where it does enormous damage. We want to be transformed, and we want it to be sudden, and we want to feel it happening. We go to the conference expecting to come home different. We start the

discipline expecting to see results in a week. And when the change does not come fast, when the ordinary slowness of real growth asserts itself, when we find ourselves a year later struggling with the same sins and the same doubts and the same ordinary difficulties, we conclude that we have failed, or that God has failed us, or that the whole thing is not working. Because we were promised, by a thousand voices, that the change would be dramatic and fast, and it is neither. It is slow. It is ordinary. It is a long obedience in the same direction, and the ordinariness and the slowness are not signs of failure. They are the actual shape of the thing.

Peterson drew his picture of this long obedience from the songs of ascents, the psalms that pilgrims sang as they walked up to Jerusalem for the festivals. And I love that he located the Christian life in the image of a walk, because a walk is the most ordinary form of travel there is. You do not walk in dramatic bursts. You walk step after step after step, each step almost identical to the last, no single step covering much distance, and yet over a long enough walk you arrive somewhere far from where you started, having crossed the whole distance not in a single leap but in ten thousand ordinary steps. That is the Christian life. That is how a soul is actually formed. Not in a leap. In ten thousand ordinary steps, each one small, each one seemingly insignificant, the whole distance crossed by the sheer accumulation of ordinary faithful steps taken in the same direction over a very long time. The walking is the point. There is no shortcut across the country. There is only the walk.

I have watched this in my own congregation, and it is one of the great privileges of being a pastor over many years in the same place, which is that you get to see the long obedience actually happen, slowly, in real people, over time. The young man who

could barely sit still through a service, who is now, twenty years later, a steady and faithful elder, and you cannot point to the moment he changed because there was no moment, there was only twenty years of showing up and slowly becoming. The woman who came in broken and bitter and is now, after a decade and a half of ordinary faithful attendance and ordinary faithful obedience, one of the most gracious people I know, and again you cannot find the moment, because there was no moment, there was only the long obedience, the ordinary steps, the years of walking in the same direction until she had, without ever noticing it happen, arrived somewhere entirely new. The transformation was real. It was just slow, and it was made of ordinary days, and no one could see it happening while it happened, including her.

This is why the spectacular is so often the enemy of the substantial, and I want to say this carefully because it cuts against everything we are trained to want. The dramatic spiritual experience, the mountaintop, the conference high, feels like progress, and sometimes it is a real gift, but it is not the same as the slow ordinary growth that actually forms a soul, and it can even become a substitute for it, a way of feeling spiritual without doing the long slow work of becoming spiritual. You can chase spiritual highs your whole life and never grow, because the highs are not the growth. The growth is the long obedience, the ordinary daily faithfulness, the ten thousand small steps in the same direction, and this cannot be shortcut by any experience, however dramatic. I have known people who had extraordinary spiritual experiences and remained fundamentally unchanged, because they mistook the experience for the transformation. And I have known people who never had a dramatic experience in their lives and were transformed beyond recognition by the sheer accumulation of ordinary faithfulness over decades. The long

obedience is what changes you. The experiences are, at best, encouragements along the way.

There is a particular endurance the long obedience requires, and it is not the dramatic endurance of the crisis but the far harder endurance of the ordinary. Almost anyone can endure a crisis, because a crisis is temporary and adrenaline carries you and everyone is watching and there is a clear enemy to fight. The much harder thing is to endure the ordinary, to keep walking in the same direction not through a dramatic trial but through the long undramatic stretch when nothing is happening, when there is no crisis and no applause and no sense of progress, when the faithfulness is required not for a moment but for years, and no one is watching, and there is no feeling to reward it. This is where most people quit, not in the crisis but in the ordinary. They can endure the storm. What they cannot endure is the long flat road with no storm and no destination in sight, just the walking, day after day, in the same direction. And yet the long flat road is where the whole thing is won or lost, because the long flat road is most of the road.

The witnesses I keep returning to in this book were all people of the long obedience. Brother Lawrence did not have one dramatic experience of God in the kitchen. He had fifteen years of ordinary daily practice, slowly training himself to hold God in his awareness through the endless tasks, and the fruit came not from a moment but from the years. Wendell Berry's whole vision of faithfulness is a vision of staying, of remaining in one place and one marriage and one vocation over a lifetime, of the slow good that can only be built by not leaving. Peterson pastored the same small congregation for decades, resisting every temptation toward the spectacular, insisting that the pastor's real work was the slow ordinary care of ordinary souls over a long time. These

were not people of the dramatic breakthrough. They were people of the long walk, and everything good and deep and lasting in their lives came from the walk and not from any single step of it.

So settle in for the long obedience, and let go of the expectation that it should be dramatic or fast or feel like progress on any given day. You are not going to be transformed at a conference. You are going to be transformed, if you are transformed at all, by ten thousand ordinary faithful days walked in the same direction, most of which will feel like nothing, none of which will make a photograph, and all of which together will slowly carry you somewhere you could never have leaped. Keep walking. Take the next ordinary step, and then the one after that, in the same direction, through the long flat stretches where nothing seems to be happening and no one is watching and there is no feeling to reward you. Because the walking is the point, and the direction is what matters, and the God you are walking toward is also the God who walks beside you, step by ordinary step, on the long road home, which is made not of mountaintops but of ordinary faithful ground, covered slowly, one step at a time, for as long as it takes, which is the rest of your life.

Chapter Eleven: The Trouble with the Spectacular

The spectacular does not usually deepen your faith. It usually distracts you from the ordinary places where faith is actually built.

I need to say something clearly that I have been circling for ten chapters, because it is the counterweight the whole book depends on, and I have been too gentle about it. The spectacular is usually a distraction. Not always. God does break in, and when he does, we should receive it. But as a general pattern, across a whole life of faith, the craving for the spectacular does not deepen you. It distracts you. It pulls your attention away from the ordinary places where God actually works and fixes it on the dramatic places where you wish he worked, and in doing so it keeps you perpetually looking in the wrong direction, waiting for the fireworks, missing the sunrise. I say this as a recovering addict of the spectacular, so I am not condemning a sin I do not know. I am describing my own disease.

Consider the pattern in the Scriptures, because it is remarkably consistent and it cuts against our expectations. When the great figures of the Bible want the spectacular, God very often gives them the ordinary instead, and the ordinary turns out to be where he actually is. Elijah, exhausted and afraid after the most spectacular event of his life, the fire falling on Mount Carmel in front of everyone, runs into the wilderness wanting to die, and God comes to him. And God does not come in the spectacular.

There is a great wind that tears the mountains apart, and God is not in the wind. There is an earthquake, and God is not in the earthquake. There is a fire, and God is not in the fire. And then there is a sound of sheer silence, a still small voice, the most ordinary and quiet thing imaginable, and God is in that. The prophet who had just called down fire from heaven had to learn that God was more truly present in the whisper than in the fire, that the spectacular was not where God lived, that the still small ordinary voice was the real address. Elijah wanted the fire. God gave him the whisper.

The trouble with the spectacular is that it trains the appetite in the wrong direction. Once you have tasted the dramatic, the ordinary tastes like nothing, and you begin to crave the drama, to need it, to require an ever-greater intensity to feel that God is present at all. This is the exact structure of addiction, and it operates in the spiritual life as surely as in any other. The person who has built their faith on spiritual highs finds that each high satisfies for a shorter time and that a greater high is required to produce the same effect, until eventually the ordinary Christian life, the quiet daily faithfulness that is the actual substance of the thing, feels unbearably flat, feels like abandonment, feels like God has left, when in fact God is exactly where he always was, in the quiet and the ordinary, and it is only the drama-trained appetite that can no longer taste him there. The spectacular does not deepen faith. It inflames an appetite that ordinary faith can never satisfy, and then blames God for the emptiness.

I have watched this destroy people, and I have felt it working in myself, so let me describe it plainly. There are Christians who move from church to church, from experience to experience, from conference to conference, always chasing the next encounter, always convinced that the last church went cold or the

last season went dry, never able to settle into the ordinary faithful life of a particular congregation in a particular place, because the ordinary faithful life cannot deliver the intensity they have taught themselves to require. They are spiritual thrill-seekers, and they mistake their thrill-seeking for spiritual hunger, when in fact it is the opposite, it is a spiritual restlessness that cannot receive the very thing it claims to want, which is God, who is quietly and steadily available in the ordinary place they keep leaving in search of something more dramatic. They are looking for God everywhere except where he is, which is here, in the ordinary, in the still small voice they have trained themselves to no longer hear.

There is a deeper problem underneath, which is that the spectacular flatters the self in a way the ordinary does not. When something dramatic happens to you, when you have the powerful experience or the remarkable answer to prayer or the extraordinary sense of God's presence, it is very easy to feel that you are special, that God is doing something particular with you, that you have been singled out. The spectacular feeds the ego's hunger to be significant. And the ordinary starves that same hunger, which is exactly why the ego hates the ordinary and craves the spectacular. To accept the ordinary Christian life, the life of unremarkable daily faithfulness that looks like everyone else's, is to accept that you are not special, that God is not doing anything with you more dramatic than what he is doing with the faithful widow in the third pew, that your spiritual life is going to look ordinary because it is ordinary. This is a death to the ego, and the ego will do anything to avoid it, including dressing up its craving for significance as a hunger for God.

Now I want to be fair to the mountaintop, because I have spent this chapter being hard on it and I do not want to overcorrect into

a bloodless faith that never expects God to move at all. God does break in. There are genuine spiritual experiences, real encounters, moments when the veil thins and God is undeniably near, and these are gifts, and when they come we should receive them with gratitude and not with suspicion. The point is not that the spectacular is always false. The point is that it is not the norm, not the foundation, not the place to build. The mountaintop experience, when it is genuine, is given for the sake of the valley, as fuel for the ordinary road, as an encouragement to sustain the long obedience, and never as a place to live or a standard by which to judge the ordinary days as failures. The problem is not having the experience. The problem is needing it, building on it, requiring it, and despising the ordinary days that do not provide it.

Discernment, then, is the ability to tell the difference between the God who occasionally breaks in with the spectacular and the appetite that craves the spectacular for its own sake, and this discernment is one of the marks of a mature faith. The immature believer cannot tell the difference and chases every dramatic experience as though it were God. The mature believer receives the genuine gift when it comes but does not require it, does not build on it, does not go looking for it, and is entirely content to meet God in the still small voice, in the ordinary day, in the quiet and unremarkable faithfulness that the drama-seeker finds unbearable. Maturity is not the absence of spiritual experience. Maturity is no longer needing it, being able to rest in the ordinary presence of God without requiring the fireworks, having an appetite trained back toward the quiet where God actually lives most of the time.

So beware the spectacular, not because it is always false but because your appetite for it is almost always misleading you,

pulling your attention toward the dramatic exception and away from the ordinary rule, training you to crave an intensity that the real Christian life will rarely provide, and blaming God for the flatness that is really just the withdrawal of a drug you should never have started taking. God is in the still small voice. God is in the ordinary day. God is in the quiet faithful life that looks like nothing and makes no photograph and generates no thrill. Learn to hear him there, in the whisper, in the silence, in the ordinary, and you will have found the God that the whole restless drama-chasing world keeps missing, because they are watching the wind and the earthquake and the fire, and he is not in any of them. He is in the whisper. He has been in the whisper the whole time. Get quiet enough, ordinary enough, still enough, to finally hear it.

Chapter Twelve: Liturgies of the Ordinary

You are being formed every day by what you repeat, whether you chose it or not. The only question is what you are being formed into.

James K. A. Smith has spent his career pressing a single point until it becomes impossible to ignore, and it has changed how I understand nearly everything about the ordinary life. The point is this: you are not primarily a thinking thing that occasionally acts. You are primarily a loving thing, a desiring thing, and your loves are shaped not by what you believe but by what you repeatedly do. His book is called *You Are What You Love*, and the argument is that the deep orientation of your heart, what you actually love and long for at the level below conscious thought, is formed by the practices you repeat, the routines and rituals and habits of your ordinary daily life, which he calls liturgies. Not just the liturgy in church. The liturgy of the shopping mall. The liturgy of the smartphone. The liturgy of the morning routine. Everything you repeat is forming you, aiming your loves, shaping your heart toward some vision of the good life, whether you have chosen it or not, whether you have noticed it or not.

This lands with enormous weight once you take it seriously, and it is a deeply ordinary weight, because it means that your formation is happening not in the moments you think of as spiritual but in the ordinary repeated practices you never think about at all. You believe, perhaps, that you are formed by your

Sunday worship and your Bible reading, the explicitly religious inputs. But Smith is arguing that you are being formed far more powerfully by the things you do far more often, the thousand daily repetitions that fly below the radar of conscious reflection. If you check your phone two hundred times a day, that is a liturgy, and it is forming you, training your attention and your desire and your sense of what matters, aiming your heart, and it is doing so with a repetition that your once-a-week worship cannot possibly match. You are what you repeat. And most of us are repeating things we never chose, being formed by liturgies we never examined, becoming people we never decided to become, one ordinary unnoticed repetition at a time.

This is the most practical and the most alarming implication of the whole theology of the ordinary, so let me put it starkly. Your character is not being built in the big decisions. It is being built in the small repetitions. The person you are becoming is being determined less by your beliefs than by your habits, less by what you think than by what you do over and over without thinking. And this means that the ordinary repeated practices of your daily life, the very things you dismiss as trivial, the morning routine and the commute habit and the evening scroll and the way you spend the ordinary hours, are actually the primary machinery of your formation. They are liturgies, and they are aiming your heart, every single day, toward something. The only question, the question you cannot avoid, is what they are aiming your heart toward, because they are aiming it somewhere, and if you have not chosen the direction, someone else has, and that someone is usually a corporation that has studied precisely how to capture and shape your ordinary repeated attention for its own ends.

I have had to examine my own liturgies, and it has not been comfortable, because I discovered that many of my most

formative daily practices were forming me into someone I did not want to be. I would have told you that my deepest loves were God and my family and the good of my congregation. But my actual daily liturgies told a different story. The first thing I reached for in the morning was not prayer but the phone, which means the first liturgy of my day, the practice that set the aim of my heart before I was even fully awake, was a liturgy of anxiety and comparison and distraction. And that morning liturgy was forming me far more powerfully than the prayer I might get to later, because it came first and it came every single day and it had trained itself into my hands below the level of any decision. I was being formed, at the very start of every day, into an anxious distracted comparing person, by a practice I never chose and never examined, and no amount of right belief was going to counteract a daily liturgy aimed in the opposite direction.

The good news buried in this, and it is very good news, is that the same mechanism that forms us badly can form us well, and it works through the same ordinary means. If we are formed by what we repeat, then we can be formed toward God by repeating practices aimed at God, and these practices do not need to be dramatic, they need to be repeated. This is the whole ancient wisdom of the spiritual disciplines, which are nothing more than ordinary practices deliberately repeated to aim the heart in the right direction. Fixed times of prayer. A practice of gratitude before meals. A rhythm of Sabbath rest. The reading of Scripture at the same time each day. None of these is spectacular. Each of them is an ordinary practice, and their power lies entirely in their repetition, in the fact that done day after day after day they slowly train the loves of the heart toward God the way a bad liturgy trains them away. The disciplines are counter-liturgies, ordinary practices deployed on purpose to reshape a heart that other ordinary practices have been shaping in the wrong

direction.

Brother Lawrence understood this centuries before Smith gave it academic language, and he understood it in the most ordinary possible key. His practice of the presence of God was not a spectacular spiritual achievement. It was a habit, deliberately cultivated through endless repetition, of turning his mind toward God throughout the ordinary tasks of the day, until the turning became second nature, until the presence of God was woven into the very habit-structure of his ordinary life. He said it was a habit he had formed by long practice, that at first he had to keep recalling his mind to God, over and over, and that it had felt like failure because his mind kept wandering, but that he persisted, and that over years the practice became a habit and the habit became a settled state, so that the presence of God was as natural to him in the kitchen as breathing. He formed himself, through the deliberate repetition of an ordinary practice, into a man who lived in the presence of God. He became what he repeated. And so will you, toward God or away from him, depending entirely on what you repeat.

So examine your liturgies, which means examine the ordinary repeated practices of your actual daily life, not the spiritual practices you aspire to but the real ones you actually perform, the things you do over and over without thinking. What is the first thing you reach for in the morning? What do you do in the ordinary gaps of the day, the moments of waiting and boredom? What is the last thing you attend to before sleep? These ordinary repeated practices are your real liturgy, and they are forming your heart far more powerfully than anything you believe, and they are aiming your loves at something, and you had better find out what. Because you are being formed every single day by the ordinary things you repeat, and the formation is relentless, and it

is happening right now, and the only real question of the spiritual life may be this simple and this ordinary: what, in the small repeated practices of your daily life, are you actually training your heart to love. Change the liturgy, and over time, slowly, ordinarily, day by repeated day, you will change the love. And your loves are who you are.

Chapter Thirteen: The Sacrament of the Present Moment

God is not available in the past you are regretting or the future you are dreading. He is available only now, in the ordinary moment you keep leaving.

There is a phrase from an eighteenth-century French priest named Jean-Pierre de Caussade that has haunted me for years, and I return to it whenever I catch myself living everywhere except where I am. He wrote about the sacrament of the present moment, sometimes translated as the sacrament of the duty of the present moment, and the idea is that God comes to us not in some special holy time we must escape our ordinary lives to reach, but in this exact moment, whatever it holds, however ordinary, and that the present moment, received as from the hand of God, becomes a sacrament, a means of grace, a place of real encounter with him. De Caussade wrote in the 1730s, and his central conviction was that the whole will of God for you, the entire content of your holiness, is contained in the present moment and its ordinary duty, and that you meet God not by escaping the present into something more spiritual but by giving yourself fully to the present as it actually is.

The problem, which de Caussade saw as clearly in the 1730s as it can be seen now, is that we almost never actually inhabit the present moment. We are, most of us, almost never here. Our bodies are in the present, standing at the sink or sitting in the meeting or lying next to our spouse, but our minds are

somewhere else entirely, in the past we are replaying and regretting, or in the future we are anticipating and dreading. We live in a kind of perpetual absence from the actual moment we are in, and this is not a minor psychological quirk. It is a spiritual catastrophe, because God is not available in the past or the future. The past is gone and cannot be entered. The future does not exist and cannot be entered. There is only one place where you can actually meet God, and that is the present moment, the ordinary now, the exact moment you are in, which is precisely the moment your mind is almost never actually in. We miss God not because he is hard to find but because we are almost never where he is, which is here, now, in the ordinary present we keep abandoning for the past and the future.

I am a chronic offender, and I want to describe the disease precisely because I know it from the inside. I can be sitting with one of my sons, physically present, and be entirely absent, my mind running the accounts of the day's frustrations or planning tomorrow's obligations or rehearsing some conversation I need to have, so that my body is there and I am not, and my son is receiving the presence of a father who is not actually present, and the moment, the ordinary irreplaceable present moment of being with my child, is passing unlived, unreceived, wasted, while I am off in a past or a future that does not even exist. And the tragedy is compounded because that present moment, the one I am missing, is the only place God was offering himself to me. He was in the moment with my son. He is always in the present moment. And I was not there to meet him because I am almost never there, because I have trained myself, like most people, to live everywhere except the one place where God actually comes.

The theology here is more radical than it first appears, so let me press on it. If God is available only in the present moment, and if

the present moment is almost always ordinary, then it follows that God is available almost entirely in the ordinary, and that the practice of finding God is, to a large degree, simply the practice of being present to the ordinary moment you are actually in. This reframes the whole spiritual life. The spiritual life is not primarily about acquiring extraordinary experiences. It is about becoming present to ordinary reality, because ordinary reality, the present moment as it actually is, is where God has chosen to make himself available. To be present to the dishes is to be where God is. To be present to the child is to be where God is. To be present to the ordinary conversation, the ordinary task, the ordinary moment of an ordinary day, is to stand in the exact place where God is offering himself, and to be absent from that moment, off in the past or the future, is to miss him, not because he was hidden but because we were not there.

De Caussade uses a beautiful image, the idea of self-abandonment to divine providence, which sounds passive and is actually the opposite. It means receiving each present moment, whatever it contains, as coming from the hand of God, and giving yourself fully to it, to its ordinary duty, without straining after some other moment you would prefer. The mother receives the present moment of the crying child as from God and gives herself to it. The worker receives the present moment of the ordinary task as from God and gives himself to it. This is not passivity. It is the most active possible engagement with reality, a full-hearted presence to what actually is, as opposed to the divided, distracted, half-present way most of us move through our days, always reaching past the present moment toward some other moment we imagine would be better. The sacrament of the present moment is received by presence, by actually being here, in the ordinary now, giving yourself to it fully as the place where God has chosen to meet you.

This is desperately hard, and I do not want to pretend otherwise, because we are formed by a whole civilization to be absent from the present. The screen in your pocket is, among other things, a machine for removing you from the present moment, for pulling your attention out of the ordinary now and into an endless elsewhere, and it is extraordinarily good at it, and it has trained hundreds of millions of people into a near-permanent absence from their own lives. To be present to the ordinary moment, in a culture engineered to prevent exactly that, is now a genuine spiritual discipline, requiring real practice and real resistance. It does not come naturally anymore, if it ever did. It has to be practiced, deliberately, against the current, the way Brother Lawrence practiced recalling his wandering mind to God over and over in the kitchen until presence became a habit. Presence to the ordinary moment is a skill, and it is a skill our whole culture is arranged to destroy, and recovering it may be one of the most important spiritual tasks of our particular moment in history.

And yet the reward is everything, because the reward is your actual life, received at last instead of missed. Most of us are missing our lives. We are so rarely present to the ordinary moments that make up almost the entire substance of our existence that we are, in a real sense, absent from our own lives, living them without inhabiting them, letting the ordinary present pass unlived while we wait for some more significant moment that is always somewhere else. And the sacrament of the present moment is the way back into your own life, the practice of actually showing up for the ordinary now, receiving it as from God, giving yourself to it, and discovering that the ordinary moment you kept leaving was full of God the whole time, that he was there in the dishes and the child and the conversation and the ordinary task, offering himself, waiting for you to arrive. He is

here, now, in this ordinary present moment, the one you are in as you read this. He has always been in the present moment, because the present moment is the only place anything real ever happens, and the only place he ever comes. Be here. That is nearly the whole of it. Be here, in the ordinary now, and you will find him, because here, now, in the ordinary present, is exactly where he is.

Chapter Fourteen: Money and Work Without Idolatry

Money is a wonderful servant and a murderous god, and the difference between the two is decided in ten thousand ordinary transactions.

I want to talk about money, and I want to do it in the register of the ordinary, because money is one of the most ordinary things in the world and one of the most spiritually dangerous, and the danger lives not in the dramatic financial decisions but in the ten thousand ordinary ones. We tend to think about money spiritually only at the extremes, in the crisis of debt or the temptation of sudden wealth, and we miss the fact that our real relationship with money is being formed and revealed every ordinary day, in the small daily transactions and anxieties and desires that we never examine because they seem too ordinary to matter. But they matter enormously, because money is not neutral. Jesus said more about money than about almost anything, and he named it as a rival god, mammon, a power that competes with God for the throne of the human heart, and he said plainly that you cannot serve both. The battle between God and mammon is not fought in the dramatic moment. It is fought in the ordinary Tuesday, in how you feel about your paycheck and your neighbor's newer car and the ordinary daily arithmetic of want and worry.

Here is the strange doubleness of money that makes it so dangerous. Money is genuinely good, a real gift, a tool for love

and provision and generosity, and the Bible never pretends otherwise. The problem is not money itself but the love of money, the way this useful thing has a tendency to stop being a tool and start being a god, to move from the position of servant to the position of master, and to do so gradually, ordinarily, imperceptibly, so that most people who are enslaved to money have no idea it has happened, because it happened not in a dramatic act of worship but in a slow accumulation of ordinary daily choices, each one seemingly reasonable, that together handed the throne of the heart to a thing that was only ever meant to be a servant. Nobody decides to worship money. They just make ten thousand ordinary financial decisions, each aimed at a little more security or a little more comfort or a little more status, and one day discover, if they are honest enough to look, that money has become the thing they actually trust, the thing they actually serve, the god they actually obey.

The tell, the sign that money has moved from servant to god, is anxiety, and anxiety about money is one of the most ordinary experiences there is, which is exactly why it is such a useful diagnostic. Jesus, in the Sermon on the Mount, connects money and anxiety directly. Right after saying you cannot serve both God and money, he says therefore do not worry about your life, what you will eat or drink or wear. The therefore is crucial. The worry about ordinary provision is the fruit of serving money instead of God, because when money is your god then the amount of money you have determines your security, and since you can never have enough to be truly secure, you live in perpetual low-grade financial anxiety, an ordinary daily worry about provision that is, at its root, a spiritual condition, the anxiety of a person trusting in a god that cannot actually save them. The ordinary daily worry about money is not just a financial fact. It is a spiritual diagnosis, and it reveals, more

honestly than any stated belief, who you are actually trusting.

I have felt this anxiety, and I have felt it precisely as a man trying to provide for a wife and five sons on a pastor's salary, so I am not lecturing from a position of ease. I know the ordinary daily worry, the arithmetic that runs in the background of the mind, the way a financial pressure can seep into everything and steal the peace out of an ordinary day. And I have had to face the uncomfortable truth that my financial anxiety, however understandable, was at bottom a failure of trust, a sign that in the ordinary daily reckoning of my heart I was trusting the number in the account more than the God who fed the birds and clothed the lilies and promised to provide. The anxiety was ordinary. It was also idolatry, or at least the shadow of idolatry, the fear that belongs to serving a god who cannot save. And the cure was not more money, because more money never cures the anxiety of the person who trusts in money. The cure was the slow ordinary daily practice of trusting God for daily provision, of receiving daily bread as a gift and not white-knuckling a security I could never actually secure.

The antidote that the Scriptures prescribe is generosity, and generosity is interesting precisely because it is so ordinary and so counterintuitive, a daily practice of giving money away as a deliberate defiance of money's claim to be god. When you give money away, freely, generously, you are performing an ordinary act with an extraordinary spiritual meaning, declaring in the plainest possible terms that money is your servant and not your master, that you hold it loosely, that it does not own you. Generosity is how you break the power of mammon, not in a single dramatic gesture but in an ongoing ordinary practice of open-handedness, the regular giving that trains your heart, liturgically, to hold money loosely and to trust God freely. This is

why the biblical practice of giving is regular and proportional, woven into the ordinary rhythm of income rather than reserved for dramatic moments of charity. It is a counter-liturgy against the daily liturgy of accumulation, an ordinary repeated practice deliberately aimed at keeping money in its place as a servant and keeping God on the throne.

Work is entangled with all of this, because work is how most of us get money, and the relationship between work and money is another ordinary place where idolatry hides. Work is good, as we have already said, a way of bearing God's image and serving the neighbor. But work is easily corrupted into a way of building the tower of your own security and significance, so that you are no longer working to serve and provide but working to accumulate, working to prove yourself, working to build the financial fortress that will finally make you safe, which it never will. The ordinary daily grind of work can be worship, offered to God in service of the neighbor, or it can be idolatry, offered to mammon in service of the self, and the difference is often invisible from the outside, because the same job, the same ordinary daily labor, can be either, depending on the god it actually serves. This is why the workaholic and the faithful worker can look identical from a distance and be worlds apart in the heart, one serving God through work and the other serving money and self and the endless anxious pursuit of enough.

Wendell Berry has written with great clarity about an economy that has lost its sense of proportion, that treats accumulation as an end in itself, that has forgotten that the purpose of work and money is life and not the reverse. He insists that there is such a thing as enough, that the good life is not the life of maximum accumulation but the life of sufficiency held in gratitude, of ordinary provision received as a gift and shared with the

neighbor and not hoarded against an anxiety that no amount of hoarding can cure. This is a deeply countercultural word in an economy built on the premise that there is never enough, that you should always want more, that the ordinary sufficiency of an ordinary life is a problem to be solved by acquiring more. And it is a deeply biblical word, because the God of the Scriptures gave manna in the wilderness that could not be hoarded, that had to be received fresh each day, that taught a whole people the ordinary daily discipline of receiving enough and trusting God for tomorrow rather than accumulating against a fear that God would not provide.

So the battle over money is fought in the ordinary, in ten thousand small transactions and daily anxieties and quiet decisions about want and enough and trust, and it is won or lost not in a dramatic moment but in the slow ordinary formation of a heart that either serves money or serves God. Watch your ordinary financial life, your daily anxieties and desires, your relationship to enough, your openness or tightness of hand, because these ordinary things are telling you the truth about which god you actually serve. Practice the ordinary daily discipline of generosity, of open-handedness, of receiving your provision as a gift and holding it loosely and giving it freely, and you will slowly break the power of mammon and keep money in its place as a good servant. Money is a wonderful servant and a murderous god, and you decide which it will be not in one dramatic choice but in the ordinary daily transactions of an ordinary financial life, offered either to God or to mammon, one ordinary Tuesday at a time.

Chapter Fifteen: Rest as Trust

Sabbath is the ordinary weekly proof that the world does not depend on you, and you will resist it because you do not believe that.

God rested. Before there was any command about rest, before Sabbath was a law, there was the simple stunning fact that God himself, having made the world in six days, rested on the seventh. He did not rest because he was tired, since God does not tire. He rested to establish a rhythm, to write into the very structure of the creation a pattern of work and rest, and to model for his image-bearers a way of living that includes a regular, ordinary, recurring stop. And then he commanded it, and he built it into the Ten Commandments right alongside the prohibitions of murder and theft and adultery, which should tell us how seriously he takes it, and yet the Sabbath command is the one we break most casually, the one we have most thoroughly abandoned, the one we barely even think of as a command anymore. We would never say murder is optional. We treat rest as optional every single week.

The Sabbath is an ordinary weekly practice, and its ordinariness is the point, because it is not a dramatic once-a-year spiritual retreat but a regular recurring weekly rhythm, a stop built into the ordinary structure of the week, every week, for a lifetime. And this ordinary weekly stop turns out to be one of the most spiritually revealing practices there is, because how you handle rest tells the truth about what you believe. The reason we resist rest, the reason we find it so hard to actually stop, the reason we

fill our Sabbaths with productivity and our vacations with activity and our evenings with the endless small work of the phone, is that at the deepest level we do not believe the world will hold together without us. We believe, below the level of stated belief, that our striving is what keeps things running, that if we stop, things will fall apart, that our worth and our security depend on our ceaseless productivity. And the Sabbath exposes this unbelief with surgical precision, because to actually rest, to genuinely stop, is to confess that the world does not depend on you, that God holds it together, that you can let go, and most of us cannot let go, which reveals that we do not actually believe God holds it together at all.

I am terrible at rest, and I say this as a pastor who preaches it, which is its own kind of hypocrisy that I have had to face. I know all the theology of Sabbath and I violate it constantly, because when I actually try to stop, when I actually try to keep a Sabbath, an anxiety rises in me that I have learned to recognize as the tell. The anxiety says there is too much to do, that stopping is irresponsible, that the world needs my continued effort, and underneath the anxiety, if I trace it down, is the naked unbelief that God cannot be trusted to run things while I rest, that it all depends on me, that I am, functionally, the god of my own little world, and that a god cannot afford to rest. The difficulty I have in stopping is a direct measure of the smallness of my trust. If I truly believed that God held the world together, I could rest easily. The fact that I cannot rest easily reveals that, whatever I say I believe, I am functionally trusting myself, and the Sabbath drags this unbelief into the light every single week, which is exactly why I avoid it.

The Sabbath was given to a people who had just come out of slavery, and this is not incidental, it is the whole meaning. In

Egypt, they had been slaves, and slaves do not get to rest, because slaves are valued only for their production, and a slave who stops working is worthless to the master. To be a slave is to be defined entirely by your output, to have no worth apart from what you produce, to be driven ceaselessly with no permission to stop. And when God brought them out of slavery, one of the first things he gave them was the Sabbath, a command to rest, which was a declaration that they were no longer slaves, that their worth was no longer measured by their production, that they were free people who could stop, who were valued not for what they made but for who they were, children of God rather than units of labor. The Sabbath is the ordinary weekly proof that you are not a slave. And when we refuse to rest, when we drive ourselves ceaselessly, when we cannot stop producing, we are choosing to return to Egypt, to define ourselves by our output, to be slaves again, this time to a master we have installed in our own heads.

I think our current inability to rest is a kind of civilizational slavery, and it is deeply ordinary, woven into the texture of our daily lives so thoroughly that we cannot even see it. We are never off. The work follows us home in our pockets. The ordinary boundaries between work and rest have dissolved, so that we are perpetually available, perpetually producing, perpetually anxious, and we have lost the ordinary rhythm of the stop that God built into the creation and commanded to his people. And the cost is enormous, not just in exhaustion but in the spiritual condition of a people who never stop long enough to remember that they are not God, that the world does not depend on them, that they are free and beloved and not enslaved to their own productivity. The recovery of Sabbath, of an ordinary weekly practice of genuine rest, may be one of the most countercultural and most necessary spiritual disciplines available to us, precisely

because our culture is arranged to make it nearly impossible and precisely because we need it more than we know.

There is a deep connection between rest and trust that the whole practice depends on, and it turns the Sabbath from a burden into a gift. To rest is to trust. To stop working is to declare that God is working, that the world is in his hands and not mine, that I can let go because he will not. And this is why rest, properly understood, is not primarily a discipline of self-care or a strategy for productivity, though it produces both, but an act of faith, a weekly ordinary practice of placing the world back in God's hands and taking my own hands off it, of confessing my creatureliness and his divinity, of laying down the exhausting pretense that I am the one holding everything together. The Sabbath rest is a weekly enactment of the gospel itself, which says that salvation is God's work and not mine, that I am saved by grace and not by my ceaseless effort, that I can stop striving because Christ has done the work. The person who cannot rest is, at the deepest level, a person who has not yet believed the gospel, who is still trying to save themselves and their world by their own unrelenting effort, and the Sabbath is God's ordinary weekly invitation to stop, to trust, to rest, to believe.

So keep the Sabbath, not as a legalistic burden but as an ordinary weekly gift and an ordinary weekly act of trust, a regular recurring stop built into the rhythm of your ordinary life, in which you deliberately cease your striving and rest in the God who holds the world together without your help. It will be hard, harder than you expect, because the anxiety will rise and tell you that stopping is irresponsible, and you will have to face, in that anxiety, the smallness of your own trust and the largeness of your own functional self-worship. But push through it, week after ordinary week, and the Sabbath will slowly teach your

anxious striving heart the thing it most needs to learn, which is that you are not God, that the world does not depend on you, that you are free and beloved and held, and that you can rest, really rest, in the ordinary weekly proof that the God who made the world in six days is more than able to hold it together on the seventh while his tired child lays down the work and simply, trustingly, ordinarily, rests.

Chapter Sixteen: The Faithfulness No One Applauds

The deepest faithfulness is the kind that no one sees, and the reward for it is not applause but the approval of the only one who was watching.

There is a kind of faithfulness that gets applauded, the visible kind, the kind done in front of people, the kind that earns recognition and gratitude and the warm approval of a watching crowd. And there is another kind, the kind done where no one can see, the ordinary hidden faithfulness that will never be recognized, never be thanked, never be known, because it happens in the private and unwitnessed corners of an ordinary life. And I have come to believe that the second kind, the unapplauded kind, is the deeper and the truer, precisely because it has been stripped of every external reward and can only be sustained by love of God and love of neighbor, having no other fuel. The faithfulness that no one applauds is the faithfulness that reveals what you actually are, because it is the faithfulness you cannot possibly be performing for anyone, since no one is watching.

Jesus was blunt about this in the Sermon on the Mount, and his words cut against everything our public, performative age trains us to want. He said that when you give, do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing, so that your giving may be in secret. When you pray, go into your room and shut the door and pray to your Father who is unseen. When you fast, wash

your face and comb your hair so that no one will know, so that it will not be seen by others. Over and over he pushes the real spiritual life into the secret, the hidden, the unwitnessed, and he warns explicitly against the faithfulness done to be seen, saying that those who practice their righteousness in front of others to be seen by them have already received their reward, which is the being seen, and will receive nothing further, because the applause was the whole of it. The faithfulness done for applause is paid in applause and there the account is closed. The faithfulness done in secret is paid by the Father who sees in secret, and that account stays open into eternity.

I want to honor the unapplauded faithful ones, because I have known so many of them and they are the actual load-bearing structure of the church and the world, and almost no one ever names them. The woman who has cared for her disabled adult child for forty years, in ten thousand ordinary unwitnessed acts of love that no one will ever thank her for, whose faithfulness happens entirely offstage, whose name will never be known beyond the small circle of her ordinary life, and whose forty years of hidden love are, I am certain, more precious in the sight of God than the entire visible careers of a hundred applauded people. The man who has quietly cared for his aging parents, changed the diapers of the father who once changed his, done the unseen degrading tender ordinary work of caring for a dying parent, with no audience and no recognition, purely out of love and duty. These are the great saints, and they will never be called saints by anyone but God, and the total invisibility of their faithfulness is precisely what makes it holy.

There is a peculiar temptation in the visible life, the life of public ministry or public service or public anything, and I know it intimately because I have lived in it, and it is the temptation to

let the applause become the fuel. When you do good and are seen doing it, when you are thanked and recognized and approved, there is a pleasure in it that is not wrong in itself but that is spiritually dangerous, because it can quietly become the reason you do the good, so that without noticing you shift from doing good out of love to doing good out of a hunger for approval, and once that shift has happened your faithfulness has been hollowed out from the inside, still looking the same from the outside but rotted at the core, no longer worship but performance. And the only reliable cure for this rot is the discipline of the hidden, the deliberate practice of doing good where no one can see, of maintaining a whole realm of faithfulness that earns you nothing, that no one applauds, that keeps your love honest by keeping it secret.

The hiddenness is a gift, though it rarely feels like one, because the hiddenness is what keeps the faithfulness pure. If all your faithfulness were visible and applauded, you could never be sure whether you were being faithful out of love or out of vanity, whether you were serving God or serving your own reputation, because the two would be perfectly entangled and impossible to separate. It is the unapplauded faithfulness, the good done where no one will ever know, that answers the question, because there the vanity has nothing to feed on and the faithfulness can only be love. The mother in the night with the sick child, the caregiver in the long invisible years, the ordinary faithful worker doing the honest job that no one notices, the person who forgives in secret and prays in secret and gives in secret, these are people whose faithfulness has been purified by hiddenness, whose love has been made honest by the absence of any reward but God, and they are, whether they know it or not, among the richest people alive, storing up in secret a treasure that the applauded will never touch.

I think often of the fact that the vast majority of the faithful lives that have ever been lived are entirely unknown to history, and this is not a tragedy but a mercy and a revelation. Billions of ordinary faithful people have lived and died and been forgotten, their faithfulness recorded nowhere, their names lost, their ten thousand ordinary acts of love and duty vanished from all human memory. And if human recognition were the measure of a life's worth, these lives would be worthless, wasted, gone without a trace. But they are not worthless, because human recognition is not the measure. God is the measure, and God saw every one of them, every hidden act, every unapplauded faithfulness, every ordinary offering of love made where no human eye could see, and God does not forget, and God will not fail to reward, and the whole vast forgotten multitude of the ordinary faithful will be found, on the last day, to have been the ones who mattered most, precisely because their faithfulness was pure, being hidden, and their reward was kept, being God's.

There is a specific comfort here for anyone whose faithful life is going unrecognized, and I want to speak it directly, because our applause-hungry age makes the unrecognized life feel like a failure. If you are being faithful where no one sees, if you are pouring out love and labor that no one thanks you for, if your ordinary daily faithfulness is invisible to the world and always will be, you are not failing and you are not wasting your life. You are living the exact kind of life that Jesus most commended, the faithful life hidden from human view and seen only by the Father, and your reward is not lost, it is kept, it is safer than any applause could ever be, held by the God who sees in secret and who has promised to reward what is done in secret. The absence of applause is not the absence of witness. There is a witness. He sees every ordinary hidden act of your faithful life, and his approval, which you cannot hear now, is worth more than all the

applause you are not getting, and you will hear it, at the last, when the only voice that ever mattered says the words the whole unapplauded multitude has waited their whole hidden lives to hear.

So do not despise the unapplauded faithfulness, and do not measure your life by the recognition it receives, and do not let the hunger for applause hollow out the love that should be its only fuel. Be faithful in secret. Do the good that no one will see, care for the ones who cannot thank you, pour out the love that earns you nothing, and let the very hiddenness of it purify it into something honest and holy, fueled by love of God and not by hunger for approval. The world will not applaud you. The world does not applaud the faithfulness that matters most, because the faithfulness that matters most happens where the world cannot see. But there is one who sees in secret, one who watches the hidden faithful life with a love and an attention that no crowd could ever match, and his is the only approval that will finally matter, and it is being earned, right now, in every ordinary unapplauded act of your hidden faithful life, and it will not be lost.

Chapter Seventeen: Growing Old in the Ordinary

The final test of whether you believed in ordinary holiness is how you handle the slow ordinary losses of growing old.

Everything in this book gets tested by aging, because aging is where the ordinary becomes unavoidable and the spectacular becomes impossible, and the whole question of whether you can find God in the ordinary life you actually have comes due, at last, in the ordinary losses of growing old. When you are young, you can maintain the illusion that the real life is still ahead, that the spectacular is still coming, that the ordinary present is merely the waiting room for a more significant future. Aging strips this illusion away. Slowly, ordinarily, the future contracts, the possibilities narrow, the body declines, the drama recedes, and you are left with the ordinary present and the ordinary losses and the increasingly undeniable fact that this ordinary life, the one you have been living, is the life you were given, the only one, and there is no other coming. Aging is the final examination of whether you learned to find God in the ordinary, because in old age the ordinary is all there is.

I am not old yet, but I am no longer young, and I have watched my own parents' generation age and die, and I have sat at a great many deathbeds as a pastor, and I have learned some things about the ordinary losses of aging that I want to set down honestly. The losses are ordinary, which is what makes them so

hard, because they do not come as dramatic blows but as a slow accumulation of small subtractions, the ordinary daily diminishments that add up, over years, to the stripping away of nearly everything a person once was. The strength goes, a little at a time. The memory frays at the edges. The friends die, one ordinary funeral after another. The roles fall away, the work that gave meaning, the usefulness that gave worth, the independence that gave dignity. And it all happens ordinarily, undramatically, in the slow accumulation of ordinary losses that the aging person must somehow endure and, if they are to age well, somehow receive.

And here is where the whole theology of the ordinary is tested to its limit, because if God is only in the spectacular, in the strength and the drama and the significant achievements, then aging is nothing but a long defeat, a slow subtraction of everything that made God feel present, ending in the final ordinary loss of death. But if God is truly in the ordinary, if he is in the small and the quiet and the unremarkable, then aging, even in its losses, even in its diminishments, can be a place of his presence, perhaps the deepest place, because aging strips away all the spectacular distractions and leaves the soul alone with the ordinary God who was there the whole time. I have watched both kinds of aging. I have watched people age into bitterness, raging against the ordinary losses, unable to find any meaning in a life stripped of its drama and its strength. And I have watched people age into a luminous ordinary holiness, a deep quiet peace, a presence to the small remaining goods of an ordinary diminished life that was more beautiful than anything their younger stronger selves had ever managed.

The saints who age well have almost always been people who learned, long before, to find God in the ordinary, and this is why

the practice matters so urgently now, while you are still young enough to build it, because you are building the person who will have to age. The person who has spent a lifetime finding God only in the spectacular will have nothing when the spectacular is gone, when the body can no longer climb the mountain, when the drama is over and only the ordinary remains. But the person who has spent a lifetime finding God in the dishes and the ordinary moment and the small daily faithfulness will find, in old age, that they are richly equipped for exactly the life that aging leaves them, a life of small ordinary goods received with gratitude, a life of presence to the quiet remaining moments, a life in which God is as available in the diminished ordinary present as he ever was in the strong dramatic past. How you age is being determined right now, by whether you are learning to find God in the ordinary, because the ordinary is where you will spend the whole long ending of your life.

There is a stripping that happens in aging that the spiritual traditions have always recognized as a purification, though it is a painful one, and I have seen it do its work. The roles fall away, the achievements recede, the usefulness that we so often mistake for our worth is taken from us, and the aging person is confronted, at last, with the naked question of whether they are loved and valued apart from anything they can do or produce or achieve. This is a terrible question and a merciful one, because it is the question the Sabbath was always asking, the question of whether your worth is in your output or in your being, in what you do or in whose you are. And aging asks it inescapably, stripping away everything you might have hidden behind, leaving you to discover either that you are nothing without your usefulness, which is despair, or that you are beloved simply as a creature of God, apart from all doing, which is the deepest peace available to a human being and the fruit of a whole life spent

learning that holiness was never about achievement but about presence, ordinary presence, the being with God in the ordinary life you actually have.

I think of the ordinary deaths I have witnessed, and how much they have taught me, because death is the final ordinary event, the one thing every single human being does, the most common and the most ordinary experience there is, and also the most profound. There is nothing spectacular about most deaths. They are quiet, ordinary, undramatic, a slow letting go, a final ordinary breath. And I have seen the presence of God in those ordinary rooms more powerfully than I have ever seen it anywhere else, a peace that has nothing to do with drama, a holiness in the ordinary letting go, a sense that the God who was in the dishes and the ordinary moments of the whole long ordinary life is there, too, in the ordinary ending, gathering his ordinary faithful child home. The people who die well are almost always the people who lived well in the ordinary, who learned somewhere along the way to find God in the small and the daily, and who find him, at the last, in the smallest and most daily and most ordinary event of all, which is the ordinary human death that comes to everyone and in which, if you have eyes to see it, God is powerfully, quietly, ordinarily present.

So do not fear the ordinary losses of aging as much as you fear them, and do not build your life on the spectacular strength that aging will inevitably take from you, and do begin now, while you are young enough, to find God in the ordinary, because you are building the person who will one day be old, and the only people who age well are the people who learned to find God in the small and the quiet and the daily, long before the small and the quiet and the daily were all that was left. Growing old is the final examination of ordinary holiness, and it is an examination you

are preparing for right now, in how you handle this ordinary day, whether you are learning to meet God in it or still waiting for the spectacular that is not coming and that will one day be forever beyond your reach. Learn the ordinary now. Learn to find him in the small remaining goods, in the quiet daily faithfulness, in the ordinary present moment, because the ordinary present moment is the one thing that will be with you all the way to the end, through every ordinary loss, into the final ordinary letting go, where the God of the ordinary will be waiting, as he always was, in the last small quiet ordinary breath.

Chapter Eighteen: The Grandeur in the Common Thing

Hopkins saw God flaming out of the most ordinary matter, and the tragedy is not that the grandeur is hidden but that we have gone blind to what is shining in plain sight.

Gerard Manley Hopkins wrote the line that opens this book in 1877, and he was a strange and difficult man, a Jesuit priest who wrote poems almost no one read in his lifetime, who died at forty-four believing himself a failure, and who left behind some of the most astonishing poetry in the English language, poetry that saw the grandeur of God flaming out of the most ordinary things. The world is charged with the grandeur of God, he wrote, and the word charged is doing enormous work, because it means the world is not merely decorated with occasional signs of God but is saturated with him, loaded with him, electrified with his presence the way a wire is charged with current, so that the grandeur is not sitting on the surface of things but coursing through them, through all of them, through the most ordinary and common matter of the ordinary and common world. Hopkins did not see God only in the sunset and the mountain and the spectacular vista. He saw God in the dappled things, the freckled and the spotted and the ordinary, in the plough down the field and the tackle and trim of the workman's trade, in the most common stuff of the most ordinary world.

There is a theological word for what Hopkins saw, and it is a

word the church has always confessed but rarely lived, which is the doctrine that God is present in and through his creation, that the created world is not empty matter but is charged, sustained, upheld, and indwelt by the God who made it and who has not withdrawn from it. Every ordinary thing exists only because God is, at this moment, holding it in being, and this means that every ordinary thing is a place where the sustaining presence of God can be encountered, if only we had the eyes to see it. The grandeur is not somewhere else. It is here, in the ordinary matter of the ordinary world, in the ordinary objects and the ordinary tasks and the ordinary moments, charged with the grandeur of the God who is holding all of it in being at every instant. Hopkins saw this. Most of us are blind to it. And the tragedy is not that the grandeur is absent but that we have lost the capacity to perceive what is shining, at this very moment, in plain and ordinary sight.

Why have we gone blind? Hopkins asks this in the same poem, and his answer is as ordinary as the grandeur itself. Generations have trod, have trod, have trod, he writes, and all is seared with trade, bleared, smeared with toil. It is the ordinary daily grind, the endless repetitive labor, the wearing down of the ordinary life, that dulls our perception, that sears and blears and smears our capacity to see the grandeur that is still there. We become so habituated to the ordinary world that we stop seeing it at all. We tread the same ordinary ground so many times that we no longer perceive it, and the grandeur that is flaming out of it becomes invisible to us not because it has dimmed but because we have gone numb, worn smooth by the ordinary repetition of ordinary days, until the charged and glorious world looks to us like mere flat ordinary stuff, meaningless matter, the dull backdrop of a dull life. The blindness is ordinary. The numbness is ordinary. And it is the great enemy of ordinary holiness, because it takes

the very thing that is charged with the grandeur of God and makes it look like nothing at all.

And yet Hopkins does not end in despair, and this is the heart of the poem and the heart of this book. And for all this, he writes, nature is never spent. There lives the dearest freshness deep down things. For all the searing and blurring and smearing, for all the numbness of the ordinary grind, the grandeur is not actually diminished, the freshness is not actually spent, it is only hidden from our dulled perception, waiting, deep down in things, to be seen again by anyone whose eyes are opened. The grandeur is still there. It was never the world that went dim. It was us. And the freshness lives yet, deep down in the ordinary things, deep down in the ordinary life, ready to flame out again the moment we recover the capacity to see it, which is the whole task of the spiritual life, the recovery of sight, the waking up to the grandeur that has been charging the ordinary world the entire time we thought we were living in a flat and meaningless one.

I have had moments, not many, when the numbness lifted and I saw it, and I want to describe one, because these moments are the whole evidence that Hopkins was telling the truth. I was standing at my kitchen window early one ordinary morning, tired, holding a cup of coffee, watching the light come up over the ordinary yard, and for no reason I can name, the numbness lifted, and I saw the ordinary morning light on the ordinary grass as if for the first time, and it was charged, it was flaming with a grandeur I had walked past ten thousand times without seeing, and I understood, in my body and not just my head, that this ordinary light on this ordinary grass was full of God, had always been full of God, was a place where the grandeur was flaming out in plain sight, and that I had been blind to it every ordinary morning of my life. The moment passed, as such moments do,

and the numbness returned. But I had seen it. I knew it was there. And I have never quite been able to fully un-see it, the grandeur in the ordinary morning, the God flaming out of the ordinary light, the freshness living, still, deep down in the most ordinary things.

The recovery of sight is not primarily a matter of trying harder to see, though attention matters, but of a kind of receptivity, a willingness to be surprised by the ordinary, a refusal to let the numbness have the final word. It helps to slow down, because the numbness thrives on speed, on rushing past the ordinary world too fast to see it. It helps to pay attention, deliberately, to the ordinary things, to actually look at the light and the grass and the ordinary face across the table, as if you had never seen them before, which in a sense you never have, because you have always seen them through the film of numbness. It helps to give thanks, because gratitude is a form of attention, a way of looking at the ordinary gift long enough to actually see it. And it helps, most of all, to believe that the grandeur is really there, that Hopkins was not being fanciful but was seeing truly, that the ordinary world is genuinely charged with the grandeur of God and that your blindness to it is a defect in your sight and not a fact about the world.

This is why the ordinary is holy, at the deepest level, and why this whole book has been trying to say one thing over and over in different keys. The ordinary is holy not because we make it holy by our attitude but because it is holy, actually, in itself, charged with the grandeur of the God who made it and holds it and flames out of it, whether we see it or not. Our task is not to add holiness to the ordinary but to recover the sight that perceives the holiness that is already there. The dishes are already charged with the grandeur of God. The ordinary face across the table is

already flaming with it. The ordinary morning light is already full of it. The whole ordinary world, the world you have been treating as flat and meaningless and merely functional, is charged, at this very moment, with the grandeur of God, and the only thing standing between you and the seeing of it is the ordinary numbness that generations of ordinary treading have worn into your ordinary eyes.

So ask for the sight to be given back to you, because it is a gift and not an achievement, the sight to see the grandeur in the common thing, the freshness deep down in the ordinary, the God flaming out of the ordinary matter of your ordinary life. Slow down enough to see it. Pay attention enough to receive it. Give thanks enough to perceive it. And believe, against all the numbness, that Hopkins was telling the truth, that the world is charged with the grandeur of God, that your ordinary life is shot through with a glory you have been too numb to see, and that the recovery of that sight, the waking up to the grandeur in the common thing, is very close to the whole of what it means to find God in the life you actually have. The grandeur is here. It has always been here. It is flaming out of the ordinary world at this very moment, in plain and ordinary sight, waiting for a numb and hurried people to slow down, and look, and finally see.

Chapter Nineteen: The Practice of the Presence

To find God in the ordinary is not a feeling that comes to you. It is a practice you build, one recalled moment at a time, until presence becomes a home.

I have saved Brother Lawrence for the last full chapter, though he has been present throughout, because he is the great practical master of everything this book has tried to say, and because his method, if we can call it that, is the most ordinary and achievable thing imaginable, available to anyone, requiring nothing but the willingness to begin and the patience to keep beginning. Nicholas Herman, who took the name Brother Lawrence when he entered a Carmelite monastery in Paris in the 1640s, was a former soldier and footman, an uneducated man, a lay brother assigned to the kitchen because he was not qualified for anything more distinguished. He wrote no great treatise. What we have of him is a small collection of conversations and letters, gathered and published after his death in 1691, a slim book called *The Practice of the Presence of God*, which has outlived nearly every learned volume of its century and has taught more people to find God in the ordinary than all the theology I have ever read.

His method was almost embarrassingly simple, and its simplicity is the point, because he was showing that ordinary holiness requires no special conditions, no retreat, no dramatic experience, no advanced spiritual technique, but only an ordinary practice available in the ordinary middle of ordinary work. He

simply made a habit of turning his mind toward God throughout the day, in the midst of whatever he was doing, over and over, as often as he could remember, until the turning became second nature. That was all. He would be washing pots, and he would turn his attention to God, a brief inward acknowledgment, a moment of love, a small recollection that God was present. And then his mind would wander, as minds do, and he would notice it had wandered, and he would turn it back, without frustration, without self-recrimination, simply turning back, again and again, ten thousand times a day, until the turning back became a habit and the habit became a settled awareness and the settled awareness became the continuous sense of the presence of God in the midst of ordinary work that made him famous.

What strikes me most about his method is how honestly he described the difficulty of it, because he did not pretend it was easy or that it came to him all at once. He said that for the first ten years he suffered greatly, that his mind wandered constantly, that he often felt he was failing, that the practice seemed to produce nothing but the repeated experience of his own distraction. Ten years. This is enormously encouraging to me, because it means that the great master of the practice of the presence was, for a full decade, mostly experiencing the failure of the practice, the endless wandering of the mind, the constant need to begin again. He did not have a special gift for presence. He had a stubborn willingness to keep turning back, over and over, through ten years of apparent failure, until the practice finally became a habit and the habit finally bore fruit. The fruit came not from a dramatic experience but from ten years of ordinary faithful repetition, which is exactly the pattern this whole book has been describing, the long obedience, the slow formation, the ordinary practice repeated until it becomes who you are.

The genius of his approach, if I can name it, was that he refused to separate the spiritual life from the ordinary work, and this is the exact thing most of us cannot manage. We think of prayer as something we do in a special time, set apart from the ordinary work, and so we experience a perpetual frustration that we cannot pray as much as we think we should, because the ordinary work keeps crowding out the prayer. Brother Lawrence dissolved the whole problem by refusing the separation. He did not stop his work to pray. He prayed in and through his work, turning to God in the midst of the pots and pans, so that the work itself became the occasion of the prayer rather than its rival. He said that the time of business did not differ with him from the time of prayer, that he possessed God in as great tranquility in the noise and clatter of his kitchen as if he had been on his knees before the sacrament. He had achieved what the rest of us keep failing to achieve, the integration of the ordinary work and the presence of God into a single continuous life, so that there was no longer a sacred time and a secular time but only the one ordinary life lived continuously in the presence of God.

I have tried to practice what he taught, and I want to be honest about how it goes, because I am not going to end this book pretending to a mastery I have not achieved. It goes the way he said it would go at the beginning, which is to say badly, with constant wandering, with the repeated experience of forgetting God for hours at a stretch and then remembering with a start that I had meant to be practicing his presence. I turn to God at the sink, and within thirty seconds I am off replaying a grievance or planning a task, and then some while later I notice I have wandered, and I turn back, and it wanders again. This is the practice. This is exactly the practice. The practice is not the achievement of continuous presence. The practice is the ten thousand returns, the endless turning back, the refusal to give up

despite the constant wandering, in the confidence that the returns are slowly building a habit, the way water slowly wears a channel in stone, and that one day, perhaps after my own ten years, the presence that now requires constant effortful returning will have become a settled home. I am not there. But I am practicing, which is the only thing Brother Lawrence ever asked of anyone.

There is a deep theology under the simple practice, and it is worth naming, because it is the theology that makes the practice more than a technique. The practice of the presence rests on the conviction that God is already present, always, everywhere, at every moment, in every ordinary task and place. We are not summoning a God who is absent. We are waking up to a God who is already here, turning our attention toward a presence that never left, remembering a companionship that was always the case. The practice does not make God present. It makes us present to the God who was present the whole time. This is why it can be done in the midst of ordinary work, because God is already in the ordinary work, and the practice is simply the ongoing recollection of what is already true, the repeated turning of attention toward a presence that is the most solid fact in the universe and the one we are most constantly forgetting. Ordinary holiness is not the achievement of a special state. It is the ongoing practice of remembering the ordinary omnipresent God, in the midst of the ordinary life, over and over, until the remembering becomes a home.

So begin the practice, wherever you are, in the middle of whatever ordinary work is in front of you, and begin it without expecting it to be easy or to produce quick results, because it will be hard and it will be slow, and that is not a sign that you are doing it wrong but a sign that you are doing it at all. Turn your

attention to God, briefly, in the midst of the ordinary task. Notice, without frustration, when your mind wanders, and turn it back. Do this ten thousand times. Do it for years. Do it through the long stretches when it seems to produce nothing but the experience of your own distraction, in the confidence that the ordinary faithful repetition is slowly building a habit, and that the habit is slowly becoming a home, and that one ordinary day you will notice that the presence you have been effortfully practicing has become a settled companionship, a continuous ordinary awareness of the God who was always there, in the kitchen, in the ordinary work, in the ordinary life you actually have. This is the practice of the presence of God. It is the most ordinary spiritual practice there is, and the most profound, and it is available to you right now, in the ordinary moment you are in, if you will simply turn, and turn again, and keep turning, toward the God who has been present in the ordinary the whole time.

Chapter Twenty: The Ordinary Congregation

The church you keep wishing you had is a fantasy. The church you actually have, ordinary and disappointing and real, is the one God gave you to be sanctified in.

I have spent fifteen years as a pastor of an ordinary congregation, First Baptist Church of Fenton, in an ordinary town in Michigan, and I want to say some things about the ordinary church that I could only have learned by staying in one long enough to stop romanticizing it. The ordinary congregation is not the church of your imagination. It is not the vibrant, growing, exciting community of your conference dreams. It is a collection of ordinary, flawed, often difficult people, gathered by no choice of their own into a shared life they did not design, and it is disappointing in exactly the way that all ordinary things are disappointing, which is to say it fails to be the spectacular thing you wanted and turns out to be the ordinary thing you were given. And I have come to believe that the ordinary disappointing real congregation is one of the primary instruments of God's work in a Christian's life, precisely because it is ordinary and disappointing and real, and precisely because you did not get to design it.

There is an epidemic of church-shopping and church-hopping in our time, and it is driven, I think, by the same addiction to the spectacular that this whole book has been diagnosing. People go looking for the perfect church, the exciting church, the church

that meets their needs and matches their preferences and delivers the spiritual experience they are after, and when the church they are in turns out to be ordinary, when it fails to be spectacular, when it disappoints them as all ordinary human communities eventually disappoint, they leave and go looking for a better one, and they never find it, because it does not exist, because every church is an ordinary community of ordinary flawed people, and the perfect church is a fantasy that will keep them forever moving and never rooted. Dietrich Bonhoeffer wrote, in his book on Christian community in 1939, that the person who loves their dream of community will destroy community, but the person who loves the people around them will build it. He saw that the fantasy of the ideal church is the enemy of the real church, that we must let go of our dream of what the community should be in order to receive the ordinary reality of what it actually is.

The ordinary congregation sanctifies you in ways the church of your dreams never could, and it does so precisely through its disappointments, its ordinariness, its collection of difficult people you did not choose. Because in the ordinary congregation you cannot curate your community. You are thrown together with people you would never have selected, people whose politics and personalities and preferences grate against yours, people who will disappoint you and be disappointed by you, and you are asked to love them, to serve them, to bear with them, to forgive them, over a long time, in the ordinary shared life of an ordinary church. And this ordinary, unglamorous, often frustrating work of loving the ordinary people God actually put in your congregation is the very stuff of sanctification, the exact laboratory in which God forms you into someone capable of the love he commanded, which was never a love for the ideal community of your imagination but a love for the ordinary flawed real people in front of you.

I think of the ordinary saints in my own congregation, and I mean the word saints seriously, the ordinary faithful people who have shaped me more than any book or conference. There is an elderly woman who has sat in the same pew for decades, who has buried a husband and two of her own children, who has never done anything the world would notice, and whose ordinary faithful presence, week after week, decade after decade, has been a kind of quiet sermon that has preached to me more powerfully than anything I have ever preached to anyone. There is a man of no education and less eloquence whose ordinary practical love, whose willingness to show up and fix things and help people and ask for nothing, has taught me more about the gospel than my seminary did. These are ordinary people in an ordinary church, and they are the actual treasure, the real riches, the saints hidden in plain sight in every ordinary congregation, invisible to a church culture obsessed with the spectacular and precious beyond measure to a God who has always done his best work through the ordinary and the overlooked.

The ordinary rhythms of congregational life are a liturgy, in the sense we have already discussed, an ordinary repeated practice that forms the heart over time. The gathering, week after week, in the same ordinary room, with the same ordinary people, to do the same ordinary things, to sing and pray and hear the Scriptures and share the bread and the cup, is not the dull backdrop to a spiritual life that happens elsewhere. It is a formative practice of enormous power, precisely because of its ordinariness and its repetition. The person who gathers with the ordinary congregation week after week for decades is being formed by that gathering in ways far deeper than any dramatic spiritual experience could form them, having their loves slowly aimed, their heart slowly shaped, their character slowly built by the ordinary repeated liturgy of the ordinary congregation. This

is why the ordinary discipline of simply showing up, week after week, to the ordinary church, is so much more important than it appears, because the showing up is the formation, the ordinary repeated gathering is the slow shaping of a soul.

I want to speak to the person who is disillusioned with the church, because there are many of you, and your disillusionment is often justified, and I am not going to pretend the church has not earned much of it. The church is full of hypocrisy and failure and disappointment, because the church is full of ordinary sinful people, and I am one of them, a pastor who has failed his congregation in more ways than I can count. But the answer to the disappointing ordinary church is not to abandon it in search of a better one, which does not exist, and it is not to give up on the church altogether, which is to give up on the ordinary community that God has chosen as the primary instrument of his work in the world. The answer is to let go of the fantasy of the ideal church and to love the ordinary real one, disappointments and all, to root yourself in an ordinary congregation and to stay, through the disappointments, through the ordinariness, through the long unglamorous years, in the confidence that God works through the ordinary church precisely because it is ordinary, and that the sanctification you are looking for is available not in the fantasy but in the ordinary real community you keep being tempted to leave.

Bonhoeffer understood, writing from inside a church that was failing catastrophically to resist evil in his own country and time, that Christian community is not primarily an ideal to be achieved but a reality to be received, a gift given by God in the ordinary form of ordinary people gathered by grace. He wrote that we enter into that common life not as demanders but as thankful recipients, receiving the ordinary community God gives rather

than demanding the ideal community we imagine. And this is the whole posture that the ordinary congregation requires and rewards, the posture of the thankful recipient rather than the disappointed demander, the posture of someone who has let go of the dream of the perfect church in order to receive, with gratitude, the ordinary real church that God has actually given, with all its ordinary faults and ordinary saints and ordinary means of grace.

So love the ordinary church, the real one, the disappointing one, the one you actually have rather than the one you keep wishing for. Root yourself in an ordinary congregation and stay, through the ordinariness and the disappointment and the long unglamorous years, and let the ordinary rhythms of ordinary congregational life form you, and let the ordinary difficult people God has put around you sanctify you, and let go of the fantasy of the ideal church that is keeping you forever restless and never rooted. Because the church of your dreams is a fantasy that will destroy your capacity for real community, and the ordinary church in front of you, flawed and disappointing and real, is the actual gift of God, the actual body of Christ, the actual laboratory of your sanctification, and the actual place where, week after ordinary week, in the ordinary gathering of ordinary people, the God of the ordinary is quietly, faithfully, unspectacularly at work, forming a people for himself out of the ordinary material of ordinary lives, which is the only material he has ever used, and the only material he has ever needed.

Chapter Twenty-One: Ordinary Time

The church invented a name for the long stretches when nothing spectacular happens, and called them Ordinary Time, and treated them as holy, and they were right.

The historic church calendar has a category that our spectacular-hungry age can barely comprehend, and it is called Ordinary Time. It refers to the long stretches of the church year that fall outside the great festival seasons, the weeks that are not Advent or Christmas or Lent or Easter or Pentecost, the ordinary weeks that make up the bulk of the year, when nothing dramatic is being celebrated, when the church is simply living its ordinary life in the ordinary rhythm of ordinary weeks. And the genius of the church calendar, the thing our age has lost, is that it gave these ordinary stretches a name and a color and a status, treating them not as the empty spaces between the important seasons but as a season in their own right, a holy time, Ordinary Time, in which the ordinary Christian life is lived out in the ordinary weeks with an ordinary faithfulness that is every bit as holy as the great festivals, and considerably more sustaining.

The name itself is a small theological masterpiece, because it takes the very word we use to dismiss things, ordinary, and applies it to a large portion of the sacred year, declaring that the ordinary is not the absence of the holy but a form of it, that the ordinary weeks when nothing spectacular happens are

themselves a category of sacred time, worthy of their own name and their own attention. This is exactly the reversal that this whole book has been arguing for, and it turns out the church built it into the calendar centuries ago, a standing witness against the addiction to the spectacular, a liturgical insistence that most of the sacred year, like most of life, is ordinary, and that the ordinary is where the ordinary Christian actually lives, and that the ordinary is holy. Most of the year is Ordinary Time. Most of life is ordinary time. And the calendar, wiser than we are, treats both as sacred.

There is a particular grace in a calendar that includes long ordinary stretches, because it trains the soul in exactly the endurance that ordinary life requires. The great festivals are wonderful, but they are the mountaintops of the church year, the spectacular high points, and a spirituality built only on them would collapse the way any spirituality built only on the spectacular collapses. The genius of Ordinary Time is that it teaches the soul to sustain its faith through the long ordinary stretches when there is no festival, no high point, no drama, just the ordinary weeks passing one after another, and it teaches that these ordinary weeks are not a falling-away from the real spiritual life but are themselves the real spiritual life, the long ordinary faithful walk that makes up the bulk of the Christian existence. The church that observes Ordinary Time is being trained, year after year, in the endurance of the ordinary, in the finding of God in the long undramatic stretches, in the holiness of the ordinary week, which is exactly the training that our spectacular-addicted age most desperately needs and most completely lacks.

I did not grow up with the church calendar, and I came to appreciate it slowly, as an adult, as a pastor who found in it a

wisdom that my more spontaneous tradition had lost. And what I have come to love most about it is precisely Ordinary Time, the long green weeks after Pentecost, the ordinary stretches when the great story has been told and the church settles into the ordinary work of living it out. There is a rhythm in it that answers something deep in the shape of an actual human life, which is also mostly ordinary time, mostly long green ordinary stretches between the few great festivals of birth and marriage and death. To have a calendar that honors the ordinary stretches, that names them holy, that treats the long undramatic weeks as sacred, is to have a framework that fits the actual shape of a human life and that trains the soul to find God in the ordinary weeks rather than despising them as the empty spaces between the important days.

Kathleen Norris, who has written beautifully about the monastic observance of time, notes how the ordinary daily and weekly rhythms of the monastery, the same prayers at the same hours, the ordinary round of ordinary days, produce not boredom but a kind of deep spiritual stability, a groundedness that the restless spectacular-seeking soul never finds. She observes that the monks are not bored by the repetition of their ordinary rounds but are somehow freed by it, that the very ordinariness and predictability of their days, far from deadening them, creates a stable ground on which the soul can rest and grow. This is the opposite of what our culture believes about the ordinary and the repetitive, which is that they are deadening and must be escaped through novelty and stimulation. The monastic wisdom, and the wisdom of Ordinary Time, is that the ordinary repeated rhythm is not the enemy of spiritual life but its stable ground, that the soul grows best not in the excitement of constant novelty but in the stability of ordinary repeated faithfulness.

I want to press on the way our culture is arranged against Ordinary Time, because it goes deep and it does real damage. We are a people addicted to novelty and stimulation, formed by an entertainment economy that must constantly escalate to hold our attention, trained to experience the ordinary and the repetitive as unbearable and to require an endless stream of new and exciting inputs. And this formation is catastrophic for the spiritual life, because the spiritual life is lived largely in Ordinary Time, in the long ordinary stretches, in the repeated ordinary practices, in the undramatic faithfulness of ordinary weeks, and a soul trained to require constant novelty and stimulation cannot endure the ordinary stretches where God actually does most of his work. We have been formed to be unable to bear the very thing the spiritual life requires, which is the patient endurance of Ordinary Time, and the recovery of the capacity to find God and rest in the ordinary stretches may be one of the hardest and most necessary spiritual tasks of our particular moment.

The deep lesson of Ordinary Time is that God is as present in the ordinary weeks as in the great festivals, that he does not withdraw during the long green stretches and return only for Christmas and Easter, that the ordinary undramatic weeks are as full of his presence and his work as the spectacular high points, if only we have the eyes to see it and the patience to endure the ordinary. This is the whole thesis of this book, written into the ancient rhythm of the church calendar, a standing liturgical witness that the ordinary is holy, that most of the sacred year is ordinary, that most of life is ordinary, and that God is powerfully and faithfully present in the ordinary the whole time, through all the long green undramatic weeks when nothing spectacular happens and the ordinary Christian simply lives out the ordinary faithful life in the ordinary presence of the ordinary God who is anything but ordinary in his faithfulness to the ordinary.

So learn to love Ordinary Time, both the season in the calendar and the long ordinary stretches of your own actual life, and stop treating the ordinary weeks as the empty spaces between the important ones. Let the ancient wisdom of the church, which named the ordinary weeks holy and gave them their own place in the sacred year, teach you to find God in the ordinary stretches of your own life, in the long green undramatic weeks when nothing spectacular happens and the ordinary faithful life is simply lived out in the ordinary presence of God. Most of your life will be Ordinary Time. Most of it already has been. And the church was right to call it holy, because it is holy, charged with the grandeur of God like everything else, sustained by his presence like everything else, a sacred season in its own right, the long ordinary green stretch where the ordinary Christian lives out an ordinary holiness in the ordinary weeks of an ordinary life that God has never once considered ordinary at all.

Chapter Twenty-Two: Forgiveness on a Tuesday

Grand forgiveness makes the movies. Ordinary forgiveness, the daily releasing of the small debts, is what actually keeps a life from turning to stone.

We think of forgiveness as a dramatic event, a great reconciliation, the tearful embrace after the terrible wrong, and those moments are real and they matter, and I do not want to diminish them. But the forgiveness that actually determines the quality of a human life is not the grand and dramatic kind. It is the ordinary kind, the daily releasing of the small debts, the ten thousand minor offenses that pass between people who live and work in close proximity, the constant low-grade need to let go of the irritation and the slight and the ordinary hurt that accumulate in any ordinary shared life. This ordinary daily forgiveness is far more important than the dramatic kind, because it is far more constant, required not once in a decade but many times a day, and because the failure to practice it does not produce a dramatic estrangement but something quieter and more deadly, a slow hardening, a gradual turning to stone, an accumulation of unreleased small resentments that petrifies the heart over time.

Peter came to Jesus with a question about the mathematics of forgiveness, asking how many times he had to forgive his brother, suggesting seven times as a generous limit, and Jesus answered with the famous seventy times seven, which was not a precise number but a way of saying that forgiveness is not

something you do a fixed number of times and then finish, but something you do continuously, endlessly, as a way of life, as an ordinary daily practice with no upper limit. And notice that the context is the brother, the person in close ongoing relationship, the one you live near and see constantly, because it is precisely in the close ongoing ordinary relationships that the constant forgiveness is required, where the small offenses accumulate daily and the choice to release them or hold them is made many times a day. Jesus was not describing a rare dramatic act of forgiveness for a terrible wrong. He was describing an ordinary daily practice of endless releasing, the constant letting go of the small ordinary debts that accumulate between people in close ordinary life.

I have watched what the failure of ordinary forgiveness does to a marriage, and it is not usually a dramatic betrayal that destroys a marriage but the slow accumulation of unforgiven small offenses, the record of wrongs that Paul specifically said love does not keep, the petrifying buildup of ten thousand tiny resentments that were never released and that harden, over years, into a wall of accumulated grievance that finally cannot be scaled. No single offense in that accumulation was large enough to matter. The problem was that none of them were released, that each small ordinary hurt was added to the account rather than forgiven, until the account grew so large that the relationship collapsed under the weight of it, not from one great unforgivable wrong but from a thousand small ones that were never let go. This is why the ordinary daily practice of forgiveness, the constant releasing of the small debts, is so much more important than it appears, because the failure to practice it does not announce itself dramatically but works quietly, over years, hardening the heart and building the wall one small unforgiven offense at a time.

There is a phrase in the prayer that Jesus taught us to pray, an ordinary daily prayer meant to be prayed every ordinary day, and it makes forgiveness a daily petition alongside the request for daily bread. Forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors. Notice that it is placed among the ordinary daily needs, right beside the daily bread, as though the daily practice of forgiveness were as basic and as constant a need as the daily need for food, which it is. We need to forgive daily the way we need to eat daily, because the small debts accumulate daily the way hunger returns daily, and the prayer builds this ordinary daily practice right into the ordinary daily rhythm of the Christian life. And it makes the sobering connection that our own receiving of forgiveness is somehow bound up with our practice of it, that the unforgiving heart cannot receive the forgiveness it withholds, that the daily practice of releasing the small debts of others is the very condition of the daily receiving of the release of our own far larger debt.

I have had to practice this in my own ordinary daily life, and I want to be honest that I am not naturally good at it, that my instinct is to keep the account, to remember the slight, to nurse the small resentment, to add the ordinary daily offense to a running total that I carry around and consult when I want to justify my coldness. And I have had to learn, slowly and against my nature, the ordinary daily discipline of releasing the small debts, of noticing the resentment before it hardens and letting it go, of refusing to keep the record, of forgiving the ordinary offense not as a grand dramatic gesture but as a quiet daily practice performed many times a day in the ordinary friction of ordinary shared life. It does not feel dramatic. It does not feel spiritual. It feels like the small ordinary swallowing of a small ordinary grievance, over and over, for the sake of a relationship and for the health of my own hardening heart. But it is one of the

most important spiritual practices there is, this ordinary daily forgiveness, because it is the practice that keeps the heart from turning to stone.

The stakes of this are higher than the ordinariness of the practice suggests, because the alternative to the ordinary daily practice of forgiveness is not a neutral state but an active hardening, a progressive petrification of the heart that unforgiveness produces as surely and as quietly as water produces stone. The person who does not practice ordinary daily forgiveness, who keeps the record of small wrongs, who nurses the ordinary resentments, is not merely failing to do a good thing but is actively becoming a worse thing, harder, colder, more bitter, more walled-off, as the accumulated unreleased resentment slowly turns the living heart to stone. Bitterness is not a static condition. It grows. And it grows precisely through the ordinary daily failure to release the ordinary daily debts, so that the choice to forgive or not to forgive in the small ordinary moments is, over time, the choice between a heart that stays soft and alive and a heart that hardens into stone, and this choice is made not once in a great dramatic moment but constantly, daily, in the ordinary friction of ordinary life.

There is a freedom in ordinary daily forgiveness that the unforgiving heart never knows, and it is worth naming, because forgiveness is often presented as a burden and a cost when it is at least equally a gift and a liberation. To forgive the small ordinary debt is to be freed from carrying it, to set down the weight of the resentment, to be released from the exhausting labor of maintaining the account. The unforgiving heart is not free. It is bound to the offense it will not release, chained to the person it will not forgive, carrying a weight that grows heavier with each unforgiven addition to the account. And the ordinary daily

practice of forgiveness is, among other things, the practice of freedom, the daily setting down of the weights that would otherwise accumulate and crush, the daily release that keeps the heart light and soft and free rather than heavy and hard and bound. When Jesus commanded endless forgiveness, he was not only commanding an ordinary daily kindness toward others. He was prescribing an ordinary daily freedom for ourselves, the freedom of a heart that refuses to carry the accumulating weight of unforgiven ordinary debts.

So practice ordinary forgiveness, the daily releasing of the small debts, the constant letting go of the ordinary offenses that accumulate in any ordinary shared life, and do not wait for the dramatic occasions of grand reconciliation to think you are practicing forgiveness, because the forgiveness that actually determines the quality of your life and the softness of your heart is the ordinary daily kind, performed many times a day in the ordinary friction of ordinary relationships. Release the small debt. Refuse to keep the record. Forgive the ordinary offense before it hardens, and forgive it again, and again, seventy times seven, without limit, as an ordinary daily practice woven into the ordinary rhythm of your ordinary life. It will not feel dramatic. It will not make a photograph or a testimony. But it will keep your heart from turning to stone, and it will keep your relationships from collapsing under the accumulated weight of a thousand unforgiven small wrongs, and it will keep you free, and it is, in the ordinary daily grind of an ordinary life, one of the truest and hardest and most necessary forms of the ordinary holiness that this whole book has been trying to describe.

Chapter Twenty-Three: The Ordinary Means of Grace

God chose to feed us not with lightning but with bread and water and words, the most ordinary things, delivered in the most ordinary ways, again and again.

There is a phrase from the older theological tradition that has grown very dear to me, the ordinary means of grace, and it names something that our spectacular age has almost entirely forgotten. The idea is that God has chosen to give his grace to us, ordinarily, through ordinary means, through the reading and hearing of the Scriptures, through the ordinary practice of prayer, through the sacraments of baptism and the Lord's Supper, through the ordinary gathering of the ordinary church. Not through lightning. Not through spectacular experiences. Not through dramatic mystical encounters, which may occasionally come but which are not the ordinary way. God feeds his people, ordinarily, through the most ordinary things, bread and wine and water and words, delivered in the most ordinary ways, repeated again and again over the ordinary course of an ordinary Christian life. The means of grace are ordinary, and their ordinariness is not a limitation but a mercy, because it makes the grace of God reliably available to ordinary people in the ordinary practices of ordinary life.

I want to press on how countercultural this is, because we are formed to want the extraordinary means, the dramatic encounter, the spectacular experience, and we tend to regard the ordinary

means of grace as dull, as beneath us, as the boring basics that we should have moved past by now on our way to something more advanced and more thrilling. And this is a serious error, because there is nothing more advanced than the ordinary means of grace, nothing to move past, nothing more thrilling waiting on the other side of the boring basics. The ordinary means of grace are the whole thing, the actual mechanism by which God feeds and forms his people, and the mature Christian is not the one who has moved beyond them to some spectacular advanced spirituality but the one who has learned to receive them more deeply, who has discovered that the ordinary reading of the ordinary Scriptures and the ordinary practice of ordinary prayer and the ordinary sharing of the ordinary bread and cup are inexhaustibly deep, endlessly nourishing, the very food of the soul, available in the most ordinary form to the most ordinary people every ordinary day.

Consider the reading and hearing of the Scriptures, which is the most ordinary of practices and the most profound. There is nothing spectacular about it. You open an ordinary book and read ordinary words, or you sit in an ordinary room and hear them read, and it looks like nothing, like the most ordinary thing in the world. And yet the tradition has always insisted, and I have found it to be true, that in this most ordinary of practices God speaks, that through the ordinary words on the ordinary page the living God addresses his people, feeds them, forms them, meets them, so that the ordinary daily reading of the ordinary Scriptures is not a dull religious duty but a place of real encounter with the living God, delivered in the most ordinary form, available to anyone who will do the most ordinary thing of reading the words. The person who reads the Scriptures daily, ordinarily, over a lifetime, is being fed and formed by God through the ordinary means, whether or not any given reading

feels spectacular, because the grace comes through the ordinary practice and not through the feeling.

Consider prayer, which is likewise the most ordinary of practices, the simple ordinary act of speaking to God and listening for him, available anywhere, requiring nothing, performed in the most ordinary moments of the most ordinary days. There is nothing spectacular about ordinary prayer, the ordinary daily conversation with God carried on in the ordinary moments, and yet it is one of the primary means through which God gives his grace, forms his people, changes their hearts, aligns their wills with his. And the ordinary Christian does not need a spectacular experience of prayer, some dramatic mystical encounter, in order to be fed by prayer, because the grace comes through the ordinary practice, the ordinary daily faithful speaking and listening, whether or not any given prayer feels spectacular. Brother Lawrence's whole practice was nothing more than ordinary prayer extended into the ordinary work, the ordinary turning of the mind to God throughout the ordinary day, and it made him one of the great masters of the spiritual life, through the ordinary means, faithfully practiced over ordinary years.

Consider the sacraments, the bread and the wine and the water, which take the most ordinary physical things and make them the vehicles of grace, and which therefore stand as a permanent testimony to the whole principle of the ordinary means. God did not choose to convey the grace of the Lord's Supper through some spectacular substance but through bread and wine, the most ordinary food and drink, the ordinary stuff of an ordinary meal. He did not choose to convey the grace of baptism through some rare and precious element but through water, the most ordinary and abundant substance on earth. This is not incidental. It is the

whole logic of the incarnation extended into the ongoing life of the church, the God who took on ordinary flesh continuing to meet his people through ordinary matter, through bread and wine and water, through the most ordinary things, so that the sacraments themselves preach the sermon that this whole book has been preaching, that God comes to us in the ordinary, that grace is delivered through ordinary means, that the holy is found not in the rare and spectacular but in the ordinary and abundant and near.

I have come to believe that the health of a Christian life is measured less by the dramatic experiences it has accumulated than by its faithfulness to the ordinary means of grace over the long haul, and this is a deeply unglamorous thing to believe in an age addicted to spiritual drama. The Christian who has learned to receive the ordinary means of grace faithfully, day after day, year after year, who reads the Scriptures and prays and gathers with the church and shares the bread and cup, not because it is thrilling but because it is the ordained food of the soul, is being fed and formed by God in the deepest and most reliable way, whether or not their life is punctuated by dramatic spiritual experiences. And the Christian who despises the ordinary means in search of the spectacular, who cannot be nourished by the ordinary reading and the ordinary prayer and the ordinary sacrament because they are hungry for something more dramatic, is starving in the midst of abundance, refusing the ordinary bread that God has actually provided in search of a spectacular feast that he has not promised and does not usually give.

There is a great mercy in the ordinariness of the means of grace, and I want to end this chapter by naming it, because it is one of the most encouraging truths in the whole Christian life. Because the means of grace are ordinary, they are available to everyone,

always, in every ordinary circumstance, requiring no special conditions, no spectacular experiences, no advanced spiritual attainments. The ordinary Christian in the ordinary circumstances of an ordinary life has full and complete access to the grace of God through the ordinary means, the same access as the greatest saint, because the means are ordinary and the grace comes through the means and not through the drama. The tired mother who reads a few verses and prays a few ordinary words in the exhausted margins of her ordinary day has access to the same grace, through the same ordinary means, as any spiritual master, because God has chosen to convey his grace through ordinary things precisely so that it would be available to ordinary people in ordinary lives. The ordinariness of the means is the accessibility of the grace.

So do not despise the ordinary means of grace, and do not go searching for some spectacular spirituality beyond them, because there is nothing beyond them, and they are the whole thing, the actual food of the soul, the ordained way that God feeds and forms his people. Read the Scriptures, ordinarily, daily, over a lifetime, and let God feed you through the ordinary words. Pray, ordinarily, in the ordinary moments, and let God meet you through the ordinary practice. Gather with the ordinary church and share the ordinary bread and cup, and let God convey his grace through the most ordinary matter. Be faithful to the ordinary means of grace over the long ordinary haul of an ordinary Christian life, and you will be fed and formed and held by God in the deepest and most reliable way, through the most ordinary things, delivered in the most ordinary ways, again and again, for as long as you live, which is exactly how the God of the ordinary has always chosen to feed his ordinary people, not with lightning but with bread.

Chapter Twenty-Four: The Commute and the In-Between

We treat the transitions as dead time, the space between the real moments, and in doing so we throw away a third of our waking lives.

There is a category of ordinary time that we do not even dignify with the name ordinary, because we consider it beneath ordinary, and that is the in-between, the transitional time, the commute and the waiting room and the checkout line and the drive to the store and all the countless minutes we spend getting from one thing to another. We treat this time as pure dead time, as nothing, as the empty non-space between the real moments of our lives, and we fill it, increasingly, with the phone, with distraction, with anything that will make the emptiness of it disappear. And I want to suggest that this in-between time, which adds up to an enormous portion of our waking lives, is not dead time at all, that it is ordinary time in its purest form, and that our habit of throwing it away, of filling it with distraction, of treating it as nothing, is one of the great wastes of the modern life and one of the great missed opportunities of the spiritual life.

Think about how much of your life is transition. The commute to work and home again, which for many people is a substantial part of every day. The drive to run the ordinary errands. The waiting, in lines and rooms and lobbies, for the ordinary appointments and services of ordinary life. The walk from the car to the building and back. The countless small transitions

from one activity to another that punctuate every ordinary day. Added up over a lifetime, this in-between time is not a marginal quantity. It is a large fraction of your waking existence, and how you spend it, what you do with these ordinary transitional minutes, is not a small question but a large one, because it concerns a large portion of your actual life. And most of us have decided, without ever deciding, that this time is worthless, to be gotten through, to be filled with whatever distraction is at hand, to be endured rather than lived.

The great new fact of our particular moment is that the in-between time has been colonized, completely, by the screen, and this colonization has consequences that we have barely begun to reckon with. There was a time, not long ago, when the in-between time was empty, when you stood in the line or sat in the waiting room or rode the train with nothing to do but be there, to look around, to think, to notice, to be present to the ordinary moment or to let your mind wander where it would. And that empty in-between time, though we experienced it as boredom, was doing something valuable for us, giving the mind room to breathe, to process, to wander, to rest, creating a space in which thoughts could surface and prayers could form and the ordinary world could be noticed. And we have filled all of it, every scrap of it, with the screen, so that there is no more empty in-between time, no more room for the mind to breathe, no more space in which prayers can form and the ordinary world can be noticed, and we do not even miss it, because we do not remember what it was for.

I want to make a case for reclaiming the in-between time as ordinary sacred time, and I want to root it in the practice of Brother Lawrence, who found God not in the important moments but in the ordinary transitions and tasks that filled his ordinary

day. Because if God is available in the ordinary moment, then he is available in the ordinary in-between moment, in the commute and the waiting and the transition, exactly as much as in any other ordinary moment, and the in-between time, far from being dead time, is full of the same presence of God that fills all ordinary time, waiting to be noticed by anyone who will stop filling it with distraction long enough to be present in it. The commute can be a time of prayer, of the ordinary turning of the mind to God that Brother Lawrence practiced in the kitchen. The waiting room can be a place of ordinary presence, of noticing the ordinary world and the ordinary people and the ordinary presence of God among them. The in-between time, reclaimed from distraction, can become some of the richest ordinary sacred time in a life, precisely because it is time that would otherwise be wasted, redeemed and filled with the presence of God.

I have tried to practice this, imperfectly, in my own commute, and I want to describe both the difficulty and the reward. The difficulty is the pull of the phone, the almost physical craving to fill the empty in-between time with distraction, the discomfort of the unfilled moment that our formation has made nearly unbearable. To drive without the podcast, to wait without the scroll, to let the in-between time be empty and present rather than filled and distracted, is genuinely hard, harder than it should be, because we have been so thoroughly trained to flee the empty moment. But when I manage it, when I let the commute be a time of ordinary prayer and ordinary presence rather than filling it with distraction, I find that the in-between time becomes some of the most valuable time of my day, a space of quiet in a noisy life, a room for the mind to breathe and the prayers to form and the presence of God to be noticed, a reclaimed sacred ordinary time that I had been throwing away for years without knowing what I was throwing away.

There is a deeper principle here about the value of empty time, of unfilled time, of the fallow ground in a life, and it connects to everything this book has said about rest and Sabbath and the refusal of ceaseless productivity. We are afraid of empty time, of unfilled moments, of the fallow ground, and we rush to fill every scrap of it with activity or distraction, as though empty time were a problem to be solved rather than a good to be received. But the empty time, the fallow ground, the unfilled in-between moment, is not a problem. It is a necessity, a space in which the soul can breathe and rest and be present, a room without which the crowded life becomes unbearable and the soul becomes exhausted and the presence of God becomes impossible to notice. To reclaim the in-between time is, in part, to recover the lost good of empty time, to stop filling every moment, to let some of the ordinary transitional time remain fallow and unfilled and open, as a space for the mind to breathe and the prayers to form and the ordinary presence of God to be noticed in the quiet that distraction had been drowning out.

The transitions in a monastery, the movements from one activity to another, from work to prayer to meal to rest, are marked and honored, treated not as dead time to be rushed through but as meaningful passages, often accompanied by the ringing of a bell that calls the monks to attention, to presence, to the recollection of God in the moment of transition. And there is a wisdom in this that our transition-despising culture has lost, the wisdom of honoring the in-between, of treating the transitions as sacred passages rather than dead time, of using the moment of transition as a moment of recollection, a call back to presence and to God. We could learn to treat our own transitions this way, to let the ordinary passages of our ordinary day, the commute and the waiting and the moving from one thing to another, become moments of recollection, of ordinary prayer, of the turning of the

mind to God, so that the in-between time, far from being wasted, becomes woven through with the presence of God and serves as a constant returning to him throughout the ordinary day.

So reclaim the in-between time, the commute and the waiting and the ordinary transitions that make up so much of your ordinary life, and stop treating it as dead time to be filled with distraction and gotten through. Let some of it be empty, fallow, open, a space for the mind to breathe. Let some of it be prayer, the ordinary turning of the mind to God that Brother Lawrence practiced in the ordinary moments of his ordinary day. Let the transitions become moments of recollection, of presence, of the return to God, so that the enormous portion of your life that is spent in the in-between is no longer wasted but is redeemed, filled with the presence of God, woven through with ordinary prayer and ordinary presence and the ordinary noticing of the ordinary world that God has charged with his grandeur. The in-between time is not nothing. It is a third of your waking life, ordinary time in its purest form, and it is full of God, waiting to be reclaimed from the distraction that has colonized it, and lived, at last, as the ordinary sacred time it always was.

Chapter Twenty-Five: Weather and Season and the Turning Year

God set us in a world that turns, that has seasons and weather we do not control, and the turning is a daily lesson in the two things we most need to learn.

We live inside a turning world, and this turning is so ordinary that we scarcely notice it, but it is one of the great ordinary teachers of the spiritual life, and I want to spend a chapter attending to it. The days turn from light to dark and back to light. The seasons turn from spring to summer to autumn to winter and back again. The weather changes constantly, beyond our control, bringing rain and sun and heat and cold in a rhythm we cannot command. And all of this ordinary turning, this ordinary changing of days and seasons and weather, is not merely a backdrop to human life but a constant ordinary lesson, built into the very structure of the created world, teaching us daily the two things we most need to learn and most resist, which are that we are not in control, and that there is a wisdom and a goodness in the rhythm we did not make and cannot command.

Our culture is at war with the turning world, and this war goes deeper than we notice. We have built an artificial environment designed to abolish the turning, to make every day the same, to eliminate the seasons and the weather and the turning of light and dark from our daily experience. We light our nights so brightly that the darkness is abolished and we can pretend the day never ends. We heat and cool our buildings so precisely that

the seasons are abolished and every day inside is the same temperature. We fly against the seasons, eat food out of season, work through the night, arrange our lives to be as independent as possible from the turning of the world that God set us in. And this war against the turning, this abolition of the seasons and the weather and the rhythm of light and dark, is not the neutral triumph of comfort that it appears to be but a spiritual loss, because it removes us from one of the great ordinary teachers of dependence and rhythm and the acceptance of what we do not control.

Consider the ordinary turning of light and dark, the day and the night, which the modern world has done so much to abolish. There is a wisdom in the darkness, in the ordinary daily coming of the night, that our brightly lit world has lost. The night was always a daily lesson in limits, in the setting of a boundary on the day's activity, in the ordinary daily coming of a darkness that said, enough, stop, rest, you have done what you can do today, the rest will wait for the light. And we have abolished the darkness, lit our nights, extended our activity around the clock, and in doing so we have lost the ordinary daily boundary that the darkness provided, the ordinary daily call to stop that was built into the turning of the world. The person who honors the ordinary turning of light and dark, who lets the night be night, who allows the ordinary coming of the darkness to set a boundary on the day, is receiving an ordinary daily lesson in limits and rest that the person who abolishes the darkness never learns.

Consider the ordinary turning of the seasons, which teaches a rhythm that the modern world has likewise done its best to abolish, the rhythm of growth and harvest and fallow rest, of spring and summer and autumn and winter, of the times for

planting and the times for reaping and the times for lying dormant. There is a deep wisdom in this seasonal rhythm, a wisdom that the great agricultural cultures knew in their bones and that we have almost entirely lost, the wisdom that life moves in seasons, that there are times for growth and times for rest, times for activity and times for lying fallow, and that the attempt to make every season a growing season, to be productive all the time, to abolish the fallow winter of rest, is a violation of the created rhythm that leads to exhaustion and depletion. Wendell Berry, the farmer-poet, has written his whole life out of the wisdom of the seasons, insisting that we ignore the seasonal rhythm at our peril, that the good life follows the turning of the year rather than fighting it, that there is a time to rest and lie fallow that is as necessary as the time to grow and produce.

The weather is the great ordinary teacher of what we do not control, and I have come to love it for exactly this reason, though I resisted the lesson for years. The weather does not care about your plans. It comes as it comes, the rain and the sun and the heat and the cold, indifferent to your preferences and your schedules and your desires, a daily ordinary reminder that you are not in charge of the world, that there is a vast reality that proceeds according to its own patterns without consulting you, that your control over your own life is far more limited than your illusions suggest. And this daily ordinary lesson in the limits of your control, delivered by the ordinary weather, is a gift, though it rarely feels like one, because the acceptance of what we do not control is one of the deepest and hardest and most necessary spiritual attainments, and the weather offers this lesson daily, freely, to anyone who will receive it rather than raging against it.

Jesus spoke of the weather as a sign of God's ordinary care, noting that the Father sends rain on the just and the unjust alike,

that the ordinary weather is an expression of the ordinary providence of God, his ordinary daily care for the world he made, distributed impartially across the ordinary world without regard to merit. And there is a whole theology of the ordinary in this, the recognition that the ordinary weather, the ordinary turning of the seasons, the ordinary rhythm of the days, is not a mechanical process indifferent to God but an expression of his ordinary providence, his ordinary care, his ordinary sustaining of the world he made and loves. The rain that falls on your ordinary day is not merely a meteorological event but a token of the ordinary providence of God, his ordinary care for the ordinary world, delivered in the most ordinary form, the ordinary weather that comes as it comes, beyond your control, an expression of a care and a wisdom and a sustaining that you did not create and cannot command.

I want to make a plea for reconnecting with the turning world, for stepping back into the ordinary rhythm of days and seasons and weather that the modern world has done so much to abolish, because I believe we have lost something essential in our war against the turning, and I believe the recovery of it is part of the recovery of ordinary holiness. Let the night be night sometimes, and receive the ordinary daily boundary that the darkness provides. Attend to the turning of the seasons, and honor the seasonal rhythm of growth and rest, refusing the modern demand to be productive in every season. Notice the weather, and receive it as an ordinary daily lesson in the limits of your control and a token of the ordinary providence of God. Step back into the turning world that God set you in, and let its ordinary rhythms teach you the ordinary lessons they were made to teach, the lessons of limits and rhythm and dependence and the acceptance of what you do not control.

So attend to the turning of the world, the ordinary daily turning of light and dark, the ordinary yearly turning of the seasons, the ordinary constant turning of the weather, and let it teach you what it was made to teach, which is that you are a creature set in a world you did not make and do not control, moving through rhythms you did not design, dependent on a providence you did not arrange, and that this is not a limitation to be abolished but a truth to be received, the truth of your creatureliness, which is the beginning of all wisdom and all worship. The world turns, and the turning is a daily lesson, and the God who set the world turning is expressing, in every ordinary sunrise and every ordinary season and every ordinary rainfall, an ordinary care and an ordinary wisdom and an ordinary sustaining presence that you were made to notice and receive, in the ordinary turning of the ordinary world, which is charged, like everything else, with the grandeur of the God who made it turn.

Chapter Twenty-Six: The Ministry of Small Things

We keep waiting to do something great for God, and while we wait, the small things that were the actual assignment go undone.

There is a particular temptation that afflicts serious Christians, and I have suffered from it my whole life, which is the desire to do something great for God. It sounds noble, and it is not entirely ignoble, but it hides a subtle and dangerous error, which is the assumption that the great and visible thing is what God wants, that the significant and impressive work is the real service, and that the small ordinary things are beneath the ambitions of a person who wants to serve God greatly. And this desire to do something great, this ambition for the significant and visible service, has a way of blinding us to the small ordinary things that are, in fact, the actual assignment, the real ministry, the true service that God has actually placed in front of us, while we wait for the great thing that we imagine will be our real contribution. We keep waiting to do something great, and while we wait, the small things go undone, and it turns out the small things were the whole point.

The Scriptures are relentlessly focused on the small things, and this focus cuts directly against our hunger for the great and significant. A cup of cold water given to a little one. A visit to a prisoner. A meal for the hungry. A welcome for the stranger. When Jesus describes the works that will matter at the final

judgment, he does not describe great and significant achievements but the smallest and most ordinary acts of care, the cup of water and the visit and the meal and the welcome, the small ordinary kindnesses that anyone can do, that require no greatness, that make no impression, that will never be recorded in any history. And he says, astonishingly, that these small ordinary acts of care, done to the least of these, were done to him, that the small ordinary kindness to the ordinary person in need was, all along, a kindness to God himself, so that the small ordinary thing turns out to have an infinite significance that the great and visible achievement never had.

I have watched people ruin their lives, or at least waste large portions of them, in the pursuit of the great thing, always waiting for the significant work that would justify their existence, always despising the small ordinary service in front of them as beneath their calling, always looking past the ordinary person in ordinary need toward the great and visible ministry they imagined God had for them. And I have watched other people, quieter and less ambitious, simply do the small things, the ordinary daily acts of care and service that were in front of them, the cup of water and the visit and the meal and the welcome, without ambition, without waiting for something greater, and I have come to believe that these quiet doers of small things were the ones actually serving God, actually ministering, actually building the kingdom, while the ambitious seekers of the great thing were mostly serving their own hunger for significance and mostly missing the actual assignment, which was always the small ordinary thing in front of them.

Mother Teresa, who spent her life among the ordinary poor and dying of Calcutta, is often quoted as saying that we cannot do great things, only small things with great love, and whether or

not she said it exactly that way, it captures something true about the whole shape of her life and about the whole logic of the ministry of small things. She did not do great and visible and impressive things. She did the smallest possible things, the washing of the dying, the feeding of the hungry, the holding of the abandoned, the small ordinary acts of care for the least of these, done with great love, over a lifetime. And it turned out that this life of small things done with great love was one of the great lives of her century, not because the things were great but because the love was great, because the small ordinary acts of care were the vehicle of a love that made them infinitely significant, which is exactly the logic of the ministry of small things, that the significance is not in the size of the thing but in the love with which the small thing is done.

There is a freedom in the ministry of small things that the ambition for great things never provides, and I have found this freedom slowly, as I have made peace with the smallness of most of what I actually do. The ambition for great things is a heavy burden, a perpetual dissatisfaction with the ordinary service in front of you, a constant sense that you are not doing enough, not accomplishing enough, not serving greatly enough, and it makes the ordinary daily service feel like a failure, a falling short of the great thing you were supposed to be doing. And the ministry of small things releases this burden, because it declares that the small ordinary thing in front of you is the actual assignment, that you do not have to do something great to serve God, that the cup of water and the visit and the meal and the ordinary kindness are the real ministry, and that you can do them today, right now, in the ordinary circumstances of your ordinary life, without waiting for the great thing that was never actually required. The ministry of small things is available to everyone, always, and it releases the crushing burden of the ambition for greatness.

I think of the ordinary saints again, the ones who have taught me the most, and I notice that none of them did anything great, and that this is precisely why they were saints. The woman who brought a meal to every grieving family in the church for forty years. The man who quietly paid the electric bill of struggling families without ever letting them know who had done it. The teenager who sat with the lonely kid at lunch. These are the small things, the ordinary acts of care that will never be recorded in any history, that made no impression on the world, that accomplished nothing great, and that were, I am convinced, among the truest and most significant works of ministry that I have ever witnessed, because they were done with love, to the least of these, in the small ordinary way that Jesus specifically commended and specifically identified with himself. The ministry of small things is the real ministry. The great things are mostly a distraction from it, a way of serving our own significance while the actual assignment goes undone.

Let me press on the self-implication here, because I am the ambitious seeker of great things as much as anyone, and this chapter is a confession as much as a teaching. I became a pastor, in part, out of a desire to do something significant for God, to have a ministry that mattered, to make a difference on a scale that would justify my existence. And I have had to face, over fifteen years, that most of the actual ministry, most of the real service, most of the work that has actually mattered, has not been the great and visible things I dreamed of but the small ordinary things I nearly despised, the ordinary pastoral visit, the ordinary conversation with the struggling person, the ordinary faithful presence at the hospital bed and the graveside and the kitchen table. The small things were the ministry. The great things I dreamed of were mostly my own ambition dressed up as service. And the sooner I made peace with the smallness of the actual

assignment, the sooner I began to actually serve God, in the small ordinary things that were in front of me the whole time.

So take up the ministry of small things, and stop waiting to do something great, because the small things are the actual assignment, the real ministry, the true service that God has placed in front of you, and the great thing you are waiting for is mostly a distraction from the small things that were the point. Do the small ordinary act of care that is in front of you today, the cup of water and the visit and the meal and the ordinary kindness, and do it with great love, and know that in doing the small thing with great love you are ministering to God himself, serving him in the least of these, building his kingdom in the only way it has ever actually been built, one small ordinary act of love at a time. You will probably never do anything great. Almost no one does. But you can do small things with great love, today, in the ordinary circumstances of your ordinary life, and that, it turns out, is the whole of what God has ever asked, and it is enough, and it is more than enough, and it is, in the economy of God, greater than any great thing you were ever waiting to do.

Chapter Twenty-Seven: Boredom and the Fear of the Empty Room

We flee the empty room because we are afraid of what we will find there, which is ourselves, and beyond ourselves, God, waiting in the silence we cannot bear.

Blaise Pascal wrote in the seventeenth century that all of humanity's problems stem from our inability to sit quietly in a room alone, and I have thought about that sentence for years, because it names something about the human condition that has only grown truer since he wrote it. We cannot bear the empty room. We cannot bear the silence, the stillness, the unfilled moment, the ordinary boredom of having nothing to do and nowhere to be and no distraction at hand. We flee it, always, into activity or distraction or noise, into anything that will fill the empty room and save us from the silence, and Pascal saw that this flight from the empty room, this inability to sit quietly alone, is at the root of an enormous amount of human misery and folly. And in our age, the age of the screen that fills every empty moment, the flight from the empty room has become nearly total, so that we scarcely ever sit quietly alone anymore, and we have almost entirely lost the capacity for the ordinary stillness that Pascal knew was so important and so difficult.

Why do we flee the empty room? Pascal's answer, and I think he was right, is that we flee it because of what we find there, and what we find there is, first, ourselves, the naked reality of our own existence without the distractions that usually hide it from

us, and this is genuinely difficult to face. In the empty room, without distraction, we are confronted with ourselves, with our own thoughts and fears and regrets and longings, with the reality of our own mortality and smallness and need, and this confrontation is uncomfortable, even frightening, so we flee it, filling the room with distraction so that we will not have to sit with ourselves in the silence. The ordinary boredom of the empty room is not really boredom at all but a kind of low-grade dread, the dread of being alone with ourselves, of facing the reality that the distractions usually hide, and we flee it not because it is dull but because it is threatening, because in the empty room we cannot escape ourselves.

But there is more in the empty room than ourselves, and this is the deeper reason we flee it, and the reason its recovery is so important for the spiritual life. Beyond ourselves, in the silence of the empty room, is God, waiting in exactly the stillness we cannot bear, available in precisely the silence we flee. The great spiritual traditions have always known that God is found in silence, in stillness, in the quiet of the empty room, that the flight from silence is, at some level, a flight from God, and that the recovery of the capacity for stillness is essential to the recovery of the capacity to find God. Be still, says the psalm, and know that I am God. The stillness is the condition of the knowing. And when we flee the stillness, when we fill every empty room and every silent moment with distraction, we are fleeing not only ourselves but the God who waits to be found in the stillness, the God who speaks in the still small voice that can only be heard in the silence, the God who is available in the empty room we cannot bear to enter.

I have to confess my own inability here, because I am as much a fugitive from the empty room as anyone, perhaps more, and I

have watched my own flight from silence with a growing alarm. I reach for the phone in every empty moment, fill every silence with input, flee the stillness into distraction as reflexively as breathing, and I have noticed that I have almost entirely lost the capacity that I once had, that everyone once had, to simply be still, to sit quietly alone, to endure the empty room without fleeing it into distraction. And I know, because the tradition tells me and because my own experience confirms it, that this lost capacity for stillness is a serious spiritual loss, that in fleeing the empty room I am fleeing both myself and God, that the silence I cannot bear is exactly the silence in which God is found, and that the recovery of the capacity for stillness may be one of the most important and most difficult spiritual tasks of my life and of our whole distracted age.

Boredom, which we treat as a purely negative experience to be eliminated at all costs, may actually be a doorway, and this is a possibility our distraction-addicted culture cannot even imagine. Boredom is what we feel at the threshold of the empty room, the discomfort of the unfilled moment, the restlessness of having nothing to do. And we have decided that boredom is intolerable, that it must be eliminated immediately by distraction, that the good life is a life with no boredom in it, every moment filled, every silence banished. But what if boredom is a doorway? What if the discomfort of the empty moment is the threshold we must cross to find the stillness in which God is available? What if the very restlessness we flee is the beginning of a deeper rest, if only we could endure it long enough to pass through it into the silence beyond? The mystics and the monks have always known that boredom, endured rather than fled, can be a doorway into contemplation, that the person who can sit with the empty moment long enough, past the initial discomfort, discovers a stillness and a presence on the other side that the person who

always flees the boredom never finds.

There is a discipline here that is desperately countercultural and desperately needed, the discipline of deliberately entering the empty room, of choosing the silence, of sitting quietly alone without distraction, of enduring the boredom and the discomfort long enough to pass through them into the stillness beyond. This is what the contemplative traditions have always practiced, the deliberate cultivation of silence and solitude, the intentional entering of the empty room that everyone else is fleeing, in the confidence that God is found in the stillness and that the capacity for stillness must be deliberately recovered and practiced against the constant pull toward distraction. It does not have to be dramatic. It can be as ordinary as sitting quietly for a few minutes without the phone, enduring the discomfort of the unfilled moment, letting the silence be silent, waiting in the stillness for the God who is found there. But it must be practiced, deliberately, against the current, because the capacity for it has been so thoroughly eroded by our distraction-saturated age.

The recovery of stillness is not an escape from the ordinary life but a way of finding God within it, and I want to be clear about this, because the contemplative disciplines can sound like a flight from the ordinary into a special spiritual practice. But the stillness I am describing is available in the ordinary empty rooms of the ordinary life, in the ordinary silences and unfilled moments that punctuate every ordinary day, if only we would stop fleeing them into distraction. The ordinary quiet of the early morning before the house wakes. The ordinary silence of a solitary drive. The ordinary stillness of a moment alone. These ordinary empty rooms, which we usually fill with distraction, are available every day as doorways into the stillness in which God is found, and the discipline is not to add some special spiritual

practice to the ordinary life but to stop fleeing the ordinary silences that the ordinary life already contains, to let the ordinary empty room be empty, to endure the ordinary boredom, to wait in the ordinary stillness for the God who is found there.

So learn to sit quietly in a room alone, which Pascal knew was the hardest and most important of human capacities, and which our age has all but destroyed. Stop fleeing the empty room into distraction. Endure the ordinary boredom of the unfilled moment, and let it be a doorway rather than an enemy. Enter the ordinary silence, and wait in it, past the initial discomfort, past the confrontation with yourself, into the stillness beyond, where God is found, where the still small voice can finally be heard, where the God you have been fleeing along with the silence waits to be found by anyone who can bear to be still. The empty room is not empty. It is full of yourself, which you must face, and full of God, who waits to be found there, in the silence you cannot bear, in the stillness you keep fleeing, in the ordinary quiet of the ordinary empty room that you have been filling with distraction your whole life, and that God has been waiting in, patiently, the whole time, for you to finally stop, and be still, and know.

Chapter Twenty-Eight: Gratitude and the Recovered World

Gratitude is not a mood. It is a discipline of attention that slowly gives you back the ordinary world you had stopped seeing.

There is a practice so ordinary that we barely think of it as a spiritual discipline at all, and yet I have come to believe it may be the single most important practice for recovering the capacity to find God in the ordinary, and that practice is gratitude. Not gratitude as a mood, a pleasant feeling that comes and goes with our circumstances, but gratitude as a discipline, a deliberate practice of attention, a chosen turning of the mind toward the good gifts of the ordinary world that we have stopped seeing. Because the deepest problem with the ordinary, the thing that makes it invisible to us, is that we have stopped seeing it, that the ordinary gifts of ordinary life have become so familiar that they have disappeared from our attention, and gratitude is the practice that reverses this, that turns our attention back toward the ordinary gifts we had stopped noticing, and in doing so gives us back the ordinary world we had lost.

Consider how much of the ordinary world has disappeared from your attention through sheer familiarity. The ordinary miracle of your own body, which heals its wounds and digests its food and beats its heart and breathes its breath without any conscious effort from you, and which you notice only when it fails. The ordinary gift of the people in your life, whose faces you have

seen so many times that you no longer really see them, whose presence you have come to assume rather than receive. The ordinary abundance of the food on your table, the water from your tap, the roof over your head, the ordinary daily provisions that you use without thought and would grieve terribly to lose. All of this ordinary good has largely disappeared from your attention, worn invisible by familiarity, taken for granted rather than received as gift, and the practice of gratitude is the deliberate reversal of this disappearance, the intentional turning of attention back toward the ordinary gifts, the practiced noticing of the good that familiarity had made invisible.

I did not understand the power of gratitude as a discipline until I began to practice it deliberately, and I want to describe what happened, because it surprised me. I began, at a low point, to make a practice of naming ordinary things I was grateful for, not the great and dramatic blessings but the small ordinary ones, the ordinary gifts I had stopped noticing. The warmth of the coffee. The particular light of a particular morning. The sound of my sons in the house. The ordinary good of a body that mostly worked, a home that was warm, a table that had food on it. And as I practiced this deliberate noticing of ordinary gifts, something shifted, slowly, over time. The ordinary world began to reappear. The gifts that familiarity had made invisible began to become visible again. And I found that I was living in a world I had forgotten was there, a world full of ordinary good, ordinary gift, ordinary grace, that I had stopped seeing and that the practice of gratitude was slowly giving back to me. Gratitude was not changing my circumstances. It was changing my attention, and in changing my attention it was giving me back the ordinary world.

There is a theology under this practice, and it is important,

because gratitude is not merely a psychological technique for feeling better but a way of telling the truth about the nature of reality. The truth about the ordinary world is that it is gift, that none of it is owed to us, that every ordinary good we receive is grace, undeserved, unearned, freely given by a generous God. And gratitude is simply the truthful response to this reality, the acknowledgment that the ordinary world is gift, the receiving of the ordinary good as grace rather than as entitlement. The ungrateful heart lives in a lie, treating the ordinary gifts as owed, as deserved, as simply the way things are, and therefore failing to receive them as gifts at all. The grateful heart lives in the truth, receiving the ordinary world as the gift it actually is, and this truthful receiving is not only more accurate but more joyful, because the gift received as gift brings a joy that the entitlement assumed as owed never can.

Gerard Manley Hopkins, whose vision of the charged and grandeur-filled world sits at the head of this book, was fundamentally a poet of gratitude, of the astonished grateful noticing of the ordinary world's glory. His poems are acts of attention, deliberate noticings of the ordinary things that most people walk past, the dappled things and the ordinary light and the common creatures, received with an astonished gratitude that saw the grandeur of God flaming out of them. Glory be to God for dappled things, he wrote, and then he named the ordinary dappled things, the skies of couple-colour, the rose-moles on the trout, the ordinary common freckled spotted things that gratitude had made visible to him and that ingratitude makes invisible to the rest of us. Hopkins saw the grandeur in the ordinary because he practiced the gratitude that gives back the ordinary world, and his poems are a school of exactly this practice, a training in the grateful attention that recovers the lost glory of the ordinary.

Gratitude is also, and this surprised me, an ordinary daily antidote to the specific diseases of our age that this whole book has been diagnosing. It is the antidote to the manufactured dissatisfaction of the comparison economy, because gratitude turns the attention toward what you have rather than what you lack, toward the ordinary goods of your actual life rather than the spectacular goods of other people's curated lives. It is the antidote to the addiction to the spectacular, because gratitude finds its satisfaction in the ordinary gifts rather than requiring the dramatic and exceptional. It is the antidote to the perpetual restlessness of the acquisitive heart, because gratitude discovers that the ordinary provision is enough, that there is abundance in the ordinary, that the good life is available in the ordinary gifts already received rather than in the spectacular acquisitions still pursued. Gratitude, this most ordinary of practices, turns out to be a daily medicine against the specific spiritual sicknesses that our particular age produces, a recovery of contentment and sufficiency and presence in the ordinary abundance we had stopped seeing.

I want to name the connection between gratitude and grace, because they are the same word at the root, and this is not an accident but a deep truth about the shape of the Christian life. Grace is the free gift of God, the unearned favor, the goodness given to those who do not deserve it. And gratitude is the receiving of grace, the acknowledgment of the gift, the return of thanks to the giver. The whole Christian life moves in the rhythm of grace received and gratitude returned, and the practice of gratitude for the ordinary gifts is simply this fundamental rhythm applied to the ordinary world, the receiving of the ordinary good as grace and the returning of thanks for it, so that the ordinary daily practice of gratitude becomes a participation in the deepest rhythm of the Christian life, the rhythm of grace and gratitude,

gift and thanks, which is the rhythm of the whole relationship between God and his people, practiced in the ordinary key of thanks for ordinary gifts.

So take up the ordinary discipline of gratitude, the deliberate daily practice of noticing and naming and giving thanks for the ordinary gifts of your ordinary life, and let it do its slow work of giving you back the ordinary world you had stopped seeing. Notice the ordinary good that familiarity had made invisible. Receive the ordinary provision as the grace it actually is. Return thanks to the giver of the ordinary gifts, and let the ordinary daily practice of gratitude recover for you the lost glory of the ordinary world, the charged and grandeur-filled world that Hopkins saw and that gratitude makes visible again. Gratitude is not a mood that comes and goes with your circumstances. It is a discipline of attention that you can practice deliberately, every ordinary day, and that will slowly give you back the ordinary world as gift, as grace, as the good and abundant provision of a generous God, received at last with the astonished thanks that is the only truthful response to the ordinary world that is charged, in every ordinary part of it, with the grandeur of God.

Chapter Twenty-Nine: The Long Faithfulness of Marriage and Vow

A vow is a decision made once that must be kept ten thousand times, and the keeping is where the whole meaning lives.

I want to return to marriage, but from a different angle than before, because I have been thinking about the nature of the vow, the promise, the commitment made once that must be kept over a lifetime, and I have come to believe that the vow is one of the great instruments of ordinary holiness, one of the primary ways that the ordinary daily faithfulness gets its meaning and its strength. A vow is a strange thing when you think about it. It is a decision made once, in a single moment, about a future that has not yet happened, a binding of the will to a course of action that will have to be sustained through ten thousand ordinary days, most of which you cannot foresee. And the whole meaning of the vow lies not in the moment of making it but in the ten thousand ordinary days of keeping it, in the long faithfulness that sustains the single decision through the ordinary and the unforeseen and the difficult, so that the vow made once becomes the faithfulness kept daily, which is where the whole meaning lives.

We are, as a culture, deeply suspicious of the vow, of the binding commitment, of the promise that limits our future freedom, and this suspicion is worth examining because it goes to the heart of what we have lost. We prize our options, our flexibility, our

ability to change course, our freedom to reconsider, and the vow is the enemy of all of this, because the vow closes options, limits flexibility, binds the future, forecloses reconsideration. The vow says, I have decided, once and for all, and I will keep this decision through whatever comes, regardless of how I feel, regardless of what better options may appear, regardless of the difficulty. And this closing of options, this binding of the future, this foreclosure of reconsideration, strikes the modern mind as a kind of imprisonment, a loss of freedom, a diminishment of the self. But I have come to believe the opposite, that the vow is not the enemy of freedom but the condition of a deeper freedom, the freedom to build something that can only be built by the long faithfulness that the vow makes possible.

Because there are goods that can only be built by the long faithfulness of the kept vow, and these goods are among the highest available to human beings, and they are entirely inaccessible to the person who will not make and keep the binding commitment. A marriage of thirty years, with its deep knowledge and its tested love and its shared history and its interwoven lives, is a good of enormous richness, and it can only be built by two people who made a vow and kept it through the ten thousand ordinary days, including the difficult ones, including the ones when they wanted to leave. This good is simply not available to the person who keeps their options open, who will not make the binding commitment, who reserves the right to reconsider, because the good is built precisely by the foreclosure of that option, by the vow that says I will stay regardless, by the long faithfulness that the vow makes possible. The vow does not diminish freedom. It makes possible a good that freedom alone can never build.

Wendell Berry has written about marriage as a form of the vow

to a place and a life and a person, an act of binding oneself to a particular and limited future for the sake of the goods that only such binding can produce. He writes that the meaning of marriage begins in the giving of words, in the vow, and that this giving of words is a binding of oneself to an unknown future, a commitment made in ignorance of what it will require, and that this very binding, this commitment in ignorance, is what makes marriage possible, because if we waited to commit until we knew everything the commitment would require, we would never commit at all. The vow is made in trust, in the willingness to bind oneself to an unknown future for the sake of the good that only such binding can build, and the keeping of the vow through the unknown and the difficult is the long faithfulness that produces the good, the deep and rich and tested good of a marriage or a life or a place held faithfully over a long time.

I have kept my vow to Susanna for a long time now, and I want to be honest about what the keeping has actually involved, because the romantic picture of marriage obscures the ordinary reality of the kept vow. The keeping has involved staying through seasons when I did not want to stay, when the marriage was hard, when the love had cooled to something that felt more like duty than romance, when other lives and other options presented themselves as more appealing. And the vow held me through those seasons, the vow made once and binding me still, the commitment that said I will stay regardless, and I stayed, not always out of feeling but out of faithfulness, out of the kept vow, through the ordinary difficult seasons, and I have discovered on the other side of them a love deeper and richer than the romantic love that first brought us together, a love that could only have been built by the staying, by the kept vow, by the long faithfulness through the difficult ordinary days. The vow held me when feeling failed, and the holding built something that feeling

alone could never have built.

There is a connection between the marriage vow and the deeper vow of the Christian life, the commitment to follow Christ through the ten thousand ordinary days regardless of feeling, regardless of difficulty, regardless of the better options that present themselves. The Christian life is itself a kind of vow, a commitment made once, or made and remade, that must be kept through the long faithfulness of the ordinary days, most of which will not feel spiritual, many of which will be difficult, some of which will present the appealing option of abandoning the whole thing. And the keeping of this deeper vow, the long faithfulness to Christ through the ordinary and the difficult, is the whole substance of the Christian life, the long obedience in the same direction, the kept commitment that produces the good of a life shaped by God, a good that can only be built by the faithfulness that the vow makes possible, and that is entirely inaccessible to the person who keeps their spiritual options open, who will not make the binding commitment, who reserves the right to reconsider whenever the following grows difficult.

The faithfulness that keeps the vow is not usually dramatic, and this is why it belongs so centrally in a book about the ordinary. The keeping of a vow is not a series of heroic moments but a long accumulation of ordinary daily choices to remain, to stay, to keep the commitment through the ordinary difficulties and the ordinary temptations and the ordinary seasons of cooled feeling. Each daily choice is small, ordinary, unremarkable, the ordinary choice to stay in the marriage today, to keep following Christ today, to remain faithful to the vow today, and no single one of these ordinary daily choices is dramatic or heroic. But their accumulation over a lifetime is the kept vow, the long faithfulness, the good that could only be built by the ten

thousand ordinary daily choices to remain, and this is the ordinary heroism of the kept vow, the unremarkable daily faithfulness that builds, over a lifetime, the deep and rich and tested goods that are among the highest available to human beings.

So do not be afraid of the vow, of the binding commitment, of the promise that limits your future freedom, because the vow is not the enemy of the good life but the condition of its deepest goods. Make the vow, and keep it, through the ten thousand ordinary days, including the difficult ones, including the ones when you want to leave, and let the long faithfulness of the kept vow build the deep and rich and tested goods that only such faithfulness can build. The vow made once must be kept ten thousand times, in ten thousand ordinary daily choices to remain, and the keeping is where the whole meaning lives, in the long ordinary faithfulness that sustains the single decision through the unforeseen and the difficult, and that produces, over a lifetime, the marriage and the life and the faith that could never have been built by the person who kept their options open, but that are built, slowly and surely, by the ordinary daily faithfulness of the kept vow, one ordinary day at a time, for as long as you both shall live, and beyond.

Chapter Thirty: The Sanctity of the Overlooked Person

The person the world overlooks is often the person God has placed at the center of the room, and we keep seating them at the edges.

There is a pattern in the Gospels so consistent that once you see it you cannot un-see it, and it has to do with who Jesus notices. He notices the overlooked. Over and over, in scene after scene, while the important people command the center of attention, Jesus turns aside to the overlooked person at the edge, the one everyone else has failed to see, the child, the beggar, the widow, the leper, the woman, the outsider, the ordinary and unremarkable person that the world has placed at the margins. And he treats this overlooked person not as marginal but as central, not as an interruption of his important work but as the very object of it, so that again and again the person the world overlooked turns out to be the person God had placed at the center of the room, and the whole scene reorganizes itself around the one everyone else had failed to see.

Think of the woman who touched the edge of his cloak in the crowd, an ordinary overlooked woman, sick for years, invisible to everyone, who reached out in the press of the crowd hoping to be healed unnoticed, and whom Jesus stopped everything to see, to name, to bless, turning the whole procession aside to attend to the one overlooked woman that no one else had noticed. Think of the children that the disciples tried to keep away, treating them

as an interruption of the important work, and whom Jesus insisted on receiving, blessing, holding up as the very picture of the kingdom, reorganizing the scene around the overlooked children that the important adults had tried to push to the edges. Think of the widow whom he watched put her two small coins into the treasury, an overlooked woman making an overlooked gift, whom he noticed and named and honored above all the wealthy givers whose large gifts everyone else was watching. The pattern is relentless. Jesus notices the overlooked, centers the marginal, sees the invisible, and reorganizes every scene around the ordinary unremarkable person that the world has failed to see.

I have had to reckon with how thoroughly I fail at this, how consistently my own attention flows toward the important and away from the overlooked, and this chapter is a confession as much as anything. In any room, my attention goes, automatically, toward the people who seem to matter, the influential, the impressive, the ones who can do something for me or my work, and away from the overlooked, the ordinary, the marginal, the ones the world has taught me not to see. I do this in my own congregation, drawn toward the people who seem significant and neglecting the overlooked ones at the edges. I do it everywhere, my attention obeying the world's ranking of who matters, flowing toward the center that the world has designated and away from the margins where the overlooked wait, unseen by me as by everyone else. And this failure of attention is a serious spiritual failure, because it is a failure to see as God sees, a failure to notice the overlooked person that God has placed at the center of the room, a failure to reorganize my attention around the ones Jesus consistently reorganized his attention around.

There is a profound theology of the overlooked person, and it is bound up with the whole logic of the incarnation and the kingdom. God, it turns out, has a preference for the overlooked, a consistent pattern of choosing the marginal and the unremarkable and the ones the world fails to see, of working through the overlooked rather than the important, of placing his presence and his purposes among the people the world has pushed to the edges. God chose a small overlooked people, Israel, rather than a great empire. God chose an overlooked town, Nazareth, rather than a great city. God chose overlooked people, fishermen and tax collectors and women of no status, rather than the important and the powerful, to be the bearers of his kingdom. And this consistent divine preference for the overlooked is not a marginal theme but a central revelation, a disclosure of the very character of God, who sees and centers and chooses the ones the world overlooks, and who calls his people to see as he sees, to center the overlooked, to reorganize their attention around the ones the world has failed to see.

The overlooked person is often, specifically, the ordinary person, and this is why this theme belongs so centrally in a book about the ordinary. The world overlooks the ordinary person precisely because they are ordinary, unremarkable, unimportant by the world's ranking, and it directs its attention toward the exceptional, the impressive, the significant. But God, who dwells in the ordinary and works through the ordinary and reveals himself in the ordinary, sees and values and centers the ordinary overlooked person that the world fails to see, and calls his people to the same seeing. The ordinary overlooked person, the one the world walks past, the unremarkable person at the edge of the room, is precisely the person that God notices and values and has placed, in his own reckoning, at the center, and the recovery of the capacity to see the overlooked, to notice the ordinary person

the world walks past, is a central part of learning to see as God sees and to find God in the ordinary.

I think of the specific overlooked people in my own life whom I have finally learned to see, and how much they have given me, and how nearly I missed them. There is an elderly man in my congregation, overlooked by nearly everyone, unremarkable, quiet, easily walked past, whom I nearly failed to see for years, and whom I finally came to know, and who turned out to be one of the wisest and most Christlike people I have ever met, a treasure hidden in an overlooked ordinary life that I had nearly missed because my attention flowed, like everyone's, toward the important and away from the overlooked. And I have come to believe that every overlooked person, every ordinary unremarkable person at the edge of the room, is a treasure of this kind, a person of infinite worth in the sight of God, a bearer of the image of God, a person Jesus would have turned aside to see, and that the world is full of these overlooked treasures, walked past every day by people whose attention obeys the world's ranking rather than God's, missing the overlooked ones that God has placed, in his own reckoning, at the center of the room.

There is a discipline of attention here, a deliberate practice of learning to see the overlooked, of directing attention toward the margins rather than the center that the world designates, of noticing the ordinary unremarkable person that everyone else walks past. It does not come naturally, because our attention has been trained, deeply, to obey the world's ranking of who matters, to flow toward the important and away from the overlooked. But it can be practiced, deliberately, the practice of noticing the overlooked person, of turning aside like Jesus to see the one everyone else has failed to see, of reorganizing our attention around the margins where the overlooked wait. And this practice,

this deliberate seeing of the overlooked, is a central discipline of ordinary holiness, a way of learning to see as God sees, to find God in the overlooked ordinary person, to center the ones the world has pushed to the edges, and to discover, again and again, that the person the world overlooked was a treasure all along, placed by God at the center of the room, waiting to be seen.

So learn to see the overlooked, and practice the deliberate discipline of noticing the ordinary unremarkable person that the world walks past, and reorganize your attention around the margins where the overlooked wait, as Jesus consistently reorganized his. Turn aside to see the one everyone else has failed to see. Notice the child, the elderly person, the marginal one, the ordinary unremarkable person at the edge of the room, and treat them as God treats them, as a treasure of infinite worth, a bearer of the divine image, a person God has placed, in his own reckoning, at the center. Because the person the world overlooks is often the person God has placed at the center of the room, and we keep seating them at the edges, and the recovery of the capacity to see them, to notice the overlooked ordinary person that God so consistently notices, is a central part of learning to see as God sees and to find God in the ordinary overlooked people that fill the ordinary world, walked past by everyone, seen by God, and waiting to be seen by us.

Chapter Thirty-One: The Slow Work of God

We want our growth to be a sudden event, and God, patient beyond our understanding, insists on making it a slow work, because slow is how living things actually grow.

There is a prayer, often attributed to the Jesuit priest and paleontologist Pierre Teilhard de Chardin, who died in 1955, about trusting in the slow work of God, and I have returned to it again and again over the years, because it names something that I resist with my whole impatient nature and that I know to be true. Above all, the prayer says, trust in the slow work of God. We are quite naturally impatient in everything to reach the end without delay. We should like to skip the intermediate stages. We are impatient of being on the way to something unknown, something new. And the prayer counsels patience, trust in the slow work of God, the acceptance that our growth and our formation will be slow, gradual, incremental, a slow work rather than a sudden event, because that is how God works, and that is how living things actually grow.

We do not want the slow work of God. We want the sudden work, the instant transformation, the dramatic change that would make us different all at once. And our whole age reinforces this desire, promising instant results, rapid transformation, the quick fix for every problem, so that we come to expect our spiritual growth to be fast and dramatic and to read its slowness as failure.

But God, patient beyond our understanding, insists on the slow work, refuses the sudden transformation we crave, and forms us gradually, incrementally, over long stretches of ordinary time, through a slow work that we can barely perceive while it is happening, because slow is how living things grow. A tree does not grow suddenly. A child does not mature overnight. A soul is not formed in an instant. All living growth is slow, gradual, incremental, imperceptible in the moment and evident only over the long stretch, and the growth of the soul is no exception, and our impatience with its slowness is an impatience with the very nature of living growth.

I have watched the slow work of God in my own life, and the most striking thing about it is how little I could perceive it while it was happening. Looking back over twenty years of following Christ, I can see that I have changed, that I am, by grace, a somewhat different person than I was, less driven by some of the old sins, more shaped by some of the graces, slowly formed over the long stretch into something a little more like Christ. But I could never perceive this change while it was happening. Day to day, year to year, I mostly experienced the frustrating sense of not changing, of struggling with the same sins, of failing to grow, of the slowness of the work that felt, in the moment, like no work at all. It was only looking back over the long stretch that I could see the slow work of God, the gradual incremental formation that had been happening all along, imperceptibly, beneath the frustrating daily sense of not changing, the slow work that was real even though I could not feel it, that was forming me even though it felt like nothing, that was the actual growth of an actual living soul, which is always slow, always gradual, always imperceptible in the moment and evident only over the long stretch of ordinary time.

The impatience with the slow work of God is spiritually dangerous, and I want to name the danger, because it does real harm. When we cannot perceive the slow work, when we experience only the frustrating daily sense of not changing, we are tempted to conclude that nothing is happening, that we are not growing, that God is not working, that the whole thing has failed. And this conclusion, drawn from our impatience with the slowness, can lead us to abandon the very practices and the very faithfulness through which the slow work is actually happening, to give up on the long obedience because we cannot feel it working, to seek instead some dramatic shortcut that promises the fast transformation we crave. The impatience with the slow work leads us to abandon the slow work, and in abandoning it we abandon the actual means of our actual growth, chasing instead a dramatic transformation that God does not usually give, and missing the slow work that was forming us all along beneath the level of our perception.

Teilhard's prayer counsels a specific posture toward this slowness, and it is the posture of trust, of patience, of accepting the slowness as the nature of the work rather than raging against it as a failure. Trust in the slow work of God. Accept that you are on the way, in process, being formed, not yet arrived, and that this being on the way, this incompleteness, this slow gradual formation, is not a failure but the very shape of the work, the nature of living growth, the way God actually forms a soul. Give God, the prayer says, the benefit of believing that his hand is leading you, and accept the anxiety of feeling yourself in suspense and incomplete. The posture is trust, patience, the acceptance of slowness and incompleteness and process as the nature of the work, and this posture, so contrary to our impatient nature and our instant age, is essential to enduring the long slow work of God without abandoning it in frustration.

There is a deep consolation in the slow work of God for anyone who feels they are not growing, not changing, not becoming the person they long to be, and I want to speak it, because this frustration is nearly universal among serious Christians. If God's work is slow, gradual, imperceptible in the moment and evident only over the long stretch, then your daily sense of not changing is not evidence that nothing is happening. It is exactly what the slow work of God feels like from the inside, the frustrating daily experience of a growth too slow and too gradual to perceive, that is real nonetheless, that is forming you nonetheless, that will be evident nonetheless over the long stretch of ordinary time. Your frustration with your slow growth is not evidence of failure. It is evidence that you are experiencing, from the inside, the slow work of God, which always feels like this, which always feels like not enough, which is always imperceptible in the moment and always real over the long stretch. Take heart. The slowness you feel is the slowness of living growth, and living growth is exactly what God is working in you, slowly, gradually, faithfully, over the long stretch of your ordinary life.

The slow work of God connects to everything this book has said about the ordinary, because the slow work happens precisely in the ordinary, in the long stretch of ordinary days, through the ordinary practices and the ordinary faithfulness and the ordinary means of grace. God does not form us suddenly in dramatic moments but slowly through the ordinary faithfulness of ordinary days, the ordinary practices repeated over the long stretch, the ordinary means of grace received again and again, the ordinary obedience sustained through the long ordinary time. The slow work of God is an ordinary work, happening in the ordinary, through the ordinary, over the long stretch of ordinary time, imperceptible in the ordinary moment and evident only over the ordinary years, and it is the actual way that God actually

forms the actual soul of the actual ordinary Christian, not in a sudden dramatic transformation but in the slow ordinary work of ordinary formation through ordinary faithfulness over the long ordinary stretch of an ordinary life.

So trust in the slow work of God, and let go of the impatience that demands a sudden transformation and reads the slowness as failure. Accept that your growth will be slow, gradual, imperceptible in the moment, a slow work rather than a sudden event, because slow is how living things grow and slow is how God forms a soul. Do not abandon the ordinary faithfulness and the ordinary practices and the ordinary means of grace because you cannot feel them working, because the slow work is happening beneath your perception, in the long stretch of ordinary time, forming you gradually into something more like Christ even though it feels, day to day, like nothing at all. Trust the slow work. Endure the slow work. Give yourself to the slow work, in the ordinary faithfulness of ordinary days, in the confidence that God's hand is leading you, that his slow work is real, that the growth too slow to feel is happening nonetheless, and that over the long stretch of your ordinary life the slow work of God will have formed you, imperceptibly and surely, into the person he is patiently, slowly, faithfully making you, in the ordinary, over time, which is the only way that living things have ever grown.

Chapter Thirty-Two: The Body of Others and the Ordinary Care

Most love is not a feeling. It is a casserole, a ride to the appointment, a presence in the room, the ordinary care that shows up when the drama is over and the need remains.

I want to talk about the ordinary care that people give to one another, the casseroles and the rides and the sitting with, the ordinary practical love that shows up not in the dramatic crisis but in the long ordinary aftermath, when the drama is over and the need remains, and everyone else has gone home. Because this ordinary care is, I have come to believe, one of the truest forms of love there is, and one of the most overlooked, and one of the most Christlike, and it belongs at the heart of a book about finding God in the ordinary, because it is love in its most ordinary and most incarnate form, love that has hands and feet and shows up and does the ordinary practical thing that the drama-loving world overlooks.

Consider what happens when someone in a community suffers a great loss, a death, a diagnosis, a crisis. In the immediate drama, everyone rushes in. There is a flurry of attention, of sympathy, of presence, a great outpouring in the dramatic moment of the crisis. And then the drama passes, as drama always does, and everyone goes home, and the crowd disperses, and the sufferer is left alone with the ongoing ordinary reality of the loss, the long aftermath that the drama-loving world finds far less compelling

than the dramatic moment of the crisis. And it is here, in the long ordinary aftermath, when the drama is over and the crowd is gone and the need remains, that the truest love shows up, the ordinary care that keeps showing up, week after week, in the long unglamorous aftermath, with the casserole and the ride and the ordinary practical presence, when everyone else has moved on to the next dramatic thing.

I have watched this in my congregation over many years, the difference between the drama-loving attention of the crisis and the ordinary faithful care of the long aftermath, and I have come to see that the ordinary care of the aftermath is the far truer and far rarer love. Anyone can show up for the drama of the crisis, in the flurry of sympathy and attention that the dramatic moment generates. It is a much rarer and truer love that keeps showing up in the long ordinary aftermath, that brings the casserole in the third month when everyone else has forgotten, that provides the ride to the ongoing appointments long after the crisis has ceased to be interesting, that sits with the sufferer in the ordinary loneliness of the long aftermath when the drama is over and the need remains. This ordinary care of the aftermath is the love that Jesus described, the love that visits the sick and the imprisoned not in the dramatic moment but in the ongoing ordinary reality of their need, the love that has hands and feet and shows up and keeps showing up in the ordinary long aftermath that the drama-loving world overlooks.

There is a deep incarnational theology in the ordinary practical care, and I want to name it, because we tend to spiritualize love in a way that removes it from the ordinary practical form that it actually takes. Love, in the Christian understanding, is not primarily a feeling but an action, not primarily an emotion but a practical care that takes ordinary bodily form, that has hands and

feet, that shows up and does the ordinary practical thing. The love of God itself took ordinary bodily form in the incarnation, in a God who did not merely feel love for us from a distance but came in the flesh and touched the sick and fed the hungry and washed the feet and did the ordinary practical acts of care that love actually takes. And our love, made in the image of this incarnate love, is meant to take the same ordinary practical bodily form, to show up in the flesh and do the ordinary practical thing, the casserole and the ride and the presence in the room, because love that remains a feeling and never takes ordinary practical form is not the love that Christ commanded or the love that Christ embodied.

I have to confess my own preference for the dramatic form of love over the ordinary practical form, because it is a preference I share with the whole drama-loving world. I would rather love in the grand gesture, the dramatic moment, the significant act, than in the ordinary practical care that keeps showing up in the long unglamorous aftermath. I would rather feel love than make a casserole. I would rather have the dramatic moment of sympathy in the crisis than the ordinary faithful presence in the long aftermath. And I have had to learn, slowly and against my drama-loving preference, that the ordinary practical care is the truer love, that the casserole in the third month is worth more than all the sympathy of the dramatic moment, that love takes ordinary practical bodily form or it is not the love that Christ commanded, and that the ordinary faithful care of the long aftermath, which I am so tempted to overlook, is one of the truest and most Christlike forms of love available to a human being.

The people who excel at this ordinary care are usually not the impressive or the eloquent but the ordinary faithful ones, and I have noticed this pattern with growing admiration over the years.

The people who bring the casseroles and provide the rides and sit with the suffering in the long aftermath are usually not the prominent people, the impressive people, the ones who command attention in the dramatic moment, but the quiet ordinary faithful ones who simply show up, again and again, in the long unglamorous aftermath, doing the ordinary practical thing that love actually takes. These are the ordinary saints of the ordinary care, the ones who have mastered the truest form of love, the ordinary practical care that keeps showing up, and they are, I am convinced, among the greatest lovers in the kingdom of God, though the drama-loving world overlooks them completely, because their love takes the ordinary practical form that the world finds far less compelling than the dramatic gesture.

There is a whole ministry available to anyone in the ordinary practical care, and it requires no special gifts, no eloquence, no impressive abilities, only the willingness to show up and do the ordinary practical thing that love takes. You do not have to be able to say the profound thing to the grieving person. You can simply bring the casserole, provide the ride, sit in the room, be the ordinary faithful presence in the long aftermath. This ordinary practical care is available to everyone, and it is one of the truest forms of love, and it is one of the primary ways that the love of God takes ordinary form in the ordinary world, through ordinary people doing the ordinary practical acts of care that show up when the drama is over and the need remains. The ministry of ordinary care is available to you, right now, in the ordinary practical acts of love that you can do for the ordinary people in ordinary need around you, the casserole and the ride and the presence, the ordinary practical love that has hands and feet and shows up.

So take up the ordinary practical care, and do not despise it as a

lesser form of love than the dramatic gesture, because it is a truer form, the form that love actually takes, the form that Christ embodied, the form that shows up in the long ordinary aftermath when the drama is over and the need remains. Bring the casserole. Provide the ride. Sit in the room. Be the ordinary faithful presence in the long aftermath of someone's suffering, when everyone else has gone home and moved on to the next dramatic thing. Let your love take ordinary practical bodily form, with hands and feet, showing up and doing the ordinary practical thing, because that is what love is, not a feeling but a casserole, not an emotion but a ride to the appointment, not a sentiment but a presence in the room, the ordinary incarnate care that is one of the truest and most Christlike forms of love available to a human being, and that is desperately needed in a drama-loving world that rushes to the crisis and abandons the aftermath, where the ordinary need remains, and waits, for the ordinary faithful love that shows up.

Chapter Thirty-Three: When the Ordinary Is Hard

Not every ordinary day is a gentle one. Some ordinary days are a grind of suffering, and the God of the ordinary is there too, in the hard ordinary, most of all.

I have written a great deal in this book about finding God in the ordinary, and I have tried throughout to resist making the ordinary sound merely pleasant, but I want to devote a full chapter now to the hard ordinary, the ordinary that is not gentle, the ordinary day that is a grind of suffering rather than a quiet gift, because for many people, in many seasons, the ordinary is hard, and any theology of the ordinary that cannot speak to the hard ordinary is a theology for the comfortable only, and that is not the theology of the God who suffered. The ordinary is not always gentle. Some ordinary days are a long grind of chronic pain, of grinding poverty, of daily anxiety, of the ordinary suffering that does not make a dramatic crisis but simply goes on, day after ordinary day, an ordinary suffering that is all the harder for being ordinary, for having no drama to dignify it, for being simply the ordinary hard reality of an ordinary hard life.

I think of the people I have pastored through the hard ordinary, and I do not want to romanticize their suffering or pretend it was a gentle gift. The woman with chronic pain that never lets up, whose ordinary days are a grind of enduring an ordinary suffering that has no end and no drama and no relief, just the ordinary daily reality of pain. The family grinding through

ordinary poverty, whose ordinary days are a constant anxious arithmetic of not enough, an ordinary suffering that never rises to a dramatic crisis but simply goes on, the ordinary hard reality of not having enough, day after ordinary day. The person grinding through ordinary depression, whose ordinary days are a heavy fog, an ordinary suffering of the spirit that has no drama and no clear cause and no easy end, just the ordinary daily weight of it. For these people, and there are so many of them, the ordinary is hard, and the theology of the ordinary must be able to speak to the hard ordinary or it is worthless.

And here is what I believe, and I believe it precisely because of the cross, that the God of the ordinary is present in the hard ordinary most of all, that the ordinary suffering, far from being the place of God's absence, is the very place of his deepest presence, because the God we worship is a God who suffered, who entered the hard ordinary himself, who knows the ordinary suffering from the inside. The cross is not a dramatic exception to the ordinary but the ultimate entering of God into the hard ordinary of human suffering, the God who did not remain above the suffering in dramatic glory but came down into the ordinary hard reality of pain and loss and abandonment, and who is therefore present, as no distant God could be, in the hard ordinary of human suffering, present in the chronic pain and the grinding poverty and the heavy depression, present in the ordinary suffering from the inside, as one who has been there, who knows it, who entered it, who suffers with us in the hard ordinary that he made his own.

There is a mystery here that I do not fully understand and will not pretend to explain away, the mystery of the presence of God in suffering, of the God who does not remove the hard ordinary but enters it, who does not always end the ordinary suffering but

is present within it, who meets the sufferer not by taking away the hard ordinary but by being present in it, alongside, within, as one who suffers too. This is not an answer to the problem of suffering, and I am suspicious of the neat answers, the dramatic explanations, the tidy theodicies that try to make the hard ordinary make sense. The hard ordinary often does not make sense, and the sufferer does not usually need an explanation so much as a presence, and what the God of the ordinary offers in the hard ordinary is not primarily an explanation but a presence, the presence of the God who suffered, who is with the sufferer in the hard ordinary, who does not stand outside the suffering explaining it but stands inside it suffering too.

I have found, in my own smaller sufferings and in accompanying others through their larger ones, that the presence of God in the hard ordinary is real but often quiet, not the dramatic deliverance we cry out for but the quiet ordinary presence that sustains, that holds, that keeps the sufferer going through the hard ordinary day, that is felt not as a dramatic rescue but as an ordinary strength to endure, a quiet ordinary grace sufficient for the hard ordinary day. My grace is sufficient for you, God said to Paul in his ongoing ordinary suffering, the thorn that God did not remove, and the grace was not a dramatic deliverance but an ordinary sufficiency, a quiet ordinary grace that was enough for the hard ordinary day, that sustained Paul in the ongoing ordinary suffering that God chose not to end. And this is often the shape of God's presence in the hard ordinary, not the dramatic deliverance but the ordinary sufficiency, the quiet grace that is enough for today, the ordinary strength to endure the hard ordinary day, given not once in a dramatic rescue but daily, ordinarily, as the sufficient grace for the hard ordinary that God has not removed but has entered and is present within.

I want to speak directly to the person in the hard ordinary, because the comfortable theology of the ordinary can feel like a mockery to the person whose ordinary is a grind of suffering, and I do not want to add to your burden with a cheerful spirituality that does not know your pain. If your ordinary is hard, if your ordinary days are a grind of chronic pain or grinding poverty or heavy depression or ordinary suffering that has no drama and no end, I do not have an explanation for you, and I will not insult you with one. But I do have this, which I believe with my whole heart, that the God of the ordinary is with you in the hard ordinary, present in the suffering as one who suffered, near to you in the ordinary pain as one who entered ordinary pain himself, and that his grace, though it may not remove the hard ordinary, is sufficient for it, an ordinary sufficient grace for the hard ordinary day, given daily, quietly, enough for today, from a God who is not distant from your hard ordinary but present within it, suffering with you, sustaining you, near.

The hard ordinary is also, and I say this carefully, a place of a peculiar depth of formation, though I would never say this to justify the suffering or pretend it is good in itself. But it is true, and the witnesses attest it, that the hard ordinary, endured with God, forms a depth in the soul that the comfortable ordinary rarely reaches, that the people who have been through the hard ordinary and found God present in it often have a depth, a compassion, a groundedness, a nearness to God that the comfortable have not attained. This does not justify the suffering, and I will not use it to explain away the hard ordinary. But it is a grace within the suffering, a way that God brings depth out of the hard ordinary, forms the soul through the ordinary suffering that he did not will but is present within, so that the hard ordinary, terrible as it is, is not without a strange fruit, a depth of

soul and a nearness to God that is one of the mysterious graces of the hard ordinary endured with the God who suffers alongside.

So if your ordinary is hard, know that the God of the ordinary is with you in the hard ordinary most of all, present in the suffering as one who suffered, near in the ordinary pain as one who entered it, sustaining you with an ordinary sufficient grace that is enough for the hard ordinary day. Do not believe that the hardness of your ordinary is a sign of God's absence, because the cross tells us the opposite, that God is most present in the hard ordinary of human suffering, that he entered it himself, that he is with the sufferer in the hard ordinary as nowhere else. The God of the ordinary is not only the God of the gentle ordinary, the quiet gift, the pleasant day. He is the God of the hard ordinary too, most of all, present in the grind of suffering, near to the broken, with the sufferer in the hard ordinary that he made his own, and his grace, though it may not remove the hardness, is sufficient for it, an ordinary sufficient grace for the hard ordinary day, from a God who suffered, and who is with you, in the hard ordinary, now.

Chapter Thirty-Four: The Ordinary Word and the Ordinary Prayer

We think prayer must be eloquent to be heard, and God, who hears the groan and the sigh, keeps waiting for us to stop performing and simply speak.

I want to write about prayer once more, but specifically about the ordinariness of prayer, the plain ordinary talking to God that we so often complicate into something more impressive and more difficult than it needs to be. Because we have inherited, most of us, a sense that prayer must be eloquent to be heard, that it requires special language, special posture, special conditions, a special spiritual state, and this sense has made prayer harder than it is and rarer than it should be, has turned an ordinary conversation into an intimidating performance, has made us feel that our ordinary halting inarticulate attempts at prayer are somehow not real prayer, not good enough, not the kind of prayer that God wants to hear. And I want to say, as plainly as I can, that this is a lie, that prayer is the most ordinary thing in the world, the plain ordinary talking to God that requires no eloquence and no special conditions, and that God hears the ordinary halting inarticulate prayer as readily as the most eloquent, more readily perhaps, because it is more honest.

Consider how ordinary the prayers of the Bible actually are, once you strip away the reverent familiarity that has made them sound formal. The psalms, which are the prayer book of the Scriptures, are full of the most ordinary human speech, complaint and anger

and confusion and ordinary need, the psalmist telling God plainly how hard his ordinary life is, how long the ordinary suffering has gone on, how ordinary and overwhelming his ordinary troubles are. They are not eloquent performances of piety. They are ordinary honest human speech directed to God, the plain ordinary talking of ordinary people about their ordinary lives, and God received them, preserved them, made them the prayer book of his people, precisely because they are so ordinary and so honest, the real ordinary speech of real ordinary people, not the eloquent performance we imagine prayer must be but the plain ordinary honest talking to God that prayer actually is.

The Scriptures tell us something remarkable about prayer that should release us forever from the burden of eloquence, which is that we do not even know how to pray as we ought, and that the Spirit himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words. Read that. The Spirit prays through us in groanings too deep for words, which means that the deepest prayer is not eloquent at all, is not even articulate, is the ordinary wordless groan of ordinary human need, taken up by the Spirit and carried to God. This means that your ordinary inarticulate prayer, your halting speech, your wordless sigh, your groan that cannot find words, is not a failure of prayer but is prayer at its deepest, the ordinary groan that the Spirit himself takes up and carries to the Father. You do not have to be eloquent. You do not even have to find the words. The ordinary groan is enough, is heard, is carried by the Spirit to the God who hears the ordinary wordless prayer as readily as any eloquent one.

I have to confess that I, a pastor who prays publicly and is expected to pray well, have often found my own private prayer to be the most ordinary and halting and inarticulate thing, and that I have sometimes felt ashamed of it, felt that my private prayer

should be more like my public prayer, more eloquent, more impressive, more like the performance that prayer has become in my professional life. And I have had to learn, slowly, that my ordinary halting private prayer, the plain ordinary talking to God about my ordinary life and my ordinary troubles and my ordinary needs, is more real, more honest, more truly prayer, than the eloquent public performance, and that God prefers the ordinary honest halting prayer to the eloquent performance, hears it more readily, receives it more gladly, because it is the real ordinary speech of a real ordinary person rather than the polished performance of a professional. The recovery of ordinary prayer, the plain honest halting talking to God, has been one of the quiet graces of my ordinary life, a release from the burden of eloquence, a return to the ordinary conversation that prayer was always meant to be.

There is a place for the great formal prayers, the written prayers of the tradition, the eloquent prayers of the liturgy, and I do not want to dismiss them, because they too are a gift, a way of praying with words we could not have found ourselves, a joining of our ordinary prayer to the great prayer of the whole church across the ages. But even these great formal prayers are meant to become ordinary, to be prayed so often that they become the ordinary furniture of the praying heart, the ordinary words that rise to the lips in the ordinary moments of need, the Lord's Prayer prayed so many ordinary times that it becomes an ordinary reflex of the soul. The great prayers and the ordinary halting prayers are not enemies. They are both prayer, and they both become, in the praying life, ordinary, the ordinary formal words and the ordinary halting words alike woven into the ordinary daily conversation with God that is the ordinary praying life of the ordinary Christian.

The ordinary practice of prayer, like all the ordinary practices, works by repetition, by the ordinary daily returning to God in prayer, the ordinary daily conversation carried on in the ordinary moments, the ordinary halting speech and the ordinary formal words and the ordinary wordless groans, day after ordinary day, until prayer becomes not a special event requiring special conditions but the ordinary atmosphere of an ordinary life lived in the presence of God. This is what Brother Lawrence achieved, the making of prayer into the ordinary atmosphere of the ordinary day, the ordinary constant turning to God in the ordinary moments, so that prayer was no longer a special thing done at special times but the ordinary continuous conversation that ran through his ordinary day like an underground stream. And this is available to any ordinary Christian, not through eloquence or special conditions but through the ordinary daily practice of ordinary prayer, the plain ordinary talking to God repeated so often in the ordinary moments that it becomes the ordinary atmosphere of an ordinary life lived in the presence of God.

Let me speak to the person who feels they cannot pray, who has given up on prayer because their prayer feels so ordinary and halting and inarticulate that they doubt it is real prayer at all, because I have been that person and I suspect you have too. Your ordinary halting prayer is real prayer. Your inarticulate sigh is heard. Your wordless groan is taken up by the Spirit and carried to God. You do not need to be eloquent. You do not need special words or special conditions or a special spiritual state. You need only to talk to God, plainly, ordinarily, honestly, about your ordinary life, and to keep doing it, day after ordinary day, in the ordinary moments, until the ordinary conversation becomes the ordinary atmosphere of your ordinary life. Prayer is the most ordinary thing in the world, available to you right now, in the

ordinary moment you are in, requiring nothing but the willingness to speak, plainly and ordinarily, to the God who hears the ordinary groan as readily as the eloquent oration, and who has been waiting, all along, for you to stop performing and simply speak.

So pray ordinarily, and release yourself from the burden of eloquence that has made prayer harder than it is and rarer than it should be. Talk to God plainly, honestly, in your ordinary halting speech, about your ordinary life and your ordinary troubles and your ordinary needs, and know that this ordinary prayer is heard, is real, is prayer at its truest. Pray the ordinary formal prayers of the tradition until they become ordinary furniture of your heart. Pray the ordinary wordless groans that the Spirit takes up and carries to God. And do it daily, in the ordinary moments, until prayer becomes the ordinary atmosphere of your ordinary life, the ordinary continuous conversation with the God who is present in your ordinary life and who hears your ordinary prayer, not because it is eloquent but because it is honest, not because it is impressive but because it is yours, the ordinary prayer of an ordinary person, heard and received and answered by the God of the ordinary, who has been waiting all along for you to stop performing and simply speak.

Chapter Thirty-Five: The Ordinary Saint

There is no other kind of saint. Every saint who ever lived was an ordinary person who found God in an ordinary life and was faithful in it over a long time.

I want to reconsider the whole idea of the saint, because it is an idea that has been corrupted, in our imagination, into something spectacular and remote and inaccessible, a category of extraordinary spiritual heroes who lived dramatic lives of extraordinary holiness, and this corruption of the idea of the saint has done real damage, has made ordinary Christians believe that holiness is not for them, that the saints are a different kind of person, that the holy life is a spectacular life beyond the reach of ordinary people in ordinary circumstances. And I want to reclaim the ordinary saint, because I have come to believe that there is no other kind, that every saint who ever lived was an ordinary person who found God in an ordinary life and was faithful in it over a long time, and that the spectacular saint of our imagination is a distortion that has hidden from us the ordinary saints who are the real thing, and who are, in fact, everywhere.

Consider the actual saints of the tradition, once you strip away the legendary accretions and the spectacular haloes. Brother Lawrence was an ordinary man, a former soldier and footman, who worked in a kitchen and washed pots and found God in the ordinary work over an ordinary lifetime. There was nothing

spectacular about him. He was an ordinary person who practiced an ordinary presence of God in an ordinary life, and that is what made him a saint, not any spectacular achievement but the ordinary faithfulness that found God in the ordinary. The saints, the real ones, are almost all like this, ordinary people in ordinary circumstances who were faithful over a long time, who found God in the ordinary, who practiced an ordinary holiness in an ordinary life, and whose sanctity was not a spectacular exception to ordinary life but the fruit of ordinary faithfulness within it. The spectacular saint is largely a legend. The ordinary saint is the reality.

I have known ordinary saints, and I want to testify to them, because they are the real evidence that ordinary holiness is possible and that the ordinary saint is the real thing. I have already mentioned some of them, the elderly woman faithful in her pew for decades, the man of no eloquence whose ordinary practical love taught me the gospel, the quiet caregivers and the ordinary faithful ones. These were saints, real saints, and there was nothing spectacular about any of them. They were ordinary people who found God in ordinary lives and were faithful over a long time, and their sanctity, real and evident and formative, was the fruit of ordinary faithfulness in ordinary circumstances, not of any spectacular achievement or dramatic experience. They were ordinary saints, the only kind there is, and they were everywhere, hidden in plain sight in the ordinary congregation, invisible to a church culture that looks for the spectacular and precious beyond measure to a God who makes his saints out of ordinary people in ordinary lives.

The making of an ordinary saint follows the pattern that this whole book has described, the pattern of ordinary faithfulness over a long time, the ordinary practices repeated, the ordinary

means of grace received, the ordinary obedience sustained, the ordinary presence of God practiced, the long obedience in the same direction walked step by ordinary step over a lifetime. There is no shortcut to sainthood, no spectacular experience that produces a saint, no dramatic moment of transformation that makes an ordinary person holy all at once. The saint is made slowly, ordinarily, through the long faithfulness of ordinary days, the ordinary practices and the ordinary obedience and the ordinary presence of God practiced over a lifetime, until the ordinary person has been slowly formed, by the slow work of God, into an ordinary saint. The making of a saint is an ordinary work, a slow work, a work accomplished in the ordinary through ordinary faithfulness over the long ordinary stretch of an ordinary life, and it is available to any ordinary Christian who will give themselves to the ordinary faithfulness through which saints are made.

This means that sainthood, real holiness, is available to you, in your ordinary life, in your ordinary circumstances, and this is either the most encouraging or the most demanding thing in this book, and probably both. It is encouraging because it means you do not need a spectacular life or a dramatic experience or extraordinary circumstances to become a saint, that the ordinary life you actually have is exactly the material out of which saints are made, that the ordinary faithfulness available to you in your ordinary circumstances is the very path to the holiness you may have thought was beyond you. And it is demanding because it removes every excuse, because it means that the ordinariness of your life is no obstacle to your sanctity, that you cannot say you would be holy if only your circumstances were different, because the ordinary circumstances you actually have are precisely the circumstances in which ordinary saints have always been made, and the only question is whether you will give yourself to the

ordinary faithfulness through which the ordinary saint is formed.

I think about the great vision at the end of the Scriptures, the vision of the great multitude that no one could number, from every nation and tribe and people and language, standing before the throne, and I am struck that this great multitude of the redeemed is not a small elite of spectacular saints but an innumerable multitude of ordinary people, the vast ordinary company of the ordinary faithful across all the ages, ordinary people who found God in ordinary lives and were faithful over a long time, gathered at last into the great multitude that no one could number. The kingdom of God is populated not by a handful of spectacular saints but by an innumerable multitude of ordinary saints, ordinary faithful people from every ordinary circumstance, the vast ordinary company of the ordinary holy, and this is the company you are called to join, not by becoming a spectacular saint but by becoming an ordinary one, faithful in your ordinary life over a long time, one ordinary faithful soul added to the great ordinary multitude of the redeemed.

The ordinary saint does not usually know they are a saint, and this is one of the marks of the real thing as opposed to the spectacular counterfeit. The spectacular saint of the imagination is aware of their own holiness, conscious of their spiritual achievement, but the ordinary saint is usually unaware of their own sanctity, too busy with the ordinary faithfulness of the ordinary day to notice that they are becoming holy, too focused on the ordinary practices and the ordinary obedience and the ordinary care to be aware that the slow work of God is making them a saint. The ordinary saints I have known would have been astonished to be called saints, would have protested that they were ordinary sinners doing their ordinary best, unaware that their ordinary faithfulness was the very substance of sanctity,

that they were being made, in their ordinary unawareness, into the ordinary saints they did not know they were becoming. This unawareness is itself a mark of the real ordinary saint, whose sanctity is not a self-conscious achievement but the unnoticed fruit of ordinary faithfulness over a long time.

So become an ordinary saint, which is the only kind there is, by giving yourself to the ordinary faithfulness through which ordinary saints are made, in your ordinary life, in your ordinary circumstances, over the long ordinary stretch of an ordinary lifetime. Do not wait for spectacular circumstances or dramatic experiences to begin the holy life, because the holy life is made in the ordinary, through ordinary faithfulness, in the ordinary circumstances you already have. Practice the ordinary presence of God. Receive the ordinary means of grace. Walk the long ordinary obedience in the same direction. Do the ordinary small things with great love. Be faithful in the ordinary, over a long time, and let the slow work of God make you, in your ordinary unawareness, into an ordinary saint, one more ordinary faithful soul added to the great innumerable multitude of the ordinary holy, who found God in ordinary lives and were faithful over a long time, and who stand at last before the throne, the vast ordinary company of the redeemed, ordinary saints all, made holy not by spectacular achievement but by ordinary faithfulness, in the ordinary lives they actually had.